

BEYOND
THE
MAP'S
EDGE

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POSEY



Beyond the Map's Edge™

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Dedication

For you who cradled my vulnerable moments as if they were
your own treasures— whose soul caught my unspoken tales
and answered with unfaltering faith.

In darkest hours, you were moonlight that smoothed my
sharpest edges, a tender breath of hope whispering, “You are
enough.”

With eyes that gazed beyond my fears to see the light I
couldn't find: thank you for being my north star.



Photo by Dave Clawson

Contents

Dedication

Prologue

Introduction

Acknowledgments

Mom's House

Dad's House

The Fitzwaters

Poseys on the Road

Posey Land

The Postal Pilgrimage

The Conquistador Conquest

The Bait Bonanza

The Gracie Grail

The Concrete Kiss

The Treasure Tempest

The Peak Pursuit
The Digging Debacle
The Tour Trap
The Paternal Ploy
Rearview Riches
The Bandit Banquet
Reluctant Roommates
The Lost Liberators
The Tender Tornado
The Weepul Winners
The Minority Mix-up
The Midnight Menace
The Aft Assault
The Hatchback Hostage
The Friendly Follies
The Beano Betrayal
Trailside Troubles
The Stormy Stakeout
The Rod Race
The Living Legend
The Cable Conundrum
The Obsession's Oath
Grandma's Hands
The Bronze Beast
The Home Depot Hound
The Curious Confluence

The Sleep Study
The Derailed Duo
The Snout Scout
The Jinxed Joint
The Grizzly Gathering
The Treasure Trail
The Probability Paradox
The Redington Requiem
The Treasure
The Dubious Decision
The Mountain Memory

The Legal Lowdown

Prologue

West Yellowstone—August 2018

Sweat traced familiar paths down my back as I marked another section of forest on my GPS. Grid searching Nine Mile Hole. Again. Six years had changed me. The optimistic amateur who started this journey in 2012 was gone, replaced by someone harder, someone shaped by relentless pursuit.

“Justin!” Brandon’s voice crackled through the walkie-talkie. “Found anything?”

“Just mosquitoes and regret,” I replied, marking another empty square on my grid. But I kept going. Because that’s what obsession does to you. It makes you search the same ground, hoping for different results.

This particular descent into treasure-hunting madness began a

few days earlier when my brother Brandon rolled into town. I'd carved out a week's vacation, temporarily trading meetings for treasure maps, ready to indulge what had become my magnificent obsession.



My truck evolved in response to the challenges I faced while searching. This appears to be version 2.0 of the vehicle I dubbed “The Beast.” | Photo by Mike Key

Brandon arrived wearing the hopeful expression of someone expecting to find a camping spot in Yellowstone. In summer. On a weekend. Oh, Brandon, sweet, optimistic Brandon.

That night, pine smoke drifted through the open window of the

Airstream as I spread my maps across the dinette. Six years of theories marked in red and black, my handwriting growing smaller and more cramped as space ran out. Brandon's beer bottle clinked against the table as he leaned over my shoulder.

"Iron Springs tomorrow," I said, tracing the route with my finger. "I've got a new theory about—"

"Of course you do." Brandon's fingertips brushed the paper, following the paths we'd walked together. The lamp caught the silver starting to thread through his beard as he bent closer, eyes moving methodically across each annotation. A muscle in his jaw tightened, then relaxed. "You know what's funny? This treasure hunt of yours...we've spent more time together in the past six years than we had since we were kids."

He was right. Many of the Xs on these maps marked not just a search location, but another day with my brother in the wild. I looked up to tell him that, but his eyes were fixed on the maps, his reflection in the window glass overlaying the dark pines beyond.

That August week would be our last treasure hunt together. Brandon knew that when he arrived. I was too busy planning our next search to notice he was saying goodbye.

Introduction

Some kids dream of becoming astronauts or rock stars. I dreamed of finding a billion dollars of hidden gold in a New Mexico mountain called Victorio Peak. While other parents were reading bedtime stories about talking animals, mine were sharing tales of secret tunnels and stolen treasure. In retrospect, this explains a lot about how I turned out.

That's how I ended up spending a decade hunting for a different treasure, this one hidden by an eccentric art dealer named Forrest Fenn. While most treasure hunters stuck to metal detectors and shovels, I went slightly overboard—training a dog to sniff bronze and writing algorithms to analyze facial micro-expressions in hundreds of hours of video interviews. Mornings, evenings, weekends—if I wasn't in the wilderness getting chased by bears, I was at home analyzing clues like a dedicated cold case detective.

Somewhere between the bear encounters and the time my bronze-sniffing dog rolled in a dead porcupine, I managed to become a subject of Netflix's *Gold & Greed: The Hunt for Fenn's Treasure* series. And eventually, through a twist that would have seemed impossible on day one of my search, I ended up owning the very treasure I'd spent 780 days trying to find.

If you've seen the series, you know the exact flavor of questionable life choices I'm serving up. If not—well, you might want to pause here and watch it first. Without that context, what follows will make about as much sense as, well, a grown man hunting for hidden treasure in a national park for nearly a decade. But here's the irony—I'm writing blind. As these words take shape, I have no idea what footage will make the final cut, what stories will survive the editor's blade. So please forgive any echoes between screen and page as we press on.

Here's what I learned after a decade of treasure hunting: it's not about the gold. It's about understanding the mind of the person who hid it—their story, their obsessions, the places that shaped them. This memoir isn't just about my search for Fenn's treasure. It's about growing up in the '80s and '90s with a family who thought treasure hunting was perfectly normal dinner conversation. It's about the spectacular failures and occasional moments of dumb luck that led me here.

And yes, it's about a new treasure I've hidden—sixty pounds of

history spanning from ancient Lydia to outer space, with a few pieces from Fenn's original cache serving as a bridge between hunts. Because sometimes the best way to close one chapter is to write a whole new book of riddles.

You might find clues to my treasure scattered through these pages. You might just find a story about a kid who never quite grew out of his treasure-hunting dreams. Either way, what you won't get is some ghostwritten memoir where every failure leads to a perfect lesson. What you will get is an obsession laid bare—complete with bear encounters, algorithm failures, and one very patient dog. And Netflix's *Gold & Greed: The Hunt for Fenn's Treasure* series? I left some hints there, too.

It's waiting just beyond your comfort zone. Beyond your map's edge.



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Acknowledgments

A treasure hunter learns early that the most valuable discoveries often come from unexpected sources. This book—equal parts memoir, confession, and treasure map—owes its existence to many such discoveries and the people behind them.

First, to Matt DeMoss, who understood this book long before I did. You saw the story I was trying to tell when I was still lost in the details of the one I thought I should tell. Your brutal honesty stripped away my carefully constructed defenses, pushed past my attachments, and found the heart of what mattered. This book exists because you weren't afraid to tell me difficult truths, even when I resisted hearing them.

To Benjamin Wallace for properly introducing the treasure hunt to the world.

To Jared, Katherine, Dave, Michal, Sam, and the rest of the crew at

Nomadica Films, Union Editorial, and Gumstreet Productions: you brought the hunt for Fenn's treasure to the screen with the responsibility and nuance it deserved. Through countless hours of footage and complex storylines, you found the heart of what drives someone to search for hidden treasure. The Netflix series *Gold & Greed: The Hunt for Fenn's Treasure* exists because you understood that this story needed to be told right.



Photo by Dave Clawson

To my family, who made treasure hunting feel as natural as breathing: you never once suggested I should dream smaller dreams. Our dinner table became a war room of possibilities, where tales of

Victorio Peak mingled with homework and curfew negotiations. This book began decades ago, between bites of meatloaf and wild theories about hidden Spanish gold.

And to those close to me I haven't named: your absence from these pages is deliberate. Having witnessed the intense—and sometimes unsettling—reactions that treasure hunts can provoke, I've chosen to protect you through your anonymity. You stood beside me through bear encounters and dead ends, through late-night research sessions and endless theorizing. You answered midnight phone calls about coded messages and listened to endless theories without complaint. Your names may not appear here, but your fingerprints are on every page. In launching a new treasure hunt, the best gift I can give you is your privacy.

Finally, to Forrest Fenn, whose treasure chest started as my destination but became my launching point: your hunt taught me that the best treasures are the ones that inspire new searches, new stories, new obsessions.

To future hunters who hold this book: may you find what you're looking for, even if it's not what you expected to find. The best treasures, after all, often hide in plain sight—sometimes between the lines of an acknowledgments page.

Mom's House

Life has a funny way of planting you where you need to grow. Our brick house lay at the end of a dirt road on the outskirts of Tucson, watched over by the stoic sentinels of Saguaro National Park East. Well, back then it was Saguaro National Monument. What's the difference anyway?

When I was four, just as I was mastering the art of shoelace-tying and sandbox diplomacy, my parents decided to call it quits. The upside: my brother Brandon and I essentially won the holiday lottery: two Christmases, two birthdays, two chances to perfect our performances of surprised delight at receiving gifts we'd specifically requested. Brandon, three years my junior, was my constant shadow during those shifting times. Where I went, he went—my little brother finding his footing by following in my footsteps. A few years later, when Mom remarried, our duo expanded to include my

brother Mack. Three boys: one shared appetite for mischief.

My mother's house became ground zero for her unique approach to post-divorce coping. While other divorced mothers might have joined book clubs or taken up yoga, Mom recreated the entire biblical Noah story in our backyard, accumulating a vast array of barnyard animals and household pets. We had horses, mules, donkeys, chickens, pigs, snakes, dogs, cats, rats (the "fancy" kind, though I never saw one wearing a tie), ferrets, and a chinchilla whose hair outshone every member of our immediate family. Mom always had a deep bond with animals. Visitors didn't realize that they stood in the presence of rodeo royalty. My mother had dominated Montana's barrel racing circuit in her youth, collecting championship buckles like other girls collected charm bracelets. She and her horse Pepper moved like ballet dancers, tearing through arena courses so precisely calculated you'd think she had a protractor in her stirrups. That same wild precision infected our childhood games. Hide-and-seek at our house wasn't just "you hide and I'll look for you"; it was a tactical operation that sometimes required bribing a chicken to keep your location secret. Our property, now transformed into a petting zoo designed by someone with dubious insurance coverage, became our playground.



Left to Right: Shane, Chipper, Mom, and Pepper. Dillon, Montana.

My greatest ally in these tactical operations was a quarter horse named Meghan. While my brothers relied on mundane hiding spots like closets or under beds, I developed a technique I called “hiding in plain sight while dangling precariously from a horse’s neck.” I’d

hang off Meghan's side like a circus performer, sliding left to right as seekers passed by, never knowing the best hiding spot swayed before them, alongside a living, breathing lookout tower.



My eventual discovery would trigger what my family called *The Laugh*—a sound that perfectly recreated Daffy Duck's signature breakdown, as if Warner Brothers had somehow encoded their intellectual property into my genetic makeup. This hereditary curse wouldn't win me any prom dates, but it did have the useful side effect of inducing immediate urinary urgency in my mother. She'd abandon the game and sprint for the bathroom, leaving me technically untagged and free to continue my equine-assisted concealment.

Speaking of hide-and-seek: there was what we called *The Great Gift Hunt*. As birthdays and Christmases approached, Brandon and I would seek out the location of our gifts prematurely—though my brother, ever the honorable one, would stop short of actually peeking once we found them. I had no such restraint. And my mother would come up with new hidden spots, turning holidays into a high-stakes game of cat and mouse. One year she decided the safest place for the stash was a tiny, locked compartment on our horse trailer. Mother clearly didn't know who she was dealing with. Within hours I had picked the lock and glimpsed my treasure trove of surprises.

When Barbara, my stepfather's sister, entered the arena, we played the classic "Can you guess what's inside?" Her eyes met mine with a challenge: "You're in the big leagues now, kid." I turned her gift in my hands, assessing every corner, every edge. A light shake and the subtle noise it made was all I needed.

"A model rocket!" I declared.

Barbara's eyes widened, mixing astonishment with defeat. She laughed it off and denied it vocally, but I knew—the crinkle of her eyes, that subtle tip of her head. I had won, and we both knew it.

Even mundane shopping trips became theaters of mischief. The women's section of Macy's transformed into our personal jungle, with clothing racks offering dense foliage of discounted polyester. My brothers, Brandon and Mack, turned these errands into

performance art, staging elaborate mannequin impersonations. They'd arrange themselves among the plastic models, faces frozen in a rictus of retail rhapsody, waiting to shock unsuspecting shoppers with their sudden animation. The reactions ran the gamut—from startled jumps to shocked screams, with a sprinkling of bemused chuckles. Our family excursions to the mall became legends, cautionary tales whispered among harried sales associates.



Mom fishing the river she loves the most—The Beaverhead.

I remember one particular birthday when Mother orchestrated a

treasure hunt that transformed our house into an explorer's paradise. A dozen parchment clues led my friends and me through a labyrinth of discovery. The final prize emerged like a long-lost artifact: a blue cardboard chest.

Oddly, I can't recall what was inside that chest. But I remember the surge of adrenaline. The fear of failure. The terror of being the kid who couldn't solve the puzzle. That same jolt powers everything. Clinging to Meghan's mane. Shaking presents like a tiny detective. My brothers in those department store dresses, frozen in fluorescent light. All of us fumbling in the dark. Kids of divorce. Kids with regular homes. Kids with menageries or white picket fences. None of it mattered. We were all searching for something we couldn't name. That's why we played hide and seek too long. Why every gift became a mystery. Every game an Olympic sport. Every mundane moment, theater. It was never about winning. Never about being found. Never even about the prize. My mother felt it, racing bareback through those Rocky Mountain arenas. My brothers knew it, holding their breath among mannequins, waiting for the punchline or the punishment.

It was about that perfect moment before discovery. When the present is still wrapped. When anything could be behind the next clue. When you're hidden but not yet seen. That exquisite tension between what is and what could be.

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Dad's House

Too much grit for Steinbeck, too much swagger for Hemingway, my father wasn't just larger than life; he was larger than fiction. He was a force of nature, shaped by the rugged landscapes of southern New Mexico, and something else, something that made him fill every space he entered until it couldn't hold him anymore.

Dad drove trains for the Southern Pacific Railroad, wrangling several-thousand-ton metal beasts with the same confidence he commanded dinner conversations. His hands, which looked like they had wrestled every piece of machinery in the American Southwest, were as comfortable tuning an engine as they were sautéing onions for his famous cowboy steak dinners.

I once saw him reassemble a 454 big block V8 from scratch in less than seven hours. The same night, he produced a bouillabaisse that would make Julia Child update *Mastering the Art of French Cooking*.

It was as if God had said, “Let’s make a man who can conduct both mechanical overhauls and culinary symphonies, and let’s give him enough of a god complex to make family dinners interesting.” (Though sometimes I wonder if God had anything to do with it.)

From quantum physics to the mating habits of Amazonian tree frogs, there seemed to be no subject beyond Dad’s grasp. His mind was a black hole for information—once something entered, it never escaped. I’m pretty sure he remembered every word he’d ever read, which made arguing with him about as productive as trying to win a footrace against a freight train.



Dad's insatiable curiosity was only matched by his love of adventure, a trait he was determined to instill in me from a young age. Despite long hours at work, he always found time to share his passions. This grand plan materialized in a collection of his old

adventure magazines from the 1960s and 70s with titles like *True West* and *Old Frontier*, plus a wobbling stack of dog-eared *Hardy Boys* books, which he presented with the solemnity of a knighthood. The pages were more yellow than white, the covers looked like they'd been through a war, and I was pretty sure one had doubled as a makeshift flyswatter. But to hear Dad tell it, these were the sacred texts of eternal youth. All I had to do was read them, and a life of boundless adventure would be mine. I thought I'd struck the mother lode.

Accordingly, I handled these treasures as if they were priceless artifacts fresh from an archaeological dig. The stories were all really fun, high adventure—and the interesting thing to my ten-year-old brain was that most of the lost treasures detailed in their pages were still open cases, even after all these years. I spent weeks in my room studying them like a detective working his first big case.

Not content with mere books and magazines, Dad also introduced me to the mysteries of Oak Island, a small patch of land that had been the site of countless treasure hunts and excavations. He'd spin tales of buried pirate gold, mysterious symbols carved into stone, and complex booby traps. I half expected him to pull out a shovel and suggest we start digging in the backyard, just in case some wayward pirate had gotten lost on his way to the Atlantic and decided to hide his treasure in the middle of a desert island. I *loved* the idea that some pirate had set a trap and that I could search for

the loot. I was determined to be the only kid to solve the age-old riddle.

Except there was one problem. Our family's globe of the world indicated Oak Island was in a strange land called "Nova Scotia." I never grasped how far away it was, but I schemed a hundred ways to get there. They were all ridiculous gambits my parents shut down—but I knew I could solve it if I could just get to Oak Island.

Each morning he wasn't commandeering trains, Dad performed his ritual of feeding the birds, a tradition I've continued at my own home. With a steaming mug of coffee in one hand and birdseed in the other, he welcomed the morning chorus as the world came alive.

On the rare morning when I managed to pry my eyelids open before noon (a feat that, in my teenage years, was about as common as a solar eclipse), I joined him in this spectacle of early-rising madness.

"Listen to that northern cardinal," he murmured. "Reminds me of a passage from Thoreau's *Walden*." Of course it did. Heaven forbid a bird should just be a bird in our backyard.

And without missing a beat, he recited: "The thrush alone declares the immortal wealth and vigor that is in the forest. Here is a poet indeed, who sings the beauty of the morning as much as the happiness of the bird."

I nodded sagely. It probably looked more like I was fighting off a narcoleptic episode. Here I was, at an hour when any respectable

teenager should still be in a coma-like slumber, listening to my father turn our backyard into a live-action mash-up of *National Geographic* and a nineteenth-century literature class.

“You know,” he said, setting down his mug with the gravitas of Moses about to part the Red Sea, “I’ve been thinking about this area of the backyard. What if we extended the house to have a nice, big family room here, and added columns out there with an overhang? The French doors would open about here,” he continued, striding about the yard in his robe like a movie director blocking an epic scene, pointing out landmarks that existed only in his mind.

I tried to understand, but in reality, I couldn’t envision it in the slightest. He was just pointing at random spots in our perfectly normal backyard. For all I knew, he could have been plotting landing sites for his secret alien allies. But I should have known better. In Dad’s world, today’s caffeine-fueled vision was tomorrow’s home improvement reality. Thus it was no surprise when, later that year, he transformed our backyard into exactly what he’d described.

Not content with merely altering the fabric of our home’s reality, he also decided to play God with the plant kingdom. He transformed an area of the back patio into an enclosed conservatory, a sort of Biosphere 3 that housed caladiums, bougainvillea, and fiddle-leaf figs—all sorts of exotic vegetation. Under his care, plants flourished like they were auditioning for a role in *Little Shop of Horrors*. I half expected to come home one day and find a venus

flytrap the size of a Volkswagen, asking to be fed.

When visitors came around, they'd step into Dad's horticultural wonderland and immediately slip into a state of disbelief. They'd look at the lush, vibrant greenery, then back at the arid wasteland that was the rest of our neighborhood, and their brains would short-circuit like a calculator asked to divide by zero.

"These can't be real," they'd declare with the conviction of flat-earthers at a globe convention. To them, the idea that my father could cultivate a tropical paradise in the middle of our decidedly untropical Tucson backyard was about as plausible as finding out your goldfish had learned to tap dance. Only after touching the supple leaves would they be forced to believe.



Recharging the batteries between dreams of epic discoveries.

Dad's sense of humor was a tightrope walk over a canyon of potential offense, performed without a net and with occasional fireworks shooting out of his pants. His wit could diffuse tension faster than a bomb squad on amphetamines, or create it just as quickly.

"Those who are easily offended should be offended more often," he'd say to me, flashing a smile that could charm the rattles off a snake. I once saw him reduce a PTA meeting to chaos with a single, perfectly timed quip about the principal's toupee and its

resemblance to a certain part of the male anatomy. Half the room was scandalized, the other half was in stitches. Dad just sat back, sipping his coffee, a maestro of mayhem in his element.

Dad approached humor like a mad scientist approaches genetic engineering—always pushing boundaries, occasionally creating monsters. But you had to give him this: it was never, ever boring.

The Fitzwaters

Each year, with the precision of Santa's elves, Grandpa Fitzwater would mail us a Christmas tree. Not just any tree, mind you, but a genuine noble fir from the northern Rockies, personally auditioned and cut by Grandpa. For us kids, this was better than any store-bought gift—a fragrant, sappy ambassador from the wilds of the north, complete with needles that would embed themselves in the carpet well into spring.

Grandpa Wayne Fitzwater, my mother's father, was our living link to the wild corners of the American Rockies. A retired fish and game warden, he made his home on the outskirts of Dillon, Montana, where Blacktail Deer Creek whispered stories through the willows. Dillon wasn't (and isn't) exactly a metropolis; but for Grandpa, it was the perfect base for a man as rugged as they come—enough to make Captain Woodrow F. Call envious.



Fish and Game Warden Fitzwater scanning the horizon through his ever-present binoculars. Grandpa never met a faraway view he didn't need to inspect closer.

Every winter, post-retirement, he'd hitch up his trailer and migrate to Tucson to escape Montana's bitter cold. He'd roll into town sometime in early January. Or late January. Or February. It would have been ill-advised to set your watch according to a man in his nineties who had the unrestrained spirit of a twenty-year-old, whose stories of wildlife escapades became our seasonal soundtrack.

It was during one of these trips south that Grandpa spotted a wheel merrily rolling down the highway. A collector of all things discarded—likely a habit formed during the Depression—he was naturally thrilled at this find. Picture his shock when he pulled over

in his trusty Jeep Wagoneer to discover this gleeful runaway wheel was a traitor from his own travel trailer! He stood there, slack-jawed, as it made a mad dash for liberty, hurtling down an embankment before taking a dramatic plunge into the Snake River. There it went, floating downstream, probably dreaming of a new life as a Ferris wheel.

Determined, he sprinted a quarter mile downstream, and at the river's edge, waded in, eyes on the prize. But it's prudent to note, Grandpa was no taller than a fifth grader. The wheel, with the force of a wrecking ball, slammed into him, cracking ribs and sending him into an unexpected nap on the water.



Floating along, unconscious on top of the wheel, it must have

been a sight to behold a mile downstream, where a couple of fishermen intervened. They rescued the pair, and Grandpa rolled his reclaimed wheel up to the highway and back to his vehicle. He mounted it back onto his trailer, and continued his odyssey to Tucson. He arrived more battered than an old suitcase, refusing any talk of doctors. He was a walking testament to a breed of human they just don't make anymore.

Back in Montana, Grandpa's world centered around Dillon, but his true stomping grounds stretched into the surrounding wilderness. Beaverhead-Deerlodge National Forest, in all its untamed glory, was a core part of his patrol area when he was a fish and game warden. The land here is steeped in history, like a tea bag that's been stewing for centuries. The Shoshone and Bannock tribes were the first to call it home, followed by Lewis and Clark and the Corps of Discovery, who slogged through the Beaverhead Valley in 1805. Then came Sheriff Henry Plummer, who in 1863 perfected what could only be called the original side hustle. By day, he polished his badge and pretended to care about justice, while by night, he led a gang of thieves called "The Innocents." They specialized in relieving gold shipments of their burden along mountain trails that were already treacherous enough without the added excitement of armed robbery. While Plummer served as sheriff in nearby Dillon, his true legacy would play out in Bannack, the gold rush town where his double life ultimately unraveled. Now

Bannack stands empty, its buildings slouching into the Montana soil. Local lore suggests there are millions in precious metal still hidden in those hills.

To the north lies Coolidge, one of Montana's last gold boom towns. It was a place where fortunes were made and lost faster than you could say "fool's gold." What remains is a collection of crumbling buildings, whispering tales of a bygone era. You can practically hear the echoes of saloon laughter and the clang of pickaxes against rock. It's enough to make you want to poke about, just in case someone left a few gold nuggets lying around.

My brothers and I spent countless hours traipsing through its crumbling structures, armed with more imagination than common sense. We'd return home covered in dust, our pockets jingling with what we swore was gold but always turned out to be pyrite or just plain old rocks. Mom would shake her head, muttering something about "raising a bunch of prospectors," while Grandpa would grin and ask if we'd struck it rich yet. These were his haunts, after all—places he'd patrolled as a game warden, where his own stories had unfolded decades before ours.

Our real treasures were found in Crystal Park, where we learned to hear and understand the rhythm of the land. We'd arrive after each downpour when the soil, newly washed, revealed its bounty. The smell of pine and wet granite mingled in the air as we unearthed fairy dust shards and crystal chunks that felt like the earth's very

heart. Our pockets, backpacks, even socks brimmed with glittering prizes. We were magpies, drawn to the sparkle, our eyes mirroring the crystals' gleam.

Back at Grandpa's place, Blacktail Deer Creek became my personal classroom in the art of patience. Those fishing waters taught me more about life than any textbook could—about waiting, about hope, about the quiet thrill of possibility. Each cast was a story waiting to be told, each ripple a whispered secret from the depths.



The years I spent hiking and fishing the Montana and Wyoming creeks, lakes, and rivers are tucked away in my memory like pressed wildflowers in an old book. I can still feel the chill of the mountain air on my skin, the tug of a trout on the line as I cast into the Big Hole's crystal waters, the satisfying crunch of pine needles underfoot along the Jefferson's winding banks. And it wasn't just

about the fish, though God knows I loved reeling in those slippery little suckers. It was about the stories that whispered through the trees, the ghosts of prospectors and pioneers who walked those same paths before me.

Now, decades later, when that familiar scent of pine needles drifts up from our Christmas tree, I'm transported back to those northern summers. Back to Grandpa's world of endless possibility, where every bend in the creek held promise, and every trail led to adventure. His annual migrations may have given us a rhythm to live by, but it was those northern moments that gave us something far more precious: a legacy of wild places and wilder stories, each one as true as the north star and twice as bright.

Poseys on the Road

Several times a year, Dad would declare it was time for a pilgrimage to Alamogordo to visit the grandparents.



Nature showing off over the Sacramento Mountains—as seen from my grandparents’ perfect front-row view.

We'd often hit the road after he returned from work, regardless of the hour. The concept of "departure time" in our household was less a temporal designation and more a philosophical state of being. We operated on what I'd come to think of as "Dad Standard Time," a curious phenomenon where "we're leaving now" could mean anything from "grab your shoes" to "the day after tomorrow it is." The only certainty was that we would depart at precisely the wrong hour according to any reasonable person.

These journeys always began with a ritual as sacred as any ancient ceremony: The Loading of the Truck. Dad's venerable one-ton dually pickup was less a vehicle and more a mobile fortress. It had enough metal to build a submarine and, I suspect, roughly the same fuel efficiency. The interior possessed that distinct perfume of leather, coffee, and what I can only describe as "essence of Dad"—a bouquet of Old Spice, determination, and train diesel fumes.

My brother Brandon and I would curl up like contortionists in the floorboards, a position that would horrify modern safety experts but which we considered our natural habitat. We'd fashion nests from old blankets and jackets, creating what we imagined to be the height of mobile luxury. The truck's engine hummed beneath us like an industrial lullaby, its mechanical heartbeat marking time as we crossed Texas Canyon.

Entertainment in those pre-gizmo days required a level of creativity that today's children would find exhausting. We invented

elaborate games like “Count the Road Kill” and “Guess What Dad’s Muttering About,” which usually involved either gas prices or other drivers’ infractions on the freeway. Brandon once maintained a perfect score in “slug bug” for three hours straight, primarily because it was pitch black and none of us could verify his claims.

For a reason shrouded in mystery, Dad didn’t trust the speedometer. My appointed task was to time the distance between mile markers and calculate our speed, a covert math lesson disguised as a critical duty.

“What’s our speed?” Dad would ask, gripping his eternal companion—a Stanley thermos that I’m convinced was surgically attached to his hand. This thermos was older than both Brandon and me combined, and Dad guarded it like it was the last cookie in the jar.

“Sixty-seven point three miles per hour,” I’d reply with confidence, despite being fairly certain that my calculations included at least two errors and a healthy dose of wishful thinking. Dad would nod sagely, as if I’d just provided him with vital intelligence about enemy troop movements. Sometimes he’d ask me to “check it again,” especially if we were passing through a speed trap, though I’m not sure any police officer would have accepted as valid “But sir, my kid’s mental math says we’re under the limit.”

As our unofficial tour guide, he transformed every lonely stretch of highway into an attraction worthy of *National Geographic*. Each

town we passed through had its story, delivered with the enthusiasm of someone unveiling ancient secrets. Dragoon, San Simon, Lordsburg—they all had their moment in our traveling spotlight.

“And what’s Deming’s claim to fame?” he’d quiz.

“Good water and fast ducks,” we’d reply in unison, having learned this particular piece of trivia somewhere between birth and basic motor skills. To this day, I’ve never seen these supposedly swift waterfowl, leading me to suspect they might have been too fast for even light to catch.

My grandmother’s arms were always waiting at the end of these midnight marathons, ready to ferry our sleep-heavy bodies from floorboards to mattress.

“You made good time,” she’d tell Dad every visit, regardless of whether we’d broken land speed records or stopped to help a tortoise cross the road (which we did, once, though Dad insisted it was actually a tactical delay to “let slower traffic clear out ahead of us”).



(L to R) My Great Aunt Rita Verne Martin (Grandma Posey's sister), Grandpa and Grandma Posey.

Posey Land

Once settled in Alamogordo, no visit was complete without our journeys up the mountain to Cloudcroft. The Posey clan—our people—had landed in these Sacramento Mountains after fleeing a drought in Texas during the 1800s, proving that sometimes the best family decisions are made by people who get lost on their way to California. I often wondered if they, too, had a father who insisted on exploring every possible trail, perhaps on horseback, refusing to stop for anything less than a medical emergency or an exceptionally good yard sale.

Dad approached these mountain excursions with the same military precision he brought to our nighttime drives.

“We’re burning daylight!” he’d announce at some ungodly morning hour, as if daylight were a finite resource that might suddenly be discontinued without warning. This from a man who

thought nothing of starting a six-hour drive at 10 p.m. the night before.

The drive up to Cloudcroft was an exercise in vehicular gymnastics, with our trusty dually truck navigating turns that seemed designed by someone with a profound misunderstanding of how roads should work. Dad would again point out landmarks with a tour guide's enthusiasm. "That's where your Uncle Hiram accidentally shot me!" or "Look at that view!"—the latter always coming at precisely the moment when looking anywhere but straight ahead seemed like a terrible idea.

From Cloudcroft to Mayhill, in between which my great grandparent's home still stands, all the way to Sixteen Springs, each destination was treated as if we were the first Poseys to rediscover it since the Great Migration.

"This is Posey land," Dad would declare with pride, gesturing broadly at what appeared to be public forest service property. I often wondered if the actual property deed just read "Posey land" in crayon, perhaps with a helpful doodle of a pine tree.

The Lodge at Cloudcroft stood as our base of operations, a grand old Victorian dame perched on the mountain like a fancy hat at a royal wedding. Built in 1899, it had survived multiple renovations, at least one fire, and, according to local legend, was haunted by a ghostly chambermaid named Rebecca. Dad treated this information like a personal challenge, as if Rebecca might materialize to validate

our family connection to the place.



The Lodge at Cloudcroft.

“Rebecca,” he’d say seriously to empty hallways, “we’re Poseys. We go way back.”

Her ghost never appeared, probably busy attending to spectral housekeeping duties or wondering why this man kept addressing her in empty corridors. Brandon once claimed he saw her dusting a chandelier at three in the morning, but he also claimed he could see those Deming ducks in the dark, so his credibility was questionable.

The gift shop had always been Dad's personal crusade—he visited religiously, not because we needed another snow globe or wooden bear, but because he was convinced that one day they'd stock proper Posey memorabilia. Each time, he'd scan those unchanging shelves like a man searching for his own reflection.

"You'd think they'd at least have a postcard," he'd mutter, scanning shelves that had remained the same since the Roosevelt administration. "I mean, we're practically founders."

The gift shop lady would just smile and point him toward the local history books, none of which, tragically, featured chapters on bear-wrestling uncles.

My own contribution to Lodge lore came during what we now call "The Great Fragrance Incident of '89." I was passing by one afternoon when the shop had decided to demonstrate their new line of "Mountain Air" scented products—an ambitious attempt to capture the essence of high-altitude living in wax form. While other visitors drifted by with appreciative sniffs and delighted murmurs about "fresh pine" and "winter frost," my body decided to stage an immediate and dramatic protest.

The projectile vomit that followed would have impressed a fire hydrant with its range and velocity. There I stood, betrayed by my own reflexes, creating what can only be described as an abstract expressionist masterpiece across the gift shop entrance. The shop lady, who had weathered years of Dad's Posey history lectures

without flinching, finally found something that could break her professional composure.

“I don’t think that’s what they meant by ‘making your mark’ on the Lodge,” Dad quipped, somehow maintaining his humor while simultaneously trying to prevent my further redecorating of the historic establishment. Brandon, ever helpful, suggested we should ask them to name the scent after me—“Posey’s Revenge” had a nice ring to it, he thought. That was the last day I entered that gift shop. Ever since, I’ve been afraid to even walk by it without holding my breath.

The Posey name, it seemed, was destined to be remembered in Cloudcroft one way or another. There was even a Posey Cottage at the Sacramento Mountains Historical Museum. “That’s your heritage,” Dad would say, pointing to what was essentially a very old shed.

I always wondered if its presence at the museum was less an honor and more a case of someone not knowing what to do with it. We’d nod solemnly, pretending to feel a deep connection to this architectural testament to our family’s ability to stack logs in a roughly house-shaped configuration. The cottage stood as proof that our ancestors had mastered the technological achievement of “putting one thing on top of another until you can fit inside it.”



All the Poseys gathered for a banquet in Mayhill.

The museum curator, a woman who had clearly been there since the Mesozoic era, would light up whenever we visited. "Oh, you're Poseys!" she'd exclaim, as if we were minor celebrities. She'd then launch into detailed genealogical histories that always ended with someone being chased by a bear.



Extended Posey family gathering, including the Campbells and the Walkers. My great grandfather Andrew “Jack” Posey is on the right.

Bonito Lake became our retreat when the weight of our historical legacy grew too heavy. Thirty minutes from anyplace worth being, it was where Dad transformed from family historian to fishing guru. He approached angling with the intensity of a chess grandmaster playing for world peace. Every expedition began with “tackle preparation,” a ritual that involved spreading his entire collection of gear across a picnic table. He’d examine each lure with the concentration of a jeweler appraising the Hope Diamond,

occasionally holding one up to the light and muttering, "This might be the one."

"You have to think like a trout," he'd advise, as if he'd spent years in underwater focus groups. "They're always watching." This anthropomorphizing of fish behavior reached its peak when he started attributing individual personalities to specific trout he claimed to recognize. "See that one?" he'd whisper, pointing to a ripple in the water. "That's Old Johnson. Been trying to catch him for three seasons."

The fact that all trout looked essentially identical didn't deter him from this naming convention. By our third visit that summer, he had assigned names to the entire fish population of Bonito Lake, complete with backstories and political affiliations.

Brandon and I would stand there, rods in hand, trying our best to adopt the mental state of creatures whose primary concerns were avoiding hooks and looking shiny. Dad had an entire theory about trout psychology that involved water temperature, lunar phases, and possibly the fish's zodiac signs. He'd analyze the water with squinted eyes, muttering about feeding patterns and oxygen levels, while Brandon and I watched a fish swimming past our bait with complete indifference.

"That one's definitely a Steve," Brandon would whisper, pointing to a particularly smug-looking trout.

"Looks more like a Kevin to me," I'd reply, both of us giggling

until Dad would shush us.

The lake had a way of bringing out Dad's storytelling prowess. Each fishing trip came with its own historical narrative, usually featuring some distant Posey who had caught a legendary trout. His voice would get bigger with each telling, as if the stories themselves were trying to fill something I couldn't quite see—a space that had been empty so long it had become part of him.



A. J. Posey's home in James Canyon, Sacramento Mountains, New Mexico, Sept. 30, 1909.

"Old Jack Posey once caught a rainbow trout so big," he'd begin,

and we'd settle in for a tale that would have made Hemingway blush. Sometimes I'd catch him glancing toward my grandfather, who stood motionless at the water's edge, rod held perfectly still, his approval as elusive as the fish we sought. Dad's stories would grow larger then, as if they could somehow bridge that quiet distance.

"How big was it?" Brandon would ask, playing his role in this familiar script.

"Well," Dad would say, pausing for dramatic effect, his voice carrying across the water toward the silent figure at the shoreline, "they had to widen the lake."

He'd deliver this punchline with such fierce conviction that, for a moment, I could see him as a boy himself, telling stories that grew until they could hold everything he needed them to. These stories always ended with the fish either escaping (of course) or being donated to a local orphanage, depending on Dad's mood that day.

One memorable afternoon, Dad actually caught something substantial. The ensuing battle between man and fish became, in real time, the stuff of legend. He fought with that trout for what seemed like hours but was probably closer to fifteen minutes, providing running commentary the entire time.

"This might be Old Johnson's grandson!" he declared, rod bending dramatically. "I can tell by the way he's fighting—definitely has Posey training!"

His voice carried across the lake, each proclamation a little louder

than necessary, each triumph announced like a herald seeking an audience that remained perpetually unmoved. Brandon and I watched him in that moment—this man who could build gardens from dust and pull feasts from thin air, now locked in combat with a fish that would surely grow larger with each retelling. And somehow, in the late afternoon light, I understood that every story he'd ever told was really about the same thing: impossible things could happen, if only someone was watching.



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The Postal Pilgrimage

“Go get the mail,” he said, his weathered hands steady on his glass of lemonade, as casually as if he’d asked me to pass the salt, not trek across what felt like the Sahara.

It was the kind of summer day where you could fry an egg on the sidewalk, if only there had been a sidewalk, or an egg, or really any sign of civilization. Grandpa Posey decided that I, a child barely old enough to tie my own shoes, was the perfect candidate for a life-threatening mission.

The driveway stretched before me like a gravel-strewn gauntlet that would make Lawrence of Arabia think twice. The mailbox? It might as well have been in Narnia for all I knew. You couldn’t even see the damn thing from the house, which I’m convinced was my grandfather’s diabolical plan all along—to send his grandchildren on quests so lengthy they’d return with beards and tales of

adventure.

With all the enthusiasm I could muster, I set off on my postal pilgrimage. Not two minutes into this Homeric journey, I heard a sound that turned my insides—a rattling noise that, in my panicked mind, could only be the warning call of a snake with murder on its forked tongue. I turned tail and sprinted back to the house, leaving a dust cloud worthy of a Roadrunner cartoon.

Red-faced and panting, I stammered to my grandfather, “I think I hear a rattlesnake.”

I hoped for sympathy, maybe even a parade in honor of my narrow escape.

What I got instead was a deadpan, “No, you go get the mail.”



How was I to argue with such iron-clad logic? Clearly, in my grandfather's world, potential death by snake was a small price to pay for timely receipt of the Sears catalog. And so, doomed to eternal postal retrieval, off I went again. As I approached the stretch of driveway that I now thought of as "Rattler's Lair," my ears pricked up. There it was again—that sound—only this time, it seemed closer.

I tried to channel my inner John Wayne, to summon some fragment of courage from the vast wasteland of my prepubescent psyche. I imagined my grandfather's stoic face, probably disappointed in me from all the way back at the house, where he was no doubt sipping lemonade and reminiscing about how he'd

fought off packs of wolves with nothing but a soup ladle during the Great Depression.

But alas, before I knew it, my legs were pumping like pistons, gravel spraying behind me, as I once again chose the path of cowardice. I'm pretty sure I set a new land speed record for panicked retreat, leaving my dignity somewhere back there with the imaginary snake.

And so, for the second time, I slunk back into the house, my tail between my legs—metaphorically speaking, of course, though at this point I wouldn't have been surprised if I'd sprouted one out of sheer evolutionary desperation. I mumbled something about deadly serpents lying in wait, my voice a perfect blend of prepubescent whine and barely concealed terror.

My grandfather fixed me with a stare that could have turned Medusa to stone. "Your mind," he declared, with all the warmth of an IRS auditor, "is playing tricks on you." I waited for the follow-up, maybe some grandfatherly wisdom about overcoming fear or the power of positive thinking. Instead, I got: "You go get that mail."

His tone suggested if I came back without completing my mission this time, I'd better be sporting some impressive fang marks or, at the very least, a good story about wrestling a Gila monster. It was clear in the great game of "Child vs. Imaginary Snake," Grandpa was firmly Team Snake.

So there I was, stuck between my grandfather's iron will and my

impending snakebite doom. What's a kid to do? My options seemed to be either tempting fate on the driveway of death or packing a kerchief on a stick and becoming the world's youngest, most incompetent hobo.

This time, I decided to employ a strategy I'd later perfect in my adult life: willful ignorance. I marched down that driveway like Helen Keller in a tambourine factory, steadfastly ignoring the rattling sound and trying not to look around. For a glorious moment, I thought I'd cracked the code of desert survival. That is, until suddenly, not more than a few feet away, was an honest-to-God, scales-and-all rattlesnake. Because of course there was.

I locked eyes with my virulent nemesis. I froze. Not out of any tactical brilliance, mind you, but because my fight-or-flight response had apparently taken, well, flight. As if one snake wasn't enough, a second rattler nonchalantly slithered out from the other side of the driveway. That's when it hit me—I was about to become the reluctant chaperone to a romantic reptilian rendezvous. Cupid, in his infinite wisdom, had chosen my grandfather's dusty driveway as the perfect spot for snake love to blossom. And I was smack dab in the middle of it all, a sweaty, petrified maypole around which this serpentine courtship would unfold.

The two snakes, apparently oblivious to my silent screaming, met at the edge of my sneakers. They began their reptilian courtship with all the subtlety of drunken teenagers at prom. I watched, a horrified

third wheel, as they flicked their forked tongues and made small talk. My imagination, always helpful in times of crisis, conjured up vivid scenarios of these amorous serpents deciding my pant leg would make an excellent love nest. I could practically feel their scales against my skin, slithering up my jeans like I was some sort of boy-shaped tree trunk.



It was right about then, as I was contemplating the merits of changing my name and moving to a snake-free country, that I heard the crunch of gravel. Grandpa, no doubt wondering if his personal mail retrieval service had been abducted by aliens, was coming to

investigate. I couldn't see him, of course. My eyes were locked forward in a thousand-yard stare. But I could hear him muttering something along the lines of "What in tarnation is that boy doing now?" As he got closer, though, I heard the unmistakable sound of rubber soles skidding to a halt on gravel. There was a sharp intake of breath, followed by a string of words I wasn't allowed to say. In that moment, I felt a perverse sense of satisfaction.

I wanted to turn around, to see the look on his face, to say, "See? I told you so!" But I didn't dare move. After all, I had a front-row seat to the greatest snake romance since *Anaconda*, and I wasn't about to steal their spotlight.

"Don't move!" Grandpa hollered. "I'll go get the shovel."

As I stood there, still as a department store mannequin, the snake rendezvous at my feet continued unabated. After what seemed like eons, I finally heard footsteps approaching once again.

Grandpa swooped in like a geriatric superhero, all arthritis and determination. Before I could blink, he'd performed a magic trick that would've made Houdini queasy—turning two snakes into four. As much as I relished the newfound freedom to move my legs, I couldn't help but mourn the tragic Romeo and Juliet of the reptile world. Their love story, cut short—quite literally.

As if to soften the blow of witnessing this serpentine severance, Grandpa swiftly chopped off their rattles—a souvenir of the day his grandson nearly became a snake charmer. He pocketed the rattles,

muttering something about “damned nuisances,” and turned back to the house. I trudged alongside him, feeling like I’d aged a decade in the span of an afternoon.

Of course, we still had to get that damned mail. Snake showdown or no, the mailbox wasn’t going to empty itself. I could almost hear Ed McMahon’s voice declaring we might already be winners, provided we survived the trek.

Back inside, Grandpa dropped the rattles in my palm without ceremony, his calloused fingers grazing mine for a heartbeat. I found a Dromedary pimiento jar, carefully affixed a label to it, and wrote “Rattlesnake Rattles” in my best cursive. Grandpa never said anything about it—then again, he never said much about anything. Praise stuck in his throat like fish bones. Kindness came out sideways through grunts and unfinished sentences. The jar of rattles has sat on my shelf for thirty-five years, tucked between old yearbooks and science fair ribbons.

I still take down that jar and listen to their hollow whisper. Not to remember the snakes, or even to prove I’d been right. I keep them because they’re a timestamp of that walk back to the house, the sound they made in Grandpa’s pocket with every step, the weight of everything unsaid: how fear tastes like copper, how being wrong feels like falling, how love sometimes only shows itself through what we surrender but never speak of.

We’d built our walls too high—his granite silence, my need to

prove myself. But in that moment, watching him hand over those rattles, something shifted. A wordless admission that changed everything and nothing.

The jar sits there still, dusty and undisturbed. The rattles have faded now, their warning soft as memory. But they tell me what Grandpa never could: that he'd seen me. That he'd been afraid, too. That the bravest thing we ever did was admit those walls were built on air, and the love we tried so hard to protect was there all along, disguised as a jar of rattles on a shelf.

The Conquistador Conquest

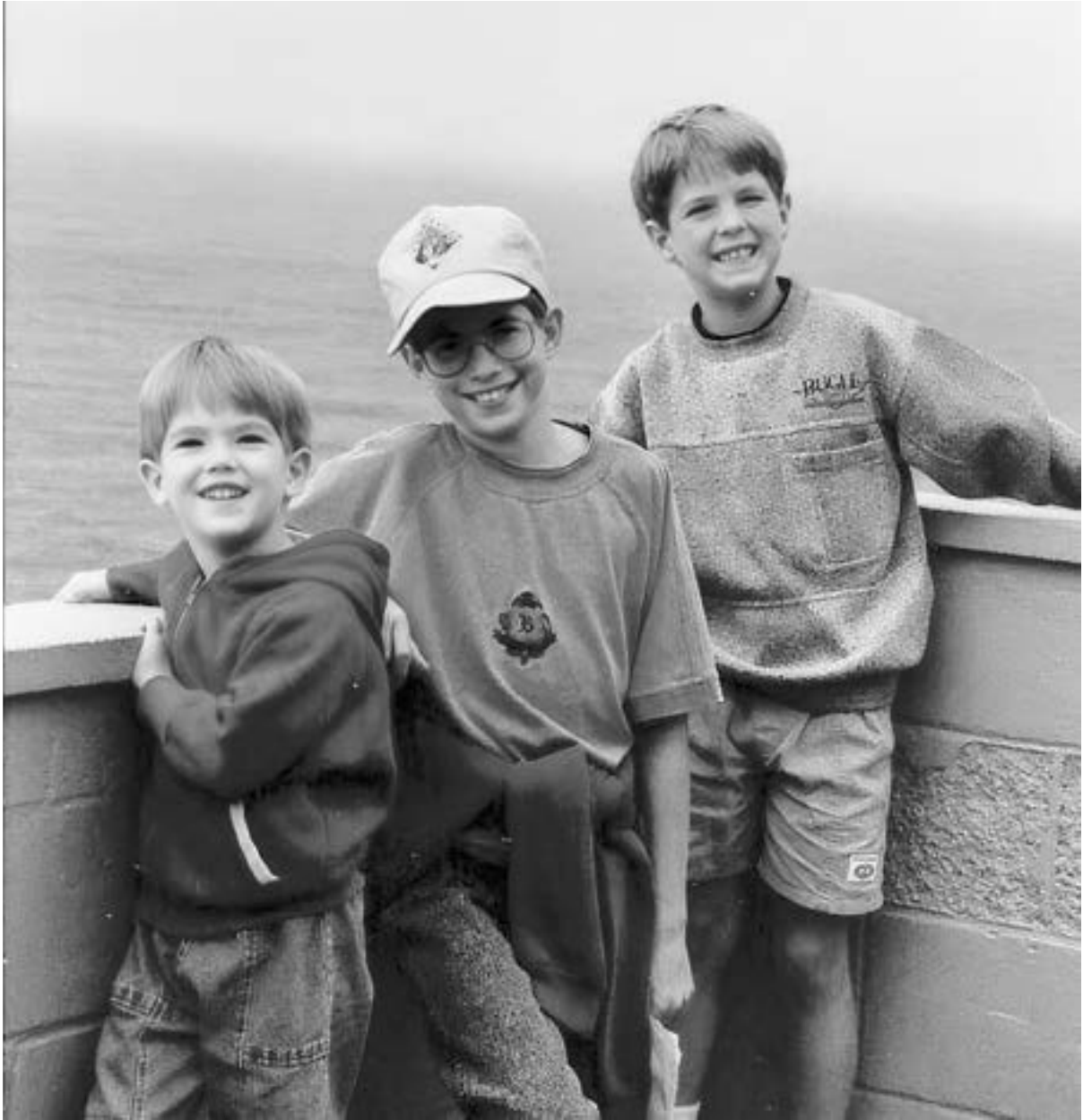
My childhood brain was like a deranged squirrel, ricocheting from one shiny object to the next. I devoured new experiences. I gorged on random facts and ill-advised pursuits. One week, I'd declare myself a future world-renowned lepidopterist, stalking butterflies through our backyard with a net cobbled from my mother's pantyhose. The next, I'd be conjugating verbs in Esperanto, much to our neighbors' bewilderment. Our house transformed into a museum of abandoned passions, each exhibit cataloging my perpetual enthusiasm. After all, what child's bedroom isn't complete without jars of murky pond water, gathered in pursuit of ichthyological research?

I burned with an insatiable need to understand the mechanics of...well, everything. No household appliance escaped my fledgling screwdriver skills. I'd like to claim I was preparing for a lucrative

career in appliance repair, but in truth, I was a mini Godzilla, leaving in my wake a wasteland of voided warranties.

While most of my cerebral obsessions demanded little physical effort, I found salvation in the outdoors. Hiking, fishing, and channeling Indiana Jones became my antidote to the relentless pinball machine of my mind. Even then, I understood the necessity of escaping the labyrinth of my half-baked projects and useless trivia.

As summer vacation's suffocating ennui threatened to transform my siblings into comatose couch-dwellers, I'd swoop in with my latest harebrained scheme. My brothers, bless them, would inevitably agree—not from any spark of genuine enthusiasm, mind you, but because the alternative was Mother's philosophical rebuttal: "Boredom is a fallacy. There are only boring people."



(L to R) Mack, me, and Brandon along the Oregon Coast. One of my most treasured memories.

My preeminent obsession was finding Spanish treasure. The urge wasn't born from any reverence for history or, heaven help me, actual archaeological expertise. No, it all sprouted from a book

bestowed by my uncle, a curious volume on ancient Spanish symbols used by conquistadors. Trust Uncle Hiram to gift a child a book that would lead to sunburn, dehydration, and a lifelong suspicion of cacti. This was the same man who'd once chronicled his flatulence for an entire year, then unveiled it as a Christmas soundtrack for the whole family. A book that propelled me into the dangers of the desert was on-brand for Uncle Hiram.

This literary question mark brimmed with what historians would diplomatically call "dubious information." It alleged that those clever Spaniards had transformed the landscape into a sunbaked game of connect-the-dots. A few stacked rocks next to a saguaro cactus with suspiciously positioned arms? Obviously part of an elaborate conquistadorial morse code. It was all there, a roadmap for the chronically optimistic.

Brandon and I shared a fierce love of nature, though he undeniably had the purer heart for it. Perhaps that's why, one fateful morning, I found my brothers surprisingly receptive to the siren song of treasure hunting in the great outdoors. A little sales pitch from yours truly, and Mack and Brandon were practically vibrating with possibility of unearthing ancient riches.

Mom lived in Oro Valley at the time—a name that whispered "gold" like a desert's fevered promise. It felt as if the universe had rolled out the red carpet for our impending adventure. So three would-be explorers ventured forth from our mother's house, armed

with audacious dreams, a spectacular absence of common sense, and a few trusty shovels. For good measure, I brought what some would call a “walking stick,” but which was in my mind unquestionably a wizard’s staff. Our provisions—granola bars and water canteens—suggested we were prepared for any challenge, save reality itself.

As we trekked into the desert to unravel *The Case of the Lost Conquistador’s Gold*, we carried the unshakeable conviction that we’d return as three wealthy heroes. On and on we marched, the morning sun climbing mercilessly higher, transforming the landscape into a sweltering, shimmering canvas.

At last, we discovered our destiny: a congregation of saguaro where I was certain Spanish gold lay waiting. Why these particular cacti? I couldn’t say, except that they bore some vague resemblance to the illustrations I’d tormented Brandon and Mack with for weeks. My methodology was as reliable as consulting tea leaves about tomorrow’s weather, but to my treasure-fevered mind, it was gospel truth. We must have been quite the spectacle: three boys wielding adult-sized shovels, examining cacti, and chatting about how they would spend the first million.

Time, that mischievous devil, plays peculiar games when you’re absorbed in decoding the secret semaphore of desert plants. One moment we were scrutinizing spiny flora like scholars before a sacred text; the next, the sun had painted the sky in apocalyptic shades of “you’re doomed” orange and “Mother’s going to kill us”

red.

I reached for my canteen with the desperation of a man lost in a desert—which, as fate would have it, I was. Its hollow clunk as I shook it dry sang about as sweetly as a rattlesnake’s lullaby. My stomach chose that precise moment to voice its grievance, producing the sound of a deflating accordion. Frantically, I groped for a granola bar, only to discover a handful of empty wrappers that rustled their accusations. Oh, the betrayal of past-me, that ravenous fool.

“We missed dinner,” I proclaimed, my voice splintering like the bone-dry earth beneath our feet.

Mack, still entranced by this cactus-based treasure hunt, didn’t acknowledge my existential crisis. Brandon, voice of reason in our triumvirate of foolishness, replied, “How can we miss dinner if we never had lunch?”

Mack finally lifted his gaze. “Are we too far to make it back for dinner?” he asked, his voice carrying the desperate optimism of a death row inmate inquiring about the dessert menu.

“Yep. Way too far,” I replied, calculating the distance between us and salvation, arriving at a figure somewhere between “impossible” and “eternal damnation.”

I pointed the wizard’s staff toward the sun, now making its theatrical exit stage west. My brothers fell silent, their faces perfectly mirroring the “oh no” epiphany dawning on us all. A lone coyote serenaded our predicament from somewhere in the gathering dusk,

while an ominous wind played its haunting melody through the cacti.

“Better book it or Mom’s gonna kill us,” I declared. “We’ve got a long walk home.”

We launched ourselves like three sunburned, dehydrated gazelles, our minds consumed by visions of maternal wrath. I pictured Mother pacing the kitchen, wooden spoon in hand, devising punishments that would make the Spanish Inquisition seem like a cheerful afternoon at Disneyland.

We learned a valuable lesson as we dragged our desiccated bodies onward. Sprinting across a scorching desert bears no resemblance to a hundred-meter dash on a pristine track. No, this was more akin to wading through molten glass. By the third mile, it felt like we were wearing concrete shoes, and our throats were as arid as Uncle Hiram’s sense of humor. Our lungs blazed with each breath, processing more desert sand than oxygen. I began to wonder if this was how it felt to be kindling in Lucifer’s firepit.



Trying to look tough.

All the while, one persistent question kept surfacing in my sand-saturated brain: *Are we going in the right direction?* For all I knew, we were headed straight for Mexico, where at least we'd have the dignity of being international fugitives.

As we stumbled through our fourth mile, night's starlit canopy began its descent like an executioner's shroud. Still no signs of home. Panic bloomed—not the mild “forgot my homework” variety, but the full-blown “future buzzard buffet” kind. In that moment of crystalline clarity reserved for the truly doomed, a single thought emerged: *Mom's going to be furious when she discovers our sun-bleached bones! She'll probably ground them for a month.*

I was about to inform my brothers that “death by vulture” was imminent, when something miraculous materialized. Through the purple twilight haze that still clung to the desert air, our house emerged on the horizon.

“Run like the wind!” I proclaimed.

Our house stood sentinel, a lighthouse of both salvation and impending maternal justice, less welcoming oasis and more finish line of some demented marathon. But in that moment, even guaranteed punishment seemed preferable to becoming the world's most underwhelming desert mummy exhibition. Victory hovered tantalizingly close, almost palpable on our parched tongues.

Mere feet from our triumphant return, just as we were about to attempt an undetected entrance, my supposedly magical wizard's staff chose that precise moment to make contact (seemingly of its own accord, I swear upon Uncle Hiram's hidden gold stash), with the sliding glass door. And by “make contact” I'm referring to a thunderous collision. I froze mid-stride, my brain shorting out like

an overloaded Christmas display. Brandon and Mack collided with my back in perfect slapstick synchronization, as if auditioning for *The Three Stooges: Desert Adventure*.

“Clumsy,” Brandon murmured.

My gaze lifted to meet Mom’s laser-beam glare through the glass. If looks could incinerate, we’d have been reduced to three neat piles of ash right there on the patio. The kitchen clock behind her proclaimed 7:39 p.m., each minute past curfew visibly pulsing in the angry vein on her forehead. What followed was a virtuoso performance in the art of groveling. I apologized with increasing desperation, each “sorry” climbing the octaves until only the desert coyotes could detect my plea.

We weathered Mom’s tempest like the seasoned adventurers we pretended to be, standing resolute before her fury. Her words cascaded over us like a monsoon in the desert—terrifying and overwhelming, yet somehow unable to erode the golden memories we’d forged that day.

So thank you, Mom, for your eventual forgiveness. And gratitude to you, Arizona desert, for your merciful restraint. But most of all, thanks to Uncle Hiram and his enigmatic book of conquistador ciphers. Without you, we might never have learned that sometimes the real treasure isn’t Spanish gold or ancient artifacts, but the profound ability to appreciate air conditioning at a molecular level.

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The Bait Bonanza

Every summer, we migrated. Like birds. Like birds with considerably more baggage and questionable navigation skills—but migrants nonetheless. Our North Star was Heron Lake. And at the head of our caravan was my grandparents' Bounder motorhome—a vehicle that managed to be simultaneously magnificent and absurd.

The annual Posey family gathering loomed. Like Christmas Eve visions or the wait for the final bell of algebra class, my anticipation was raw. Electric.

Heron Lake sat like a sapphire brooch pinned to northern New Mexico's chest, seven thousand feet up where the air is whisper-thin. Our family's mecca harbored an underwater metropolis of lake trout and kokanee salmon. In winter, the surface would freeze solid enough for ice fishing, though in a state famous for frying eggs on sidewalks, this always struck me as nature's particular brand of

irony.

Selecting the perfect campsite was serious business. Dad approached the task like a general plotting battle strategy, his eyes occasionally darting to the Bounder where his father watched. The mobile command center circled the campground. Round and round went my grandparents, pioneers scouting for their promised land. The cliffs around us had stories to tell: ancient petroglyphs sharing rock space with Spanish land grant markers. The Sangre de Cristo Mountains watched it all, named by Spanish settlers with their peculiar habit of invoking saints and blood.

Back then, I thought Dad was just being particular. Now I understand. He wasn't just picking a campsite; he was setting the stage for memories that would outlast him, adding our own layer to the geological potluck where every epoch had brought something to share.

"Your grandfather used to do the same thing," Grandma would say, watching Dad pace. "Some things just run in the blood." She'd launch into stories about Dad's childhood camping mishaps, her laughter as fresh as when the memories were new. These stories were the threads that stitched our generations together, even when some of those stitches pulled too tight.



Grandma and Grandpa Posey finding their slice of serenity at Heron Lake.

Brandon, Dad, and I would tackle tent assembly and firewood gathering. Someone always ended up cursing at an inanimate object or nursing a splinter the size of Texas. These moments of shared frustration became as much a part of our family tradition as any success.

Once camp was set, our real family legacy began to unfold. Nothing defined us quite like the annual crawdad cook-off. This wasn't just dinner—this was our family's Super Bowl. Brandon and I approached this contest with obsessive dedication. Throughout the year, we'd tinker with our traps, each design more Byzantine than the last. The other kids at Heron Lake were our rivals, though we

viewed them less as worthy opponents and more as unfortunate obstacles in our destined path to crustacean glory. This arms race of increasingly elaborate contraptions continued until fate—or perhaps the crawdad gods themselves—finally revealed what we'd been too clever to notice.



Dad, Brandon, and me showing off what turned out to be the second largest trout catch in New Mexico, a record I'm sure has since been overturned.

We'd propped our fishing poles against rocks at the shoreline, hoping to catch carp—a fish that, I'm convinced, only exists to make other fish feel better about themselves. Meanwhile, about twenty

yards away, Brandon and I busied ourselves with our latest trap innovations, contemporary art pieces that would have made Alexander Calder question his life's work. We'd also become the lake's unofficial garbage disposal system, collecting fish innards from successful fishermen. Our gunny sack of guts sat submerged in the water.

That's when I heard it—the unmistakable scream of fishing line under assault. Brandon's rod bent like a question mark searching for its answer.

"Holy mother of carp!" I shouted.

Brandon's war cry scattered birds from three counties. We abandoned our gut collection—a sentence I never thought I'd write—and sprinted for the rod. The pole launched skyward, performed a perfect triple axel, and vanished into the depths.

Dad's reaction redefined the art of the parental lecture. He paced the shoreline, words tumbling out with the deftness of a man who'd given disappointment speeches in rearview mirrors his whole life. When he finally released us back to gut-gathering duty, I caught him stealing glances at the water, as if waiting for his pole to resurface with a written apology.

But then...serendipity.

"Justin, look at the sack!" Brandon's voice cracked with excitement. His eyes had expanded to the size of dinner plates.

The gunny sack writhed and twisted, its sides bulging. The water

around it churned with activity.

“No way,” I breathed, dropping to my knees. “No freaking way.”

Brandon and I exchanged a look. Together, we grabbed the sack. It felt heavy, and alive with movement. As we hauled it from the water, the smell hit us first—earthy, like a forest floor had gone swimming. Through the mesh, crawdads clung to every fiber, their shells glistening in the afternoon sun. Water cascaded from the sack, creating a brief rainbow.

Families emerged from their campsites. Children materialized as if summoned. Even the usually unimpressible teenagers abandoned their carefully cultivated indifference. The whispers spread.

“Would you look at that?”

“How many you think are in there?”

“Martha, come see this!”

It took our combined strength—which, given our age, was roughly equivalent to that of one determined adult—to heave our bounty onto the picnic table. Grandma Posey’s “For heaven’s sake!” cut through the murmurs. She appeared at my elbow, hands on her skinny hips, shaking her head.

“Dad!” Brandon’s voice carried across the campground. “DAD! You gotta see this!”

Grandma turned to Dad, who had finally abandoned his pole-mourning vigil to investigate the commotion. His face did that thing where he was trying not to look impressed but failing miserably at it

—an expression I’d seen him perfect through years of watching me fail upwards. He circled the table slowly before finally declaring, “Well, I’ll be damned.” It was as if we’d discovered gold instead of garbage-eating bottom feeders.

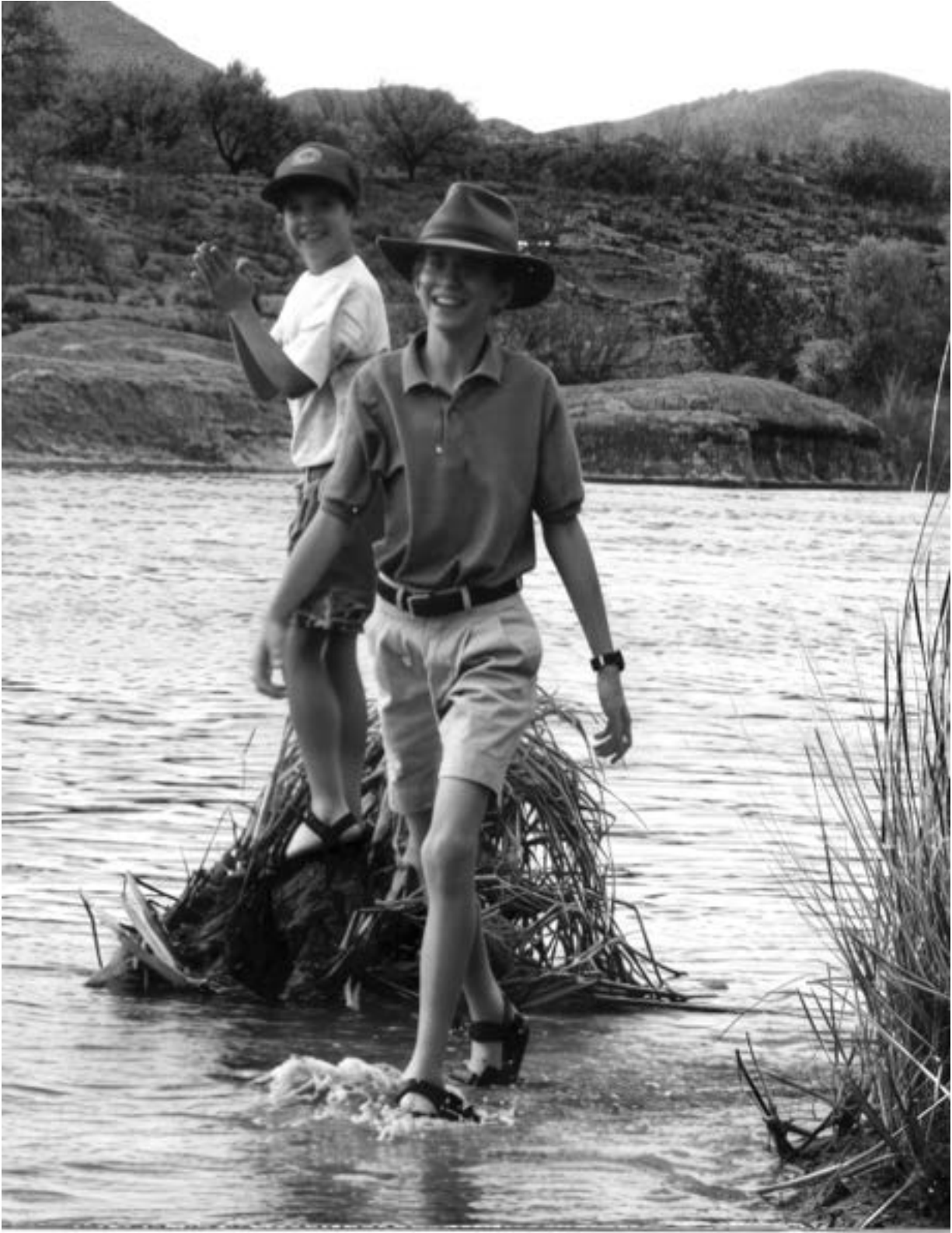
But in that moment, witnessing our family cluster around that picnic table, we might as well have found gold. The crawdad boil that followed would become the stuff of family legend, spoken about in the same reverent tones as miracle cures or particularly good casseroles.

From that day forward, we guarded our secret like Colonel Sanders and his eleven herbs and spices. Our fellow campers watched us transport our catch, seeing only a fidgeting gunny sack, never suspecting the vehicle itself was the trap. They were admiring the empty hat, missing the rabbit sitting in plain sight.

The greatest trick wasn’t catching the crawdads; it was convincing everyone that it had been difficult! Brandon and I had spent years engineering overly complex traps, when the answer was literally garbage in a bag.

Somewhere in the depths of Heron Lake, Brandon’s pole still rests—probably a shrine to the crawdad gods who watched us year after year, waiting for us to stumble backwards into genius. I imagine them gathering around it like their own Stonehenge, claws raised to human stupidity. Because that’s the real joke—sometimes you spend years engineering the perfect solution, only to find it floating in a

sack of fish guts.



Goofy grins on our faces after dropping our bag of fish guts.

The Gracie Grail

Mrs. Henderson stood up at the town hall meeting, her pearls catching the fluorescent light like tiny moons. “Synchronized lighting will destroy the fabric of our community,” she declared, each word drawn taut with horror, as if someone had proposed installing a guillotine on North Montana Street rather than a stoplight. That’s how time moved in Dillon back then—measured not in hours, but in waves and nods at the four-way stop, where people had to make eye contact, had to acknowledge each other with that small-town courtesy as fundamental to the landscape as the mountains themselves.

That summer marked the beginning of changes in Dillon. Progress crept in like water finding cracks in an old foundation, starting with those three steady colors that now conducted the rhythm of Montana Street. But while the intersection marched

forward in three-minute intervals of red, yellow, and green, there were still pockets where time pooled and eddied like a mountain stream. And nobody navigated those waters better than Gracie's Antiques.

Her shop looked like what might happen if a castle eloped with a yard sale. An arched entryway, crowned with brick and wrapped in mystery, beckoned you inside. The iron gate seemed to politely suggest this place had boundaries—albeit whimsical ones—like my grandmother's definition of “a small piece of cake.”

The shop's name, “Gracie's Antiques,” danced in cheerful script across the window, surrounded by displays that looked like they'd been arranged by a caffeinated raccoon who'd watched one too many episodes of *Antiques Roadshow*. Outside, mismatched furniture—including an overstuffed sofa that had clearly lived several lives, most of them scandalous—invited visitors to sit and contemplate their life choices. A turret-like structure at the corner crowned Gracie as queen of her own quirky kingdom, though her subjects were mainly dust bunnies and bewildered tourists.

Inside, the shop defied both categorization and the laws of physics. The air hung thick with that peculiar perfume of aged paper and forgotten summers, as if someone had distilled time itself. The bell above the door had long since abandoned its original purpose, instead producing what might be described as the dying gasp of a melodic hiccup—less a welcome and more a warning to dust motes

stirred from their decades-long meditation.

In its prime back in the late '80s and early '90s, Gracie's was my personal Narnia, a sanctuary where broken things still held value. The shop had its own geography. The Valley of Vintage Vinyl near the front window showcased album covers from the 1950s and '60s that promised impossible hairstyles and eternal youth. The Mountains of Mismatched China towered by the register like a ceramic Tower of Pisa. And then there was what I called the Forest of Forgotten Things, where borders between then and now blurred and softened, where the strangest items gathered dust and dignity in equal measure.

It was here, among ancient display cases that held Rocky Mountain beetles frozen in amber time, that I discovered my treasure: a hand-drawn map from the late nineteenth century, nestled between two beetle displays like a secret slipped through time's fingers. The Apache territories spread in faded ink across paper that had been folded and unfolded until the creases made fissure cracks in the landscape. The Dragoon Mountains traced in trembling lines seemed to pulse with memories of horses and summer heat. The paper felt crafted from the same essence as my grandmother's sugar cookies—delicate, golden-brown at the edges, and surely not long for this world.

At only \$6.00, this was more than a bargain—this was stealing! Surely when I went to pay for this precious artifact, Gracie would

notice the pricing error, perhaps a decimal point that had jumped two places to the left.

When I approached the counter, she was locked in artful combat with a customer over a pocket watch, their negotiations reaching a crescendo. She leaned across the counter, her cat-eye glasses perched on her nose like they'd witnessed every presidential administration since Eisenhower and remained thoroughly unimpressed.

"But it's an antique!" the customer protested, clutching the watch as if it might spin backwards through time at his touch. His bow tie seemed permanently affixed, like he'd emerged from the womb demanding to speak to the delivery room manager.

"Honey," Gracie drawled, "I'm an antique, and you don't see anyone offering me fifty bucks to sit on their mantle."

I seized my moment, sliding the map across the counter beneath a camouflage of trinkets—a brass button that had likely witnessed more high school band practices than Civil War battles, a tiny porcelain dog who'd sacrificed his fourth leg to some miniature skirmish, and a telegram machine manual whose earnest illustrations stood ready for that urgent moment when one simply must contact someone in 1873. I counted out ten dollars in crumpled bills, a fortune that represented months of allowance money, trying to keep my hand steady as I handed over my life's savings.

As I turned to leave, wrestling with an oversized door that seemed designed by a vindictive medieval architect with a grudge

against fingers, I heard Gracie call out, “Hey, kiddo!”

My heart, which had been performing an impressive samba, skidded to a funeral march. This was it. I was about to be unmasked as the accidental antiquities thief I’d become. I’d be sent to juvie, where my cellmate would undoubtedly answer to “Bruiser” or “Knuckles,” and I’d learn to fashion shivs from contraband cafeteria sporks.

But Gracie just winked at me, the corners of her eyes crinkling like well-loved parchment. “Lift and turn, sweetie. It’s trickier than my husband’s alibi.”

In her eyes, I saw recognition—one collector of moments acknowledging another, even if one of us was just a kid who still believed that maps could lead to treasure and that three-legged porcelain dogs deserved loving homes.

Gracie’s still stands, though she’s gone. When I unfold the map now, I understand what guided the cartographer’s trembling hand. The same force that filled Gracie’s shelves. The same fever that keeps me hunting: this desperate belief that we can somehow catch time in a net of collected things.

The Concrete Kiss

Every evening after dinner, when the desert air began to cool and before the raccoons emerged from their dens, three bikes would roll out of our garage—my father's, Brandon's, and mine. Each had its own voice: squeaking chains, clicking gears, handlebars that never stayed straight. From fall through spring, while the temperature made cycling a joy rather than an endurance test, the three of us would trace our nightly route around the neighboring golf course.

At that hour, the course belonged to us and the desert creatures. Mesquite trees whispered in the evening breeze while fading light painted the landscape in muted hues. We weren't training for anything—just three people on bikes, sharing the quiet joy of motion through cooling air. These rides carved a perfect space between day and night, where we were simply family, as much a part of the desert as the saguaros standing guard around us.

First on our nightly path came the fallen cottonwood—once a towering sentinel of the golf course, now a gentle giant resting along the treeline. Its fall had been nature’s spectacle, but in its second life it became a sanctuary. Its hollows held stories of life and renewal at the edge of the Tanque Verde Wash.

Several generations had lived here. Mother raccoons chose this fallen fortress as their nursery, weaving an unseen thread of connection through time. Each evening we approached with held breath and wide eyes, waiting. There’s a singular magic in such moments—the patient thrill of watching for the sow to begin her nightly quest for food, a ritual as steady as our own. On the rarest evenings, fortune blessed us with a sighting. In those precious moments, the only movement was the deliberate passage of a raccoon mother as she emerged from her cottonwood sanctuary, setting out beneath the desert stars.

While the cottonwood offered moments of quiet wonder, what followed set our hearts racing. We called it “The Big Hill”—though it might barely register as a speed bump in Idaho. To us, it was Everest with training wheels, the crown jewel of our daily route. For years, my brother and I treated it as our personal Indy 500, minus the fame, fortune, and any hint of actual skill.

One evening, as we barreled down this asphalt monster, I found myself in the lead—king of the hill, wind whipping through my hair. That’s when everything went sideways. My front tire started to

shimmy like Elvis on espresso, and as I fixated on this rebellious wheel, it locked up completely. In that perfect moment, my faithful bicycle transformed into an enthusiastic catapult, and I became its ammunition.

As I sailed through the desert air, my one coherent thought was, *Thank God I'm wearing a helmet.* The universe, ever the comedian, chose that exact moment to remind me about physics. The rushing wind pushed my helmet back, exposing my forehead just in time for its intimate meeting with the road.



What followed was less a landing than an archaeological expedition—my face pioneering new methods of concrete sampling. I'm certain I set a world record for "distance traveled by human nose on pavement."

My father and brother reached the scene of my nonelective facelift with the urgency of kids chasing an ice cream truck. As I peeled myself off the ground—much like removing a determined Band-Aid—I glimpsed the horror in my father's eyes.

"Oh, GOD!" he exclaimed. "Brandon—wait here with your brother. I'll be right back."

He vanished like a man fleeing an IRS audit, leaving us to contemplate the elastic nature of "right back." I half expected him to return with a priest, a notary public, and possibly a trauma specialist.

Seconds later an engine roared. There, charging down the pristine fairway of the Forty Niners golf course, was my father in his behemoth truck—a one-ton dually so massive it had its own gravitational pull. He drove with the grace of a rhinoceros through a china shop, leaving a trail of destruction and ten thousand divot's worth of upturned sod. As he skidded to a stop beside us, showering my bloody form with fresh earth and grass clippings, I felt an unexpected surge of pride. Sure, other kids' dads might respect private property laws, but mine? He turned the back nine into his

personal Fury Road, just to scrape his idiot son off the pavement.

As the fog of shock lifted, two revelations dawned. First, my smile had been involuntarily remodeled to hockey player chic. Second, and more disturbingly, my face had apparently installed an emergency exit. I discovered I could stick my tongue out without opening my mouth. They say when life gives you lemons, make lemonade. But when life gives you an extra orifice, the self-help books offer surprisingly little guidance.

As we careened toward the hospital in Dad's golf course excavator, I noticed an unusual silence from the middle seat, as uncomfortable as the skin currently dangling from my chin. But then Brandon's voice emerged, small and tremulous. He tugged at Dad's sleeve with the hesitant persistence of a kitten at a closed door. His words came barely above a whisper, as if speaking too loudly might snap the fragile thread of my existence.

"Dad," he squeaked, "is Justin gonna die?"

I'd never heard my name paired with "die" before, at least not outside my mother's daily threats over dirty dishes in the sink. I wanted to reassure him, crack some joke, but my newly ventilated face made speech a dangerous gamble.

"He might sound like it," Dad replied, "but he's going to survive. Don't you worry."

In my dazed state, I'd missed the Nascar-worthy speeds at which my father was piloting his impromptu ambulance. The local police,

however, took notice. Red and blue lights erupted behind us and we were promptly pulled over.

As the officer approached our window, no doubt ready to lecture us on speed limits and golf course sanctity, he caught sight of my face. In a split second his expression transformed from “tough cop” to “man encountering creature from the black lagoon.”

“Follow me!” he bellowed. And just like that, our rescue mission gained a police escort.

As we followed the police cruiser, sirens wailing in the night, I felt a boost of confidence. Sure, my face resembled a losing bout with a cheese grater, but how many kids could say their routine bike ride got upgraded to a high-speed police convoy?

After an eternity of hospitals, doctors, and the kind of pain that makes you reconsider the benefits of consciousness, I emerged from my chrysalis of gauze and stitches. Multiple skin grafts had turned me into a human patchwork quilt, while a parade of surgeons and dentists labored to reassemble my face into something that might pass for its former self.

My nose, though, remained a stubborn souvenir of my ill-fated flight. It now carried a slight leftward lean, as if perpetually pointing the way to my next potential disaster. I came to think of it as my built-in misfortune compass.

Some time later, in a moment of macabre nostalgia, my brother and I returned to the scene of the crime. There, scattered across the

pavement like the world's most depressing Easter egg hunt, we found the fragments of my teeth—tiny calcium keepsakes, miniature monuments to my folly. I gathered them carefully into a jar.

I learned three vital truths that day: gravity remains undefeated, pavement makes a poor pillow, and my guardian angel deserves hazard pay.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Treasure Tempest

Hidden treasure. A mysterious mountain peak. A decades-old family secret. I was about to stumble into all three, and it would change my life forever. But first, I had to survive a Posey family reunion.

The year was 1995. As was our custom, we had driven through the night to my paternal grandparents' house in Alamogordo, New Mexico. Their sprawling pecan orchard sat at the edge of town, close enough to the Sacramento Mountains you could taste the pine in the air—a forested island rising above the arid desert landscape. As relatives poured in from across the country, the house transformed into a bustling hub of laughter, stories, and Aunt Lori's famous salsa. Little did I know, buried beneath the chatter and chuckles, lay a legend that would consume my young mind for years to come.



It happened on the back porch, where the adults gathered as dusk fell. Brandon and I watched from our corner as cicadas screamed their summer anthem. My heart raced with the thrill of being allowed to stay up late, privy to the mysterious world of grown-up conversations.

That's when I heard it—a name whispered like a secret: Victorio Peak.

My ears perked up. Despite my usual talent for blending into the shadows, curiosity yanked me forward. "There's a hidden treasure?!" I blurted out.

The adults fell silent, exchanging those loaded looks that grown-ups share when deciding how much truth to feed young ears. I held my breath, certain I'd violated some cardinal rule of eavesdropping.

Finally, my father cleared his throat. "Well, son," he began, his voice carrying a mix of caution and barely contained excitement, "the story of Victorio Peak goes back to 1937 with a man named Doc Noss and his wife Ova."

Uncle Hiram, practically bouncing in his seat, couldn't hold back. "Doc was no ordinary fella!" he exclaimed, eyes twinkling. "He was a jack-of-all-trades, a real character! But let me tell you, everything changed when he found that cave in Victorio Peak."

"Gold," I whispered, my eyes wide, mind already conjuring images of pirate-worthy treasure chests.

"That's right," my father confirmed, leaning in conspiratorially. "Doc discovered a massive treasure trove. Gold bars, ancient coins, jewels—even artifacts that might've belonged to Spanish conquistadors."

Uncle Hiram slapped his knee. "And let me tell you, kiddo, this isn't some tall tale. This treasure? It's as real as the ground beneath your feet!"

Grandpa Posey, who had been quietly sipping his cuba libre, spoke up. His voice carried a hint of mischief. "Some say it was Apache treasure," he mused. "Others claim Spanish explorers left it, or maybe it was gold stolen during the Civil War. But the important

thing is—it's there."

My father nodded solemnly. "Doc managed to remove some gold bars, but most of the treasure lay too deep in the narrow cave to reach easily. Then things got...complicated."

"Complicated how?" I pressed, inching closer.

"Well," my father said, his tone darkening, "Doc got into a dispute with his partner, Charlie Ryan. That's when he started hiding the gold bars he'd managed to retrieve."

Uncle Hiram dropped his voice to a dramatic whisper. "And that's where your great Uncle Alton enters the story! He and Doc were friends, along with a fellow named Toney Jolley. They helped Doc hide some of those gold bars across Hembrillo Basin."

Grandpa Posey's eyes took on a distant gleam. "Alton...he knew things. Things he shared with me before he passed," he said softly, his words trailing into the night air.

My father and Uncle Hiram glanced at one another—a silent conversation I couldn't decode. The whole scene felt like watching a complex dance where I only knew half the steps.

"Alton was there the night before Doc was murdered," my father continued, his voice barely above a whisper. "March 5th, 1940. Doc told him his life was in danger, and he was right."

A chill walked down my spine. The idea that this treasure hunt had ended in murder made it terrifyingly real.

"What happened after that?" I asked, both dreading and craving

the answer.

“Well,” Grandpa Posey drew out the word, “word of the treasure spread. Then in the 1950s, the military claimed the area for White Sands Missile Range.”

Seeing my confusion, my father explained, “It’s a massive military installation where they test missiles and other technology. You know, outside of town—that sea of white sand.”

“That’s when the real circus began,” Uncle Hiram chimed in. “Treasure hunters, government expeditions, even supposed Spanish royal descendants all claimed rights to the gold. It was wilder than a rodeo in a thunderstorm!”

“Don’t forget Operation Goldfinder,” Dad said.

Uncle Hiram nodded. “The Army went in looking for that treasure in the ’60s. They found something, but what it was, nobody seems to know for sure. It’s all hush-hush, you know?”

I sat back, mind spinning like a dust devil. The weight of this family secret settled over me like a heavy blanket.

“So...is the treasure still there?” I whispered.

The adults traded glances, another silent conference passing between them. Finally, my father spoke, weighing each word. “Son, let’s just say that some things are better left undisturbed.”

Grandpa Posey nodded sagely. “What we know is that your great Uncle Alton saw something with his own eyes. And in this family, we don’t just believe him. We know.”

I looked to my grandmother, our family's resident skeptic. She had always been quick to deflate any story that smelled even faintly of nonsense. But as our eyes met, she simply smiled and nodded—a gesture so subtle yet profound that it sent electricity dancing down my spine.

That night, at age twelve, I became a treasure hunter.



From the right: Grandpa and Grandma Posey, great Aunt Rita Verne Martin, my great grandfather Beuford “Popo” Martin, and Rita Verne’s oldest daughter.

The Peak Pursuit

The late-night conversation on my grandparents' back porch ignited an obsession in my prepubescent brain as fierce as the New Mexico sun at high noon. For years after, my mind burned with the knowledge that hidden treasure lay so tantalizingly close, yet so maddeningly out of reach. I'd lie awake at night, thoughts racing like roadrunners across the desert of my imagination. Victorio Peak loomed large in my dreams, a siren song in mountain form, calling to a lucky kid with a flashlight, a treasure map, and what my mother called "a concerning lack of self-preservation instincts."

I devoured every scrap of information about Victorio Peak I could find—books, newspaper clippings, whispered rumors passed between crusty old-timers at the local diner. My school notebooks transformed into archaeological journals, filled with amateur cave drawings and half-baked rappelling designs. More than once, my

teachers had to drag my attention from subterranean daydreams back to the considerably less thrilling realms of long division and state capitals.

But always, that nagging question burned in the back of my mind: *How can a kid get up there to look around?* It was a puzzle more complex than a Rubik's Cube designed by Salvador Dali. The obstacles stood like a mountain range of impossibility: my age (young), my survival skills (nonexistent), the minor inconvenience of it being a restricted military installation (very illegal), and of course, my family's ironclad dinner-time curfew (absolutely non-negotiable).

By the time I entered the picture, the Victorio Peak treasure had become a labyrinthine legal nightmare. The Noss family had lost all access to the Peak, thanks to Uncle Sam deciding what America really needed to defend democracy was a mountain with a highly disputed cache of Spanish gold. In 1955, they simply folded Victorio Peak into their missile range, presumably while humming *This Land Is Your Land* without a trace of irony.

Fast forward to 1991, when the unthinkable happened—the Noss family got the access they had been fighting for over many years. We're talking a real, bona fide Act of Congress, complete with a signature from President George H. W. Bush himself. For a kid whose idea of high-stakes negotiation was trying to bargain for a later bedtime, this was earth-shattering news.

My gold fever reached new heights when Dad somehow finagled an invitation to the Ova Noss Family Partnership investor gathering in Las Cruces. There we stood, my father and I, among the Noss clan themselves, drinking in their plans to challenge the military and unearth the treasure like it was the sweetest lemonade on a scorching desert day. I absorbed every word, eyes wider than dinner plates. I was already imagining myself rappelling into Victorio Peak's mysterious depths, my headlamp revealing heaps of gold bars.



Teenage me trying to play it cool with Terry Delonas at the Ova Noss Family Partnership meeting—back when I was all elbows and dreams of treasure hunting.

Reality, however, came crashing down like an ACME anvil on Wile E. Coyote's head when the expedition was declared strictly adults-only. The injustice! There I was, a boy with more curiosity than a cat convention, relegated to sniffing around the edges of a military base like a hyperactive bloodhound. I found myself sulking on the sidelines, my dreams of adventure reduced to eavesdropping on grown-up conversations, again. It felt like being invited to Willy

Wonka's Chocolate Factory only to discover you're lactose intolerant and the elevator's broken.

But here's the thing about childhood dreams: they don't die easily. They smolder like embers in a campfire, waiting for the right gust of wind to bring them back to life. And sometimes, they ignite in the most spectacular—and spectacularly ill-advised—fashion.

As I watched the adults buzz with excitement over their plans, something shifted inside me. The bitter pill of exclusion dissolved into a familiar sweetness of determination. If they wouldn't let me join their treasure hunt, I'd just have to launch my own.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Digging Debacle

So there I stood, on the wrong side of a chain-link fence, squinting at distant peaks. And in that moment of adolescent hubris, I asked myself a question that has launched a thousand ill-advised adventures: *What would the Hardy Boys do?*

Armed with the imaginary blessing of Frank and Joe Hardy, I initiated phase one of my brilliant plan: recruit Brandon. Now, my brother was the kind of kid who'd eat a live scorpion if you dared him—his sense of self-preservation apparently lost somewhere between conception and birth. Convincing him to join my nocturnal treasure hunt proved easier than getting sunburned in the New Mexico summer.

"We'll be like ninjas," I whispered, as if the C.I.A. had bugged our Lego collection. "Ninja treasure hunters."

Brandon's eyes lit up. "Cool," he replied, with that perfect

monosyllabic enthusiasm that serves as Shakespeare-level eloquence among pre-teen boys.

And so, under the cover of darkness, we hopped on our bicycles and pedaled toward White Sands Missile Range. Our arsenal consisted of Grandpa Posey's rusty pickaxe, which looked like it had last seen action during the Gold Rush, a shovel I'm pretty sure was older than Grandpa, and an immeasurable amount of misplaced confidence.

But as we approached the perimeter, our bravado evaporated. The place had more security than Fort Knox hosting a sleepover with Area 51. Floodlights carved through the desert night, and I swear I heard the rhythmic thump of combat boots even over the pounding of my heart.

Brandon, displaying a sudden and wildly inconvenient outbreak of common sense, muttered, "Maybe this wasn't such a good idea."

He had a point. Our chances of sneaking in undetected were about as good as finding a snowball in Death Valley. With heavy hearts and heavier tools, we pedaled back home, our dreams of treasure temporarily dashed against the rocks of military-grade security and our own staggering incompetence.

But a Posey doesn't give up that easily. No sir, we just pivot to an equally improbable plan B. In this case: tunneling under the fence. I spent a week sketching out plans that would have made El Chapo proud and civil engineers weep, envisioning a subterranean

highway to hidden riches. After exploratory digs at the edge of Grandpa's property yielded nothing but sore muscles, a collection of uniquely shaped rocks, and one very confused gopher, I was forced to confront some hard truths. At our current rate of progress, we'd reach Victorio Peak sometime around my tricentennial birthday. And that's assuming we didn't hit bedrock, or a water main, or some long-lost underground civilization of prairie dogs with their own missile defense system.

Sitting in my modest crater, caked in dirt and disappointment, I had to admit that perhaps Plan B was slightly impractical. The shovel, once a proud symbol of my treasure-hunting ambitions, now seemed to mock me with its muddy indifference. I half expected it to sprout cartoon arms and start slow-clapping.

I also had to confront the thought that perhaps this particular approach might, well, land us in a hole we couldn't dig ourselves out of. The mental image of my family visiting me in federal prison, shaking their heads with that unique blend of disappointment and barely suppressed amusement, finally cooled my tunneling ambitions. My father would probably just sigh and mutter something about how he should have pushed harder for summer math camp.

As I climbed out of my pit of shame, I couldn't help but think that real treasure hunters never had to worry about being grounded or losing their allowance. Indiana Jones never had to explain to his

grandmother why he was tracking mud across her freshly vacuumed carpet, or why the backyard suddenly resembled the aftermath of a drunken frat party whose pledges were gophers and moles.

With my dreams of subterranean success thoroughly buried (along with my dignity and several earthworms who'd made poor real estate choices), I knew it was time to return to the drawing board. After all, there had to be a way into that base that didn't involve becoming an amateur excavator or risking an intimate encounter with the business end of an army flashlight.

Fortunately, I still had plenty of equally terrible ideas.

The Tour Trap

After reviewing my arsenal of terrible ideas, I landed on a brilliantly simple plan: join a public tour of the base, then get conveniently “lost.” Don’t ask me how two unsupervised boys managed to sign up for a tour of The White Sands Missile Range. Let’s just say it involved some creative form-filling and brazen confidence. But there we were, Brandon and I, strolling onto a military base with all the nonchalance of two cats trying to blend in at the Westminster Dog Show.

As we approached the visitor center, I whispered to Brandon, “Remember, we’re just two normal kids on a normal tour. Nothing suspicious about us at all.” He nodded, then promptly tripped over his own feet, nearly face-planting into the “Welcome to White Sands Missile Range” sign.



Brandon and I carving paths down the gypsum dunes at White Sands National Park.

The Airman leading our group droned on about missile specifications and Cold War history. Meanwhile, my heart was doing its best timpani drum impression, certain that any second someone would yell “Security breach!” and we’d be starring in an episode of COPS. I nodded at what I hoped were the appropriate moments, trying to play the part of World’s Most Interested Tourist. Brandon on the other hand, with eyes glazed over, apparently had fallen victim to the tour guide’s monotone delivery.

“And here we have Building 7,” our guide announced, gesturing to what looked like the architectural equivalent of a yawn. “This is where we conduct most of our classified research operations.”

My ears perked up like a dog hearing a potato chip bag. Classified research? That had to be where they were keeping the treasure! I elbowed Brandon, who had perfected the art of micro-napping while vertical. “Target acquired,” I whispered, trying to sound like the spies in those movies Dad pretended we weren’t allowed to watch.

Then, as if the universe was feeling generous, our guide turned to answer a question about missile fuel capacities. This was our moment. With a silent nod, we made our move. We slipped away from the group with all the stealth of two ninjas who had trained exclusively via YouTube tutorials.

For exactly three and a half seconds, I thought we were golden. Victorio Peak, here we come! The sweet taste of success was on my lips—until I felt a hand clamp down on my shoulder like a steel trap catching a dim-witted rabbit. Ah, yes. The Military Police. Of course. Because what’s a half-baked plan without the coup de grâce of getting caught red-handed? As we were frog-marched off the base, I had time for one coherent thought: This is going to be harder than I thought.

The MP escorting us looked like he could bench-press a Humvee. His mustache alone probably had more combat experience than the entire cast of *G.I. Joe*.

“State your purpose for being outside the designated tour zone,” he said, voice stern but eyes betraying a hint of sparkle he quickly

suppressed.

I swallowed hard, my voice cracking in that special way that happens when you're thirteen and terrified. "We were...uh...looking for the bathroom, sir?"

The MP crossed his arms and deepened his frown. "The bathroom. That's what you're going with?"

Brandon snapped to attention like a rubber band. He puffed up his skinny chest and took a half-step forward. "Permission to speak freely, First General Commander Sir!"

The MP coughed suddenly, turning it into a gruff "Granted" that didn't quite hide a suppressed laugh.

"Well, your excellency sir, those MREs in the mess hall? They've got us at, um..." He paused, clearly cycling through his mental database of military terms from Saturday morning cartoons, "...DEFCON Level Red Alert Alpha Six, sir! And also, my mom says fiber is important!"

The MP turned away sharply, his shoulders shaking in what he covered with an unconvincing coughing fit. When he turned back, his face was a masterpiece of forced severity. "Son," he said, "I've eaten MREs in three different combat zones, and not once did they cause me to infiltrate a restricted area."

He unclipped his radio, taking a beat as he composed himself. "Sierra Alpha, this is Victor Three. I've got two..." he paused, and this time I definitely saw him fighting a smile, "...very junior

unauthorized personnel in custody. How copy?"

As the radio crackled its response, he put on his sternest face yet. "Now, you boys understand this is a serious situation, correct?"

We nodded vigorously, trying to look as solemn as possible while Brandon's shoes squeaked nervously against the floor.

"And you know I'm going to have to call your parents?"

More nodding. The MP's mustache twitched again as he added gravely, "And you're aware that unauthorized entry into a restricted military facility is not an appropriate solution to..." he paused for maximum effect, "...digestive concerns?"

I wanted to die right there.

As we sat in the security office, waiting for Dad to arrive and undoubtedly ground us until the next ice age, I marveled at how quickly a plan could go south.

Dad arrived looking like he'd aged ten years in the car ride over. As the MP explained our attempted great escape, I swear I could see Dad's hair turning grayer by the second.

"I'm very disappointed in you boys," Dad said, his voice carrying that special kind of parental disappointment that makes you wish the ground would open up and swallow you whole.

Later that night at my grandparents' house, while I was supposedly confined to my room, I crept to the back porch screen door and heard them talking outside. Dad was recounting the day's events.

“You should’ve seen it. Sweet-talked their way onto the tour, and made it halfway to the research building before getting caught.”

“Sounds familiar,” Grandma said with a laugh. “Though at least they were more creative than you were at their age. Remember when you tried sneaking into that old mine when we lived in Animas? Claimed you were doing a school report on mining history?”

“Of course I grounded them—what kind of father would I be if I didn’t?” Then he added more softly, “But between us? That’s my boys.”

I tip-toed back to my room, with a single thought: Third time’s a charm.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Paternal Ploy

A few months later, nursing my wounded pride, and with a newfound wariness of men in uniform, I stumbled upon what I was sure was my golden ticket. I'd discovered another way onto the Range through a neighboring rancher's land. The plan was elegant in its simplicity, requiring only a smidgen of trespassing and the usual disregard for personal safety.

To most people, the words "trespassing" and "military base" in the same sentence might raise a red flag. But to a kid with treasure fever, it was about as concerning as jaywalking or using "your" instead of "you're" in a text message.

I found Brandon in our shared bedroom, sprawled across his bed, deeply engrossed in a book. "Hey, dude," I said, trying to sound casual and probably achieving the vocal equivalent of a giraffe on roller skates. "Remember that treasure we've been trying to find?"

Brandon lowered his book and squinted. "Yeah, and I also remember being hauled off by MPs. What's your point?"

I grinned, undeterred. "Well, what if I told you I found another way onto the Range?"

"I'd say you're crazier than a sun-stroked roadrunner," Brandon replied. But I noticed he put down his book entirely.

"Come on," I pressed, warming to my theme. "Don't you want to see what's inside that peak? It could be our ticket to fortune!"

Brandon sat up, a mix of interest and skepticism on his face I'd come to recognize as his "I know this is a bad idea but I'm probably going to do it anyway" look.

"And how exactly do you plan on getting us in this time? Another tour? Because I'm pretty sure we're on some kind of watch list now."

I waved my hand dismissively. "Nah, nothing like that. I found a way in through a neighboring ranch on the backside of the range. It's foolproof!"

"Foolproof, huh? Like the time you said using mom's good tablecloth as a parachute was foolproof?"

I winced at the memory. The tablecloth had survived. Our dignity, and Dad's prized rose bushes, had not.

"This is different. We're talking centuries of history here!"

Brandon was quiet for a moment, and I could almost see the gears turning in his head. I imagined little Brandon-shaped brain cells

weighing the pros (adventure, possible riches) against the cons (grounding until retirement age, potential arrest).

Finally, he sighed, a sound that conveyed resignation. “You know we’re probably going to get in trouble, right?”

I grinned, sensing victory. “Probably. But just think of the regret we’d have if we didn’t at least try. Goonies never say die!”

“Alright,” Brandon conceded, a smile tugging at the corners of his mouth. “But if we get caught, I’m telling Mom it was all your idea.”

“Deal,” I said, reaching out to shake his hand.

Our odds of success were somewhere between slim and none, but when did that ever stop a Posey? After securing Brandon’s reluctant partnership, the next phase of my master plan required patience (we had to wait for a visit to see the grandparents), and a delicate touch—convincing Dad to be our unwitting accomplice.

Asking your father to serve as getaway driver requires a certain... finesse. I found him reclining in Grandpa’s armchair with the *Alamagordo Daily News*.

“Hey, Dad,” I started, employing what I thought was my most winning smile. “How would you feel about taking Brandon and me on a little drive this Saturday?”

He lowered his paper slightly, one eyebrow raised in that universal dad expression that says, “I know you’re up to something.”

"A drive where, exactly?" he asked.

"Oh, you know," I said, waving my hand in a casual manner, "just out to this ranch near the Range. To talk to the rancher. About... ranch stuff."

"Ranch stuff," Dad repeated flatly.

"Yeah. It's for, uh...a school project."

To my eternal surprise, instead of shutting down my poorly disguised plotting, he folded his newspaper and smiled. It was the kind of smile that made me wonder if I wasn't the only one playing chess here.

"Sure," he said, far too easily. "I'll drive you boys out there on Saturday."

I stood there blinking, thrown off balance by his quick agreement. "Really?" I asked, unable to keep the disbelief from my voice.

"Really," he confirmed, picking his newspaper back up with an air of satisfaction that should have sent warning bells ringing through my treasure-obsessed brain. "Sometimes a father needs to let his sons learn things for themselves."

Looking back, I should have noticed the amusement in his voice, the twinkle in his eye that spelled imminent life lesson. But at that moment, all I could think was that I was a genius and phase two of Operation Fence Hop was officially a go.

The moment of truth arrived on an overcast spring Saturday. The sky was contemplating whether to rain or just sulk. Dad chauffeured

Brandon and me to the front gates of the ranch, our would-be portal to adventure. As the three of us approached the door, I held my breath, wondering who awaited us on the other side. I anticipated someone with the personality of an ornery rattlesnake; but the rancher who appeared was less “villainous adversary” and more “cowboy Santa Claus after a rough ride.” His face was a topographical map of a life lived outdoors, each wrinkle a story of sun, wind, and probably a fair bit of exasperation with city folks who thought cows were just really big dogs. His name escapes me... I think it was Niven, or maybe Gnarled Oak Come to Life. He greeted us with a nod, his weathered hands absentmindedly fiddling with a set of what must have been eighteen to twenty keys on an old brass ring.

Dad began weaving his web of words, his voice a melody of reason and charm that would have made a used car salesman take notes. Brandon and I stood there, channeling all our energy into looking angelic. As Dad worked his linguistic voodoo, the rancher’s gruff exterior softened like a marshmallow left too close to the campfire. He let slip the west side of the Range, right along his fence line, had markedly less security than the rest of the base. My heart leapt. *There’s still a chance*, I thought, crossing my fingers so hard I nearly sprained them.

Just as hope began to bloom, the rancher informed us the last group of wannabe Indiana Joneses who entered “was on the Military

Police's radar in no time." I could almost hear the sad trombone playing in the background. And just like that, all my dreams of treasure and glory vanished, leaving behind nothing but the faint residue of disappointment and the lingering scent of cattle.

As we made the drive back to my grandparents' house, I stared out the window, watching the desert roll by, every line of fence a mocking reminder of my failed adventure. It was then that Dad revealed his endgame, gently suggesting I back off because "breaking onto a military base is a federal crime no matter your age." The realization hit me like an ACME anvil: He knew we weren't getting in, and this whole expedition had been an elaborate life lesson, gift-wrapped in the guise of adventure. I'd been dad-tricked.

I slumped in my seat, defeated but not entirely deflated. After much begging and pleading, punctuated by dramatic sighs that would make a soap opera star proud, I finally agreed to give it a rest...at least until I could hatch another plan.

As we pulled into my grandparents' driveway, Dad turned to me, sympathetic and amused. "You know, son, sometimes the real treasure is the federal crimes we don't commit along the way."

I rolled my eyes so hard I saw my own brain. But hey, at least we weren't in jail. Of course, that didn't mean I was giving up. Oh no. This Posey had merely been temporarily outfoxed. The siren call of hidden treasure still echoed in my ears.

Rearview Riches

Just when I thought I'd exhausted every harebrained scheme in my treasure-hunting playbook, my cousin Eddie dropped a nugget of information about oryx hunting on the Range. Brandon and I had seen a few of these African antelopes prancing around the area. But what caught my attention wasn't the bizarre presence of African wildlife in New Mexico; it was the magic words "legal way" and "private citizens" in the same sentence as "get onto White Sands Missile Range." It was like hearing "free candy" and "no cavities" in the same breath.

Eddie, unknowingly playing the role of treasure hunting fairy godmother, explained that the base held lottery drawings for oryx hunting permits. These granted hunters mostly unsupervised access to vast swathes of the Range. They even offered multi-day hunt passes, and you could bring friends. It was as if the universe had

heard my pleadings and decided to throw me a bone.

With all the eagerness of a kid writing to Santa, I applied for a permit. In the weeks that followed, I checked the mail with such frequency that our postman started to eye me suspiciously, probably wondering if I was running some sort of illicit pen-pal ring or had developed an unhealthy obsession with junk mail. Alas, the hunting gods (or more likely, the exasperated Range administrators who recognized my handwriting) were not smiling upon me. Permit after permit was drawn, and my name remained conspicuously absent from the list of lucky hunters. Perhaps it was my age that disqualified me. Or maybe Brandon and I had earned ourselves a spot on the “No Permit List.” I could almost picture it: a crudely drawn wanted poster with our faces, captioned “Do not allow these idiots back on the base under any circumstances, even if they claim to be ‘really into oryx hunting’ all of a sudden.”

And so, with a heavy heart and a bruised ego, it was back to the old drawing board. The years rolled by like tumbleweeds in the desert wind, yet my obsession with Victorio Peak endured. Each passing season brought a new scheme more outlandish than the last. I claimed to be writing a school paper (Mrs. Herbein never assigned it). Tried joining the Civil Air Patrol (they don’t actually let cadets pilot spy planes). Faked archaeological credentials (they make phone calls to verify credentials). Even wrote to NASA about my innovative “personal photography satellite” (they don’t take

sketches on notebook paper).

But no matter how elaborate the plan or how close I thought I was getting, Victorio Peak remained tantalizingly out of reach, a shimmering mirage always dancing just beyond the horizon.



Every lead I followed about the Victorio Peak treasure.

At the Alamogordo Walmart, I watched a kid named Kevin get dragged away from the camping gear aisle. He was clutching a compass like it was the key to every mystery in the Sacramento Mountains. His mom was going on about how they're already late for soccer practice. And I witnessed the exact moment his eyes dimmed, and the fire of his wanderlust died out.

It hit me harder than one of Brandon's "accidental" elbow jabs. After all my failed missions, close calls with MPs, and Dad's life

lessons, I finally understood. The real curse of Victorio Peak isn't that the gold is hard to find—it's that people stop looking for it. They trade their treasure maps for Google Maps, their expedition plans for Excel spreadsheets, until one day they're installing Ring cameras to catch porch pirates instead of hunting for Spanish gold.

That cavern is still down there, of course. Right where it's always been, laughing at our satellite imagery and ground-penetrating radar. Kevin, wherever you are, it's not too late!

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Bandit Banquet

I declared myself the Jane Goodall of raccoons the day my father stood among his ravaged tomato plants, surveying the aftermath of another midnight raid. The summer sun had scorched the desert into submission, a merciless heat that left even the saguaros thirsting for relief. Dad examined the half-eaten tomatoes with a detective's precision, though I caught the whisper of a smile playing at his lips. "They're getting better at this," he mused, mental blueprints already unfurling for the next crop. His "sophisticated early warning system"—tin cans strewn like metallic confetti—dotted the garden, a glinting tribute to our persistent midnight visitors.

I unearthed Sterling North's *Rascal* in the depths of Tanque Verde Elementary's library, where javelinas sometimes crashed our lunch breaks, strutting across the playground like they owned it. The building rose from the desert floor like a native species, all sun-

scorched brick and windows hazed by generations of dust devils. *Rascal* described a human-raccoon friendship, the sort of thing I was prone to take as an instruction manual.

Behind her desk fan, the librarian tracked my selection, her beige institutional sentinel festooned with paper cacti and roadrunners that pirouetted in the manufactured wind. “You know that’s set in Wisconsin, dear,” she said, as if raccoons checked maps at state borders. “In 1918,” she added, no doubt contemplating a call to my father.

But it was too late. The book had already worked its magic, conjuring visions of grandeur: me and my furry accomplice, strutting down school hallways while lesser mortals clutched their mundane hamsters at show-and-tell. Our local raccoons had already proven themselves worthy, orchestrating nightly raids with military precision, an elite squadron of masked bandits.

My brother Brandon, gifted with what we called his *animal sense*, stepped naturally into the role of chief wildlife ambassador. This was the kid who’d mastered animal sounds before English, who’d once calmed a frantic hawk with quiet chirps and whistles until it let Dad untangle it from the fence. He brought this same gentle focus to our raccoon project, developing a language of soft trills and purrs that our masked visitors seemed to understand perfectly.

“They’re saying the fish sticks beat the garden tomatoes,” he’d announce at dinner, his plate forgotten as he studied the backyard

through the window. Dad would nod, sage-like, while sliding extra portions onto our plates. “Your grandfather used to feed the javelina,” he’d remind us, settling into yet another tale of our family’s questionable wildlife adventures.

Our first breakthrough arrived at the neighbor’s barbecue down the street. While adults debated the virtues of grilled portobello mushrooms (this was Tucson in the ’90s, when vegetarianism ranked as rebellion, right between Claire’s ear piercings and Nirvana albums), we spotted them: two raccoons prowling the roofline, moving with the easy assurance of frequent dinner guests.

“They’re so graceful,” I whispered.

“They’re debating who gets the last burger,” Brandon translated, tilting his head as if tuning into their frequency.

From that moment on, I was perpetually “on a diet,” which was less about counting calories and more about stockpiling offerings for what Brandon dubbed “making friends.” Each night, I’d arrange our contributions in the weathered white plastic bowl with the careful precision of a food stylist. Dad’s enthusiasm bloomed with each raccoon encounter. Soon he was leaving his own offerings—garden vegetables he claimed were “below market standards” but gleamed with suspicious perfection. “It’s called peaceful coexistence,” he’d declare from his lawn chair throne, observing our nightly rituals. “Besides, they’ve got better table manners than your Uncle Hiram.”

Brandon named our nocturnal friends with a translator’s

intuition. The largest became Professor Pudge for his “teacher energy,” the way he demonstrated jar-opening techniques to younger raccoons with endless patience. The one with the notched ear was crowned Bandit King. Brandon explained with a flawless raccoon chitter that “he’s got stories to tell.” Shadow Feet earned his title after Brandon counted seventeen silent steps across our patio, each one flowing like liquid moonlight.

Was our amateur venture into wildlife taming wise? Most certainly not. But childhood runs on wonder, not wisdom, and hindsight holds no power over a heart full of discovery. We positioned our lawn chairs each evening like astronomers charting celestial events, creeping closer to the feeding zone night by night. Then came the evening we watched, spellbound, as Professor Pudge demonstrated the art of sliding open our patio door—a skill whose implications should have concerned us more than they did.

It felt like joining a secret society the night I first hand-fed Professor Pudge a fish stick. His tiny hands accepted it with Oscar-winner grace, while the other raccoons watched like a masked academy audience. Our backyard transformed into their private club after that, featuring what Brandon called “friendship exercises”—really just us watching them decode increasingly complex Tupperware puzzles.

We should have seen it coming when Professor Pudge missed his usual dinner appointment. Like a casino noticing its most reliable

high roller had vanished—never a promising sign. But there I slept in my pizza pajamas, until a symphony of opening cabinets and rattling containers jolted me awake. Down the hallway I crept, my heart drumming a duet of excitement and dread. Then I spotted them: sooty paw prints marking the path to our kitchen, a treasure map of mischief.



The light switch revealed a midnight banquet at its peak. The Professor perched atop the refrigerator, conducting his orchestra of chaos with aristocratic paw waves. Bandit King stood frozen, one paw in the cookie jar—literally. Shadow Feet had claimed the sink as his personal water park, caught mid-splash in his first ecstatic encounter with indoor plumbing. In the corner, three junior raccoons formed a swaying ladder, inching toward the cabinet, the bottom one's face clearly saying, "I really should have called in sick today." The moment hung suspended, the word "Dad" forming on my lips just above a whisper.

I bolted down the hall, shifting into full voice: "Dad! The raccoons have gone rogue!"

Dad emerged like a pajama-clad St. George, wielding our household's universal weapon against intruders: the broom. He looked less like a defender of the realm and more like someone who'd wandered into the wrong bedtime story.

Brandon appeared next, instantly slipping into his role as raccoon hostage negotiator with a stream of chirps and chitters. "They say they're sorry," he translated, watching our tuxedoed guests plot their exit. "But also that the cookies were definitely worth it."

I flung open the sliding door, offering escape. The great raccoon exodus that followed would have impressed both Moses and David Attenborough. They streamed through our house like a furry flash

mob in reverse—some clutching stolen treasures, others maintaining expressions of dignified denial. As the final tail vanished into darkness, Professor Pudge paused at the threshold. He fixed me with an unmistakably professorial look and—I swear on my complete collection of nature documentaries—adjusted imaginary glasses before melting into the night.

The next morning, Dad sealed the chimney flue while Brandon sent apologies toward the cottonwood tree beyond our fence. “Maybe we should have started with something smaller,” Dad mused. “Like coyotes.”

Years later, I discovered that old white bowl behind the garage, its battle scars chronicling adventures like rings in a tree trunk. I considered putting it out, just for old times’ sake, but some experiments belong in the hypothesis stage.

Sometimes, in the quiet of night, I swear I hear Brandon’s old raccoon greeting echoing in the darkness. I still double-check the flue every night. You never know when Professor Pudge might decide it’s time for a remedial lesson.

Reluctant Roommates

Aidan and I were thrust together as reluctant step-siblings when his mother and my father fell in love and merged our households. We were the same age, and both accustomed to bossing around a younger sibling (in his case: Aaron, same age as Brandon). Thus began a new chapter in sibling symbiosis: the four of us bickered and brawled our way through childhood. We swung between loyal conspirators and mortal enemies with an intensity that could have powered a small village.

On a day when even lizards sought shade, my dad broke through our summer stupor with a challenge worthy of young Indiana Jones: *The Great Quail Egg Quest of the American Southwest*. The objective was as clear as it was absurd: scour the brush for the sacred treasures of quail nests. The motivation? Pure, unadulterated childlike wonder—or perhaps just a father's clever plot to get us out of the house for

a spell.



Brandon, Dad, and I looking at a desert tortoise nestled alongside a rock outcropping.

My Dad, ever the pragmatist, armed us against vipers with sturdy walking sticks for prodding the thorny brush. Stick-laden and naively optimistic, we prowled the desert like prospectors chasing gold. Then came Aidan's triumphant cry. We stampeded toward his treasure, but Aidan—self-crowned lord of the eggs—transformed into a greedy dragon, shielding his spotted clutch with fierce

possession.

In that moment, something ancient awoke in me—a surge of prehistoric injustice that demanded blood. With a barbaric yawp, I raised my stick like a caveman’s club and brought it crashing down upon his crown, fueled by betrayal’s white-hot rage.

The moment Aidan turned, regret flooded my veins. He possessed a glare that sent shivers tap-dancing down the spine of even the most hardened playground warrior. That look—his signature harbinger of doom—would begin with color climbing his cheeks like mercury in a desert thermometer. His lips would seal into a bloodless line, and his eyes...oh, those eyes would empty like a politician’s promises, pools of terrifying calm before the storm.

His fury was mythic—the kind that wouldn’t just rain on your parade but atomize your float with lightning. To hesitate was to dance with death, for when Aidan wore that face, every child knew: run.

Without thought, my feet devoured earth as I bolted for sanctuary. The world condensed to heartbeats and ragged breath, to the desperate rhythm of survival. My one backward glance revealed Aidan transformed—a dust devil made flesh, spinning with focused rage, stick raised high, bearing down on me with the fury of a desert storm.

My salvation lay in jackrabbit legs and a sprinter’s grace. If I could reach the adults, breach parental jurisdiction, I might survive

this. I burst into the house, holding my breath to track our parents' voices. Their murmurs drifted from a back bedroom, blissfully unaware of the frenzy at their doorstep.

When Aidan crossed the front door's threshold, I was already in the bedroom. I vaulted onto the top bunk and sat cross-legged, feigning meditation while my heart hammered against my ribs. Then came Aidan, fury incarnate, bursting into the room with wild eyes and raised stick, like a berserker in a quiet suburb. He lunged for my ankle, determined to drag me down to meet my fate.

Our parents intervened with startled authority, their presence a temporary shield. Without their timely appearance, I suspect my future would have contained significantly fewer birthdays.

But peace in our warzone was mere illusion. Aidan, you see, was not one to forgive and forget. Like a patient predator, he slipped back into the shadows of our shared space, waiting. Revenge was not a matter of if, but when. There's a special kind of dread that comes with knowing someone has nothing but time and sibling spite to plot their payback. One cannot maintain vigilance forever, so I clung to the adults like a living shield, hoping their presence might delay the inevitable.

The logic seemed sound—at least I convinced myself it was. Days later, our family sat in Piccadilly Cafeteria, where I foolishly believed the clatter of trays and murmur of elderly voices would protect me.

But safety, like youth, proved fleeting. Halfway through my

Salisbury steak, Aidan pivoted with sudden grace and landed a punch that sent me tumbling from the booth—my pride hitting the floor well before my body.

It was one of those moments when I watched my father's composure shatter, each fragment a silent witness to his tested patience. The line had been crossed—Aidan knew it the instant my father's eyes met his. His apologies tumbled out like water from a broken dam, spurred by Father's swift justice. After that, Aidan's warfare evolved; respect for paternal authority, seasoned with a dash of fear, brought a new wisdom to our brotherly battles.

* * *

Mount Lemmon presided over our childhood like a reticent grandparent: silent and watchful, draped in forests instead of afghans, crowned with snow instead of silver hair. Our pilgrimages up the mountain were half-hearted stabs at holiday card perfection, or at least escapes from the inferno below, where Tucson simmered like a copper pot.

The ascent was a tour of nature's costume changes. First came the saguaros, standing with raised arms like botanical stick-ups. Then—as if God had flipped channels—grasslands rolled to the horizon. A few more twisting turns delivered us through oak and juniper until we reached the ponderosa pines, where Arizona played dress-up as

Colorado. And yes, there was even a ski lift, proud holder of the title “southernmost place to freeze your ass off in the lower forty-eight.”

One autumn day our family drove to the base of Mount Lemmon. While the adults spread out a blanket, the four of us—me, Brandon, Aidan, and Aaron—traced a trail along the mountain’s edge. The air held that sharp mountain clarity, laced with sun-warmed pine and whispers of adventure. When clouds gathered overhead like circling vultures, we should have turned back, but Aidan swore we could reach the next vista before the storm struck. Wind rose through the ponderosas, its voice like distant rapids.

Thunder rolled across the peaks, and we counted seconds until lightning split the sky—our private game of chicken with nature’s wrath.

“Four seconds,” Aaron called after the next rumble. “That’s like... a mile away, right?”

Brandon kept pushing for retreat, but there’s a strange magic in watching a storm descend from a mountain’s crown. Below us, the world vanished beneath a gray veil of rain while we stood like the last petroglyphs catching light before darkness fell.

We lingered too long. The first drops were pleasant pitter patter; then the sky split wide and rain fell in silver sheets. We bolted down the trail, our feet betrayed by slick stone and mud. Lightning fractured the air above us, thunder its instant echo—the sound ricocheting off canyon walls like nature’s cannon crew.

Aidan, our would-be weatherman, looked like a drowned rat. Aaron laughed through the rain streaming down his face, while Brandon muttered dark theories about natural selection. And me? I grinned like a fool, my heart dancing with the wild thrill of it all.

We reached the car looking like creatures from the deep—four drenched boys with mud to our knees. Our parents just shook their heads with that timeless parental exasperation that said everything without saying a word.

The safety lecture would come later. For now, we huddled in the car, heater roaring against the storm beyond our windows, basking in the glow of something magnificent. We'd perched on that mountain peak and watched heaven battle earth. Reckless? Absolutely. Stupid? Without question. The kind of moment that could've turned tragic, and somewhere in us, we knew it. But we were young then, when danger was just a word—something that happened to other people, in other stories.

Mount Lemmon was our Narnia, where Aidan and I found peace in thin air. Something about the altitude transformed us into actual brothers. Up there, we were explorers, adventurers, lords of misrule in a kingdom of pinecones and crisp air. Even now, I feel that mountain chill on my cheeks—that fierce kiss of cold that was both sting and sweetness. Those moments of shared shivers are the ones that linger—just kids painting our days with mud and stick-sword battles, launching stolen pinecones while our laughter bounced off

canyon walls that seemed to share our secret joy.

Aidan and I have long since vacated the battlefield. The war drums that once echoed through our halls have softened to life's steady rhythm, our sticks and schemes traded for the unspoken truce of adulthood.

As dusk settles on these recollections, the past folding back upon itself like the pages of a well-worn memoir, the edges of my childhood fray a bit more with each year. Our battles and truces have slipped into the soft focus of nostalgia, where even the sharpest of edges dull into something resembling fondness.

Here's to Aidan, my old nemesis turned brother. Here's to the fierce heart of the Sonoran Desert and Mount Lemmon that shaped our wild young days. And here's to youth's strange magic, when every morning held adventure and every fight was just prelude to peace.

The Lost Liberators

As a child, I was the proud steward of a used White's metal detector—a contraption so weathered and ancient it might have detected itself. Most kids my age boasted about their Super Nintendo high scores or traded tips on defeating Bowser (skills I'd quietly mastered between homework assignments). But during my weeks at Dad's house, I had chosen a different path to glory: searching for treasure by waving a dented metal pole over empty lots in the Tucson heat.



Two generations of treasure hunters combing the neighborhood with my prized White's metal detector.

I was also a Cub Scout back then, nominally attached to a pack that met across the street from Tanque Verde Elementary School (now Emily Gray Junior High School). While other cubs mastered

the intricacies of square knots and folding flags—achievements that seemed to consume endless afternoons—I was drawn to the nearby vacant lots, sweeping my metal detector back and forth in methodical passes, grid searching even then.

Between the metallic chirps of my detector and the desert wind, I imagined myself unearthing Spanish doubloons or, at the very least, enough lost quarters to fund a respectable comic book collection. The reality usually involved bottle caps and the occasional penny, sun-bleached and sand-scoured into anonymity. But twice I stumbled upon something extraordinary: massive bullets that dwarfed any ammunition I'd ever seen, looking more like miniature missiles than anything that belonged in a gun. I remember how they felt in my palm: heavy with history, cool despite the desert heat, their oxidized surfaces rough against my fingers.



I raced home to Dad with my finds. He examined the bullets with raised eyebrows and a thoughtful whistle, turning them over in his hands. For once, my father—a man who had a witty comeback for everything—was speechless. He just kept turning them over, weighing them in his palm. They became permanent residents on the shelf above my bed.

My weeks alternated between two kinds of exploration. At mom's, the NEC desktop hummed away, casting a glow across the room. While other kids were mastering *Super Mario*, I was navigating the surreal landscapes of *Myst*, piecing together its cryptic puzzles with the same methodical patience I applied to my metal detecting. When I wasn't island-hopping through that game's

mysterious Ages, I was orchestrating time-traveling capers in *Day of the Tentacle*, coordinating actions between characters scattered across America's past, present, and future. There was something poetic about manipulating time through a computer while searching for history in the desert—both pursuits required solving puzzles using artifacts from different eras. When not saving the world from evil tentacles, I was helping Indiana Jones uncover the secrets of Atlantis—games that seemed to reward the same kind of systematic curiosity that drove me to grid-search those desert lots.

The computer itself became another kind of archaeological site. I spent hours excavating the layers of Windows 3.1, trying to understand how each component functioned, why Program Manager sometimes threw inexplicable errors, and what exactly made File Manager tick. Between marathon sessions of *Where in the World is Carmen Sandiego?* (played at home) and *The Oregon Trail* (played at school, usually ending in dysentery), I was slowly building my own understanding of how these machines worked. That summer, during typing classes at Agua Caliente Park, I discovered you could peer beneath the surface of any program by exploring directories, tweaking configuration files, and sometimes breaking things in enlightening ways. The computer, like my metal detector, became a tool for uncovering hidden things—though instead of bullets and bottle caps, I was finding system files and startup scripts.

Years passed, and my metal detector retired to the garage, where it probably spent its golden years detecting the gradual rust of my dad's forgotten toolbox. Then in 2016, while browsing online, I spotted an article that caused my heart to skip a beat. Those mysterious bullets were .50 caliber rounds, silent witnesses to a tragic mid-air collision between two B-24 Liberators in 1944. The cause? A pilot momentarily blinded by the glare of the same desert sun that had beaten down on me during my treasure hunting expeditions. The sun that once served as humanity's primary timekeeper had, in a cruel twist, stopped time permanently for those airmen.

Looking back, I realize I had been an accidental archaeologist, a diminutive historian armed with nothing more sophisticated than secondhand technology and boundless curiosity. While I never did find those Spanish doubloons, I had unknowingly uncovered something just as valuable: a tangible piece of history, a story that had waited patiently in the Tucson soil for decades until a kid with a metal detector stumbled upon its scattered remains. Adventure sometimes finds us in the most ordinary places. Those bullets, now forever transformed from mysterious objects into historical artifacts, remind me that stories surround us everywhere, and sometimes the most remarkable discoveries come when we're looking for something else entirely.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Tender Tornado

In elementary school, we marched like a brigade of undersized salespeople, crackling with miniature entrepreneurial dreams. From scented candles to gourmet popcorn, we pitched it all, treating commerce like hopscotch on the playground. Yet hindsight has peeled back the curtain: this wasn't corporate altruism—it was a venture orchestrated with children as unwitting foot soldiers.

Consider the math: American schools waltz with corporations to the tune of \$1.9 billion annually, according to the National Center for Education Statistics—a sum that dwarfs some nations' GDP. School-business partnerships: that peculiar mating dance, as American as cheeseburgers and creative accounting.

"We'll give you computers and textbooks," purrs the dapper corporation, "if your cafeteria exclusively serves our soda—enough sugar per can to fuel a rocket to Mars."

Here's the punch line: for every dollar these corporations sink into schools, they rake in nearly six times that amount, according to the Harvard Business Review. Schools get their pocket change—desperately needed, of course. But the real price? Students become walking billboards, their minds branded with logos before they can spell “credit score.”

It was in this corporate-sponsored childhood that I first glimpsed my true nature—not an obsession with money, but with the artistry of outsmarting systems that believed themselves foolproof.

The yearly fundraising assembly unfolded like a fever dream game show. At its heart stood the Money Machine: a transparent temple of swirling wind and currency. Make enough sales, and you'd earn your moment inside, where bills—ones, fives, tens, twenties, and the mythical hundred—danced around you like confetti in a thunderstorm. Top sellers got their thirty seconds of glory, snatching at cash while classmates whooped and hollered.

The rules seemed simple—until they weren't. One kid learned this when he tried smuggling a net into the machine. The corporate rep swooped in like a hawk: “No handheld devices—nets, sticky contraptions, or gloves of any kind.” As he trudged away, net dangling uselessly at his side, something clicked in my brain. The word “handheld” rang through my thoughts like a bell, and suddenly I saw what everyone else had overlooked: rules weren't walls, they were riddles waiting to be unraveled.

What followed was a year of quiet obsession—though “quiet” might be generous, given the shop vacuum’s endless howling in our garage. While other kids chased balls at recess, I hunched over contest rules like a lawyer possessed, mumbling about loopholes and wind resistance. At home, I’d spend hours coaxing dollar bills from my allowance through makeshift wind tunnels, testing materials for my master plan. My parents would peek in, sigh at another of my “experiments,” then retreat. I’d earned my reputation for peculiar projects—the attempted “perpetual motion machine” built from rubber bands and Mom’s kitchen timer still haunted their memories. This was just the latest chapter in their child’s encyclopedia of strange obsessions.

Wearable tech is all the rage today. But I was a forerunner in this field, even though my first cash-grabbing prototypes slumped into failure. Some fabrics stretched like a worn-out waistband, leaving the cash pocket shallow and useless. Others refused to bend into the crucial funnel shape I craved. But each collapse taught me something new, each flaw pointed toward perfection. When See’s Candy season bloomed, I hurled myself into sales with the focus of a scientist pursuing proof. Not for the money—no—but for the chance to test my theory, to dance between the lines of those rigorously crafted rules.

My Grandma Clements, Mom’s mom, became an accomplice—or perhaps my hapless business partner. I’d scoured the town for the

perfect material until inspiration struck: Grandma's knitting needles held the answer. When I begged for a specially made sweater, she saw only a grandson's interest in her craft. She knitted and sewed and stitched while I supervised. I can still see her now, bent over her Singer Featherweight, while I perched beside her like a cat watching cream, barely containing my glee as she unknowingly stitched the keystone of my master plan.



From left: Grandpa Posey, Mom and Dad (aka the bride and groom), Grandma Posey, and Grandma Clements in September of 1979.

Years later, when she discovered the true purpose of her handiwork, she'd laugh until tears streamed down her cheeks, dubbing me her "little stinker" with that uniquely grandmotherly

blend of exasperation and pride. She never suspected she was crafting my secret weapon—a sweater with a hidden wire rim that could blossom into a cash-catching basket in seconds. The fabric breathed like silk but caught like a spider’s web, each fiber engineered for minimal resistance and maximum yield. The pants emerged as a separate masterpiece—deep pockets reinforced to cradle more cash than a loan officer’s vault. Every stitch served its purpose, every modification plotted with watchmaker’s care.

Finally, after twelve months of plotting, my moment dawned. As I stepped into the Money Machine, the familiar screams swelled through the auditorium. But I stood motionless, watching, calculating. The bills began their ballet, and slowly, a pattern emerged—a circular flow from ceiling to floor, as steady as a metronome’s beat. That’s when I struck. The garment was activated by subtle movements in my shoulders and chest. “Look rep, no hands!”

The corporate rep’s expression morphed from boredom to bewilderment as my sweater unveiled its secret power. The wire rim unfurled like a flower opening to the sun, creating a perfect vortex for the swirling bills. I wasn’t just catching money—I was harvesting it with assembly-line precision.

When the buzzer wailed, the box stood nearly empty, and my pockets sagged with treasure. I’d like to say I played it cool, but truth be told, I beamed like a kid who’d stumbled into Christmas,

Easter, and their birthday rolled into one golden moment. The baffled rep studied my sweater with the intensity of an art critic at the Louvre. He couldn't mount an argument—my device wasn't handheld; it was worn. The rules, as they say, were the rules.



A tsunami of cheers crashed through the auditorium as I stepped

from the machine, my pockets heavy with vindication. The corporate rep's face cycled through emotions like a slot machine: confusion, disbelief, and finally—landing on the jackpot—grudging respect. I never learned what happened to the Money Machine rules after that day. By fall, I'd vanished into middle school, leaving behind only whispers of the kid who'd turned corporate rules into origami—folding them into exactly the shape I needed.

Looking back, I see that day less as a triumph of engineering and more as my first real taste of puzzle-solving's sweet nectar. The money was nice (what sixth grader doesn't dream of brief riches?), but the true victory whispered quieter—it lived in those midnight sessions with my grandmother, in the failed prototypes that now draw laughter, in the pure joy of finding doorways where others saw only walls. My “perfect scheme” might have bought me fleeting playground fame, but the real treasure was learning that solutions often hide in life's peripheral vision. And perhaps that's what my grandmother glimpsed in me all along: not just her little stinker with a peculiar fixation, but a child who'd dedicate a year to transforming yarn into a cash-catching contraption, simply to prove that impossible was just another puzzle waiting to be solved.

The Weepul Winners

Junior high was that delicate age when you start realizing the world isn't quite the sugary cereal commercial you thought it was. Just when you think you've outgrown the naïveté of elementary school, along comes the annual magazine sale extravaganza—yes, extravaganza, because nothing says “festive” quite like pushing glossy pages of home decor and celebrity gossip.

The annual Emily Gray Junior High School magazine sales event was a bit more complicated than the early years of selling candy for a chance to enter the Money Machine. The name of the game was the Weepul—that small, fuzzy, and strangely captivating creature that serves no practical purpose yet occupies an inexplicable space in the American collective consciousness. The Weepul is a promotional toy made of pom-pom-like material, complete with googly eyes and little felt feet. It's generally used as a marketing gimmick, given

away at trade shows and other occasions where swag items are distributed. Sometimes they have adhesive feet, allowing you to stick them to surfaces like your computer monitor, as if to say, “Hey, life isn’t so bad; look at this fluffy abomination smiling at you.”

Weepuls have a storied history, stretching back to the 1970s. They became wildly popular as fundraising tools in schools—yes, there’s that corporate tentacle in education again. Sell a magazine subscription, get a Weepul. They’re like carnival prizes: cheap to produce but somehow irresistible. Companies love them because they’re quirky enough to be memorable and inexpensive enough to be plentiful.

And that’s the odd charm of the Weepul. It doesn’t do anything, but it also doesn’t pretend to be anything other than what it is—a small, useless fuzzball that brightens your day, just a smidge. It’s a marketing ploy, sure, but it’s also an icon, a tiny, round testament to the power of kitsch in our lives.

But that wasn’t good enough for the magazine fundraising corporation. They needed that extra punch to drive kids to make every sale possible. The solution? Well, it was twofold:

First, they made the Weepul valuable, which is something like turning straw into gold. In homeroom each school day, a corporate representative would run from classroom to classroom, tossing a Tootsie Pop to each student who held their Weepuls high in the air. That big bag of sucker pops contained a precious few special Tootsie

Pops that had a coveted money sticker affixed to the wrapper. If you were the lucky student to catch a money sticker pop, you'd get paid cash on the spot, depending on how many Weepuls you had. For a child, it's like watching Willy Wonka merged with a game show host, throwing out sugary rewards for dutiful consumerism.

And second came the stratification of Weepuls, the social hierarchy of fuzzballs. Some held the status of aristocrats in Weepul society, valued twice as much as their counterparts. These were the esteemed nobles you earned by selling premium magazine subscriptions. Managed to secure a subscription for *Artisanal Cheese Monthly*? Here, have a double-value Weepul. Then there were the "multiplier" Weepuls, akin to the kings and queens of this fluffy kingdom. Large and commanding, they had the power to double the value of your entire Weepul collection, establishing a sort of regal lineage and influence within the world of cute, fuzzy spheres.

The genius was that it worked. Kids hustled. They sold magazines to their aunts, their neighbors, and the poor mailman who couldn't say no to a child holding a Weepul like it was a golden ticket. And what was the lesson here? Well, first, that anything can be commodified—even little balls of fluff. Second, that we live in a world of perceived value. A Weepul was a lesson in supply and demand, in social stratification, and in the eternal hustle. An early brush with capitalism, embodied in felt and glued-on googly eyes. Truly, the American dream in miniature.

My elementary school experience taught me well. See, loopholes are a revelation of sorts—a coming-of-age milestone. You realize you’re not just a pawn; you’re a knight, maybe even a bishop, capable of daring movement on this chessboard of life. Applying these lessons to the latest sales event, a plan sprung to life. It was time for the masterstroke, a coup d’état in the suburban war of magazine subscriptions.

The plan was ambitious, a symphony in salesmanship. It required stealth and spreadsheets, but most importantly, it required a small group of confidants. We were a band of rebels, if rebels sold subscriptions to *Good Housekeeping* with the option of four easy payments. So we sold, oh how we sold! We pitched to relatives, neighbors, passersby—heck, I think even our family dog had a subscription to *Sports Illustrated* by the end. My poor brother, in the name of the cause, found himself with not one but three subscriptions to *Working Mother*.

The genius lay in the details. I had crunched the numbers, breaking down each subscription, each Weepul reward, into cold, hard expected values. For certain magazines, it was actually profitable to buy the subscription myself. Yes, I spent money to make money, but in fluffy currency. An “Emperor Weepul,” the crown jewel of Weepuldom, was within reach. The economics were in my favor, you see. Buy a subscription for \$20, get an Emperor Weepul, which doubled the value of my entire collection. It was like a kiddie

version of insider trading, and I was the Gordon Gekko of Emily Gray Junior High.

The endgame was near, the final act in our junior high drama of capitalism and cunning. You see, selling those subscriptions was just setting the stage, positioning the chess pieces if you will. Each Tootsie Pop thrown was like a lottery ticket, a chance at hitting the jackpot. And when the winning pop landed in my palm, I did what any aspiring loophole virtuoso would do: nothing. I pocketed it, allowing the tension to build, like letting a fine wine age or waiting for the climax in a Hitchcock thriller.

You see, there was nothing in the rulebook that mandated immediate redemption of the money sticker. Oh no, my friends, I had read that rulebook cover to cover, and there was nary a word about instant gratification.

So, we waited, letting the days roll by as the corporate rep tossed his daily offering of Tootsie Pops, unaware we were building a small fortune. Finally, the last day of Tootsie Pop fun arrived. This was D-Day, or should I say, “W-Day.” Our little cadre of entrepreneurs pooled all our Weepuls together into a staggering monument of fluff and felt. It looked like a miniature mountain, a Muppet Mount Everest. An anonymous friend—I’ll never tell—carted this mighty pile into his homeroom. When the rep came in with his bag of Tootsie Pops, my friend triumphantly pulled *my* winning pop from his pocket and proudly presented it.

You see, the rulebook was conspicuously silent on the matter of sticker and Weepul transferability. Could one bestow upon another their winning Tootsie Pop, thereby transferring not just a sugary treat but also the potential for a windfall of cash? The rulebook didn't say no, and in the land of loopholes, silence is golden.

You should have seen the rep's face. He was flabbergasted, floored, utterly discombobulated. His petty cash pouch was laughably unprepared for the payout tsunami that hit him. But rules are rules, and a deal's a deal. After muttering and scrambling for cash reinforcements, he paid up, every last dime.

In the end, we split the winnings, and the take was oh so delicious. There we were, junior high moguls basking in our strategic glory. What did we learn? Well, that rules are merely the starting points of negotiation and that a well-placed loophole is worth its weight in Weepuls. It was a lesson in economics, strategy, and sheer audacity, taught not by textbooks but by the fine art of the hustle.

The end result? Our mailbox was so inundated with magazines that my parents had to make weekly trips to the post office, carrying home bundles of excess mail that would make Santa Claus wince. Yes, it created a logistical headache, but lo, the spoils of war were sweet—sweet as the Tootsie Pops that rained down upon us in homeroom. We had won, not just in amassing a fuzzy army of Weepuls but in outwitting the system, in finding that sliver of a

loophole and prying it open until it was large enough for a child-sized victory march.

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The Minority Mix-up

The sweet aroma of my youthful ambition: a bouquet of treasure hunting, fishing, and keyboard tapping. In high school, I was what you might call a “jock,” if by “jock,” you mean someone whose athletic prowess is limited to furiously typing code or casting fly fishing lines into a pond. I was, in less generous terms, a nerd—head always buried in some computer or lost in a daydream about unearthing treasure.

High school was a confusing period, like a poorly written user interface that you can’t escape from. It wasn’t the tests that bothered me; I could wade through algebra and history as smoothly as a fish swimming downstream. It was the homework that reeled me into troubled waters, a tedious chore that I was loathe to do.

I’ll never forget what Mr. Baker, my math teacher, told me. “You’re either going to be a millionaire or a bum on the street,” he

proclaimed, exasperated as he navigated the sea of my unfinished assignments. It was the kind of prediction that sticks with you, lurking in the back of your mind, like an error message you can't quite troubleshoot.

High school life was peculiar. One moment you're trying to figure out how to calculate the hypotenuse of a triangle, and the next, you're being called into the guidance counselor's office for an impromptu life evaluation. "How are you dealing with the challenges life has cast your way?" she asked, with an air of earnest concern. It was as though she was expecting me to crack open like a software program riddled with bugs, waiting for her expert intervention to patch me up.

"Life's good," I said.

"Really?" She seemed less than convinced.

"Yes, really," I assured her, finding the situation a bit amusing. Here I was, just a kid with an aversion to homework but a love for just about everything else, trying to convince someone that, yes, it's possible to be genuinely okay.

As the meeting ended, she suggested I start attending regular group sessions with other students. These would occasionally take the place of my normal classroom routine. A change of scenery sounded like a win, so I accepted the invitation, no questions asked. When the day of the group session rolled around, I jauntily exited the classroom, waving a jubilant farewell to my buddies. What a

stroke of luck!

It was an interactive session. The few students in attendance spoke in turn about the struggles they were facing, both in school and at home. I really didn't have much to complain about, so I kept quiet, even when the counselor inquired. My silence was met with a perceived uneasiness from the other students.

Confused as to why I, among the sprawling masses of Sabino High, was handpicked for this special gathering, I made a beeline for the counselor after the session. When she revealed the meetings were exclusively for the school's Native American students—and my presence wasn't optional but obligatory—I realized something was utterly amiss in this whole setup.

"Oh, you think I'm Native American?" I chuckled, half expecting her to join in on the joke.

But no, she was dead serious. "Have you spoken to your parents about this?"

I found myself imagining this conversation. "Mom, Dad, am I... Native American? And if so, why has this never come up? Like, not even once?"

I told the counselor I'd most definitely clarify my lineage, but I was fairly certain there'd been some mistake. She nodded, as if granting me temporary leave from an identity crisis she'd just assigned me. I left feeling like a character in a plot twist nobody saw coming—not even the author. Here was a person charged with

guiding young minds, seemingly unable to update her own database. Or was she right?

In a whirlwind of disbelief and fascination, I concluded that I was, in fact, a Native American—a revelation as shocking as it was unexpected. Life truly has its quirks. I rushed home to regale my mom with the extraordinary news. As I rambled on about this newfound facet of my identity, she regarded me with an incredulous, sidelong glance.

“Justin, let me stop you right there. You are not Native American. I would know; I birthed you and have a pretty good handle on our family tree.”

Pausing, I realized my peers in that counseling session had complexions notably different from my own. Oh, well this is awkward. *Now what?*

As reliable as a Swiss watch, the next counseling session rolled around. Despite a strong temptation to play hooky, I dutifully stayed in class. Soon after, that same counselor beckoned me back to her office. When I broke the news of my non-Native status, she stubbornly clung to her initial assertion.

“According to state records, you are Native American,” she declared.

Oh, really? Now that’s an argument even my mom can’t counter. Except, she did—vociferously, in fact. Mom shut down the entire conversation like a referee calling a foul. Her skepticism ran deep.

“State records?” she scoffed. “They might as well use a magic eight ball for all the accuracy they’re demonstrating.”

Even with my mom’s objections, my newfound “heritage” remained stubbornly on the books, and so the group sessions continued. The problem was, extricating myself from these meetings proved impossible. Eventually, I gave in to the inevitable. I took a seat in the back of the room and did my best to blend into the wallpaper.

To students at Sabino High, freedom looked like a square of laminated paper that allowed you the adult-like luxury of coming and going as you please: a parking pass! But like most things in life, this rarity was doled out on a need-to-have basis, and in the eyes of the school, underclassmen simply didn’t “need to have.” Seniors ruled the lot; the rest of us were bus-bound peasants.

There were loopholes, of course. Some tried to park in the nearby neighborhoods and make the walk, but it was a gamble. Residents were none too pleased to have their peaceful streets turned into a makeshift student lot. Others tried carpooling with older siblings or friends who had the coveted passes. But when you’re a junior yearning for that taste of autonomy, riding shotgun in someone else’s car just isn’t the same as being behind the wheel of your own.

When the counselor heard my lament about the parking situation—finally a problem, a real problem, not some invented, identity-confused, existential crisis—her eyes lit up as if she had struck gold.

Here was a way she could actually help. Soon enough, she was pulling strings, talking to the administration about the possible allocation of a few extra passes for the Native American students. As if by magic, the next morning not one but two parking passes showed up in my locker.

In the heady days of junior year, I ascended to a level of high school glory alongside star athletes and homecoming royalty: I had obtained a parking pass. I was the envy of every car-owning underclassman, and even shared the spoils by giving my friend Will a coveted spot next to mine. As we parked our cars with gleeful abandon, I felt invincible. In a nod to my Native American heritage (and a nod to political incorrectness), my classmates started calling me “Running Water.”

As senior year commenced, just when I thought it couldn’t get any better, a summons from the office led me to that familiar counselor’s chair. As I settled in, expecting another episode in the ongoing saga of my misidentified ethnicity, she dropped a bombshell—this one of the good variety.

“Justin, you’ve been granted a scholarship. You can attend any university on this list,” she said, handing me a roster of schools that read like the Who’s Who of Higher Education.

I sat there, utterly gobsmacked. It felt as if I had won the academic equivalent of an all-expenses-paid luxury cruise. My eyes scanned the list of institutions. *Which school suits a young man of my*

caliber? I wondered. I pictured myself, Big Man on Campus, strutting down the treelined sidewalks of a prestigious university, a cheerleader on each arm.

“Just one little thing,” she added. “We’ll need your tribal documents to finalize the scholarship.”

I blinked. “Tribal documents?”

“You know, the papers your parents would have filed away somewhere safe,” she assured me.

I finished out the rest of the school day in a head-scratching stupor, pausing in the parking lot to look at the laminated pass that hung from my rearview mirror.

“Mom, do we, by any chance, have tribal documents?” I meekly inquired, half-hopeful, half-mortified.

Her response was an incredulous look, as if I had just asked her if we were descendants of extraterrestrial beings. “Tribal what now?” she quipped, and the jig was up.

My avoidance strategy—a week or two of playing ostrich with my head in the sand—crumbled when the school office called me in again. This time the atmosphere had all the joviality of a tax audit. The counselor was there, flanked by a few other stern-faced adults. “Justin, we need to ask you something, and we need you to be very honest,” she started, fixing me with a serious stare. “Are you Native American?”

Sigh.

Looking back on that episode, I've pieced together a theory that I find fairly convincing. When I was younger, taking those routine state standardized tests, I'd reach the section that asked about my ethnicity. Being a kid who equated being born in America with being "Native American," I'd enthusiastically check that box. I mean, it made sense to me, way more than "Caucasian"—a term as foreign as the concept of deep time. So, I suspect that my younger self set this whole surreal chain of events in motion. And while it makes for a quirky chapter in my life story, it also serves as a lesson on the unintended consequences of checked boxes—literal and metaphorical.

The Midnight Menace

In railroad families, Z trains are spoken of like royalty—the Ferraris of the rail, demanding respect from even the most grizzled engineers. My father would get this particular gleam in his eye when he'd say, "Seventy miles an hour and highball!"—railroad speak for "full speed ahead with a clear track." But respect for these machines runs deeper than admiring their raw power. It's about understanding their moods, their limits, and sometimes—as I'd learn one August night in 2000—their vulnerabilities.

That moonless night, my mother was at the controls of a Z train, its diesel engines thrumming a hypnotic cadence in the desert darkness. At 2 a.m., dispatch ordered her to pull into a siding—a routine chess move in Union Pacific's endless game of keeping their freight trains from delaying Amtrak's notoriously behind-schedule passenger service. The company watched their bottom line like a

hawk, particularly the fines they'd face for disrupting passenger schedules.

I was seventeen when I learned just how quickly a Z train's majesty could turn to menace. My father's unexpected call in the night was stripped of its usual easy banter.

"Your mother's train was shot at," he said, the words falling like steel on steel.

From my bedroom in Tucson, I knew she was somewhere west of Maricopa—close enough that I might have heard that same desert wind through my window, far enough that I could do nothing but fumble in the dark for my scanner radio. I tuned to the dispatcher channel, listening as voices crackled across the Sonoran night, painting a picture of what was unfolding just a hundred miles away on those lonely tracks.

Except she never made it to that siding.

Every locomotive has its own personality, its own collection of squeaks and groans that become as familiar as a child's voice to its engineer. My mother had been running engines long enough to know every normal sound and every warning sign. Which is why when the first explosion ripped through the night, it caught her off guard. "What the heck was that?" The words barely left her mouth before she locked eyes with her equally bewildered conductor.

"Maybe a rock hit the engine," he suggested, though they both knew rocks don't usually come with their own pyrotechnics.

In the split second before all hell broke loose, my mother's instincts kicked in. Railroad engineers sometimes encounter "torpedoes" on the tracks—small, controlled explosions meant as warning signals. The sharp crack beneath the wheels was a sound every engineer respected. But this was different. Torpedoes don't shatter windows or spray electrical sparks like angry fireflies across a locomotive cab.

The pain hit her right ear the same moment the engines died, all four of them going silent as cemetery stones. In the sudden quiet, broken only by the dying momentum of a hundred freight cars, the conductor's words fell like lead: "Someone's shooting at us."

You never forget the sound of a train dying. The groans and squeals seem to come from the earth itself, like some ancient beast letting out its last breath. With an invisible gunman somewhere in the darkness, my mother had to make a choice that would haunt any engineer's nightmares—stand up at the controls or stay down and let the train roll blind.

She stood.

The Amtrak that had prompted all this maneuvering ended up stopping right where the bullets had torn through the air minutes before, its passengers blissfully unaware of how close they'd come to their own encounter with whatever darkness had targeted my mother's train.



When she finally stepped out into the desert night, safety vest glowing like a beacon, the only sound was the cooling tick of the engines and the whisper of desert wind. The same darkness that had harbored violence now offered only silence. She dabbed at her ear with her sleeve, leaving a rust-colored smear on the radio mic as she called in her status. Somehow, she got those engines started again, and dispatch—in what I imagine was either remarkable courage or remarkable foolishness—ordered her to continue on to Yuma.

The shooter was caught a month later in what could only be called a cosmic joke of timing. His license plate had chosen that night, that exact stretch of track, to shake loose and fall. While he

was taking aim at my mother's train, his means of identification was tumbling into the desert sand below. A routine traffic stop weeks later matched the plate to a pickup truck in Phoenix, and suddenly the pieces fell together like a perfectly thrown switch. Sometimes justice arrives on the smallest of breaks—or in this case, a single rattled bolt giving way at precisely the right moment.

In the end, the case got tangled in jurisdictional red tape when the shooter claimed the attack happened on Native American land further down the track. Every locomotive carries an event recorder—railroaders call it the “black box”—that logs precise locations and times, like an airplane's flight recorder. But Union Pacific failed to download this crucial data in time. Without it, they couldn't disprove the shooter's claim, and the case moved to federal court where it fizzled like a wet firecracker. My mother—one of the first female engineers in the Tucson division—handled it like she'd handled everything else in over twenty years of railroading, a profession that demanded twice the work from her with half the complaints allowed. At work, she kept the same professional demeanor she'd maintained since breaking that glass ceiling, though at home the words flowed freer about Union Pacific's fumbled evidence. She'd faced down worse than bureaucratic failures in her decades on the rail. After her mandatory eight hours of rest, when the crew board turned and her name came up, she was back in the cab, same as always—not because she wasn't angry, but because two

decades of being a woman in a man's world had taught her that the strongest statement she could make was simply showing up, run after run, proving herself one call at a time.



One of the railroad's pioneering women locomotive engineers, Mom blazed trails for female railroaders at Southern Pacific. Photo by Kevin Asher

The passengers on that Amtrak train likely spent their morning

grumbling about delays, unaware of how close they'd come to catastrophe. But out there in the Arizona desert, between Maricopa and destiny, there's a stretch of track that marks the line between before and after—where our illusions of safety and control shatter as easily as locomotive glass in the dark.

The Aft Assault

Grasshopper Valley in Southwest Montana is the kind of place that could inspire a postcard business or a robust Instagram account. It's nestled up against the Pioneer Mountains, flanked by the Big Hole Valley, sprawling out in such a way that you feel like you're either on the cusp of the world or smack dab in the center of it, depending on your perspective. The hills roll, the air is crisp, and if you listen closely, you can almost hear the echoes of the nineteenth-century mining boom that has left its ghostly fingerprint on the land, particularly in Bannack, which now plays dead very convincingly as a sleepy state park.

At night, the sky in Grasshopper Valley is so star-spangled, you'd swear it's wearing the universe's largest tiara. Without a speck of light pollution, the Milky Way splays across the sky, a celestial canvas that'll have you thumbing through your mental Rolodex for

constellations you learned about in third grade.

Our family friends, ranchers who could probably teach you seventeen ways to mend a fence and another five ways to repurpose a rusty horseshoe, have been anchors in that valley for as long as I can remember. They're the kind of folks who wave when you drive by, even if they don't recognize you, because in a place like Polaris, waving is just good manners, like saying "excuse me" after you accidentally step on a gopher.

Every so often, I'd swing by their place, armed with a freshly baked rhubarb pie, courtesy of my mother and her secret rhubarb patch, a place she holds dear and keeps close to her heart, much like the recipe for her famous baked delicacy. The pie was my ticket to Grasshopper Creek, a humble little trickle of water that wouldn't even qualify as a puddle in most parts of the world. You could practically hop across it if you were feeling spry.



“Give a man a fish and he’ll have dinner. Teach a man to fish and he’ll be late for dinner.”

But don’t let its diminutive size fool you. Grasshopper Creek is home to absurdly large brown trout that must have slipped through a crack in reality from some fisherman’s manifesting mantra. During grasshopper season, the creek transforms into a piscine pandemonium. Fish gorge themselves at this all-you-can-eat buffet,

turning fishing into a gladiatorial sport.

One afternoon, just a stone's throw south of the post office turnoff, the stage was set for an epic fishing adventure. With every step stirring up a whirlwind of insects, it was clear the fishing at Grasshopper Creek was going to be nothing short of spectacular.

The banks, cloaked in thick brush, made each cast a strategic move. This brush, both life-giver and sanity-stealer, served as an insect clubhouse and a saboteur for fishing lines. My weapon of choice was a shorter, full flex fly rod, perfect for these close-quarter conditions. No need to worry about a long cast when you're practically close enough to shake fins with the fish, provided you could get them to stop their incessant dining for a moment.

Perched on the bank, I trained my eyes on the water's surface. And there it was—a wake so pronounced it could only belong to the Moby Dick of trout. It was a ripple of hope, a watery fingerprint of the lunker that surely lurked beneath.

The creek, swollen with the season, required a tactical relocation to the opposite shore. With the stealth of a heron, I breached the aquatic barrier, the cool rush of water masking my crossing.

Fish, with their water-tuned eyes—those evolutionary marvels—see the world in a refraction riddle. Light slows and bends as it transitions from air to water, creating an optical illusion in which they see the world above through a circular window formed by light entering their domain.

As I knelt in preparation for my fish giant joust, aligning myself with the beast, I readied my rod for a roll cast befitting the Anglers Hall of Fame. The world narrowed to a tunnel and my focus was a laser beam, when suddenly the serenity was shattered. There came a cacophony from behind—a sound as if the brush were being unzipped by a frenzied, clawed hand.

For a heart-stopping split-second, my mind raced to the conclusion of a bear. The ferocity of the disturbance, the way the grass and brush heaved and shuddered, all pointed to a creature of considerable size. In my years fishing these parts, I'd never encountered a grizzly, but the prospect of a black bear, agitated and formidable, sent a surge of adrenaline through me.

I braced, not even the luxury to rise, my mind already mourning the untimely end of my fly fishing days. And then, out it tumbled—a badger, no less!

I must confess, this was no run-of-the-mill, garden variety badger. This was an irate badger, a creature so livid it seemed to have mustered the wrath of all its ancestors. As I clamored to my feet, the badger launched himself at me with a snarl that could curdle blood. In a pitiful attempt at defense, my fly rod was brandished like a knight's lance, but to this raging beast, it might as well have been a twig. He tore through it with righteous anger, a fuzzy juggernaut on a quest for vengeance.

Clearly, this was my cue for an ungraceful exit. I pivoted to make

my aquatic escape. The badger, in a parting shot worthy of a duel's finale, took one final, apocalyptic lunge. His teeth found their mark, my buttocks, forever branding me in badger warfare lore. I plunged into the creek, a mix of shock and indignity speeding my retreat.



By the time I emerged, a bedraggled figure on the other bank, my waders were sloshing with creek water due to the large tear in the rear—a lasting souvenir of the badger's bite. Clutched in my hand were the remnants of my once trusty fly fishing rod, now reduced to little more than kindling. My backside throbbed with the indignity

of the badger's farewell, a stinging reminder that nature always has the last laugh. A jab of rabies vaccine later and I was on the mend, nursing more my pride than the puncture.

It's a rite of passage, I've come to believe, for those of us who wade through the secluded waters of the American West with nothing but our wits and a fly rod. It's an unspoken pact with the wilderness: trade the occasional encounter with its wilder denizens for the soul-stirring serenity found in the ripple of a mountain stream. A badger's bite for a moment of peace—seems a fair exchange, if you ask me.

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The Hatchback Hostage

Ah, yes, the ignorance of youth, where the pinnacle of freedom and adulthood was encapsulated in the form of my grandfather's 1982 Volkswagen diesel Rabbit pickup—basically a snail on wheels in stylish silver. The thing had so little oomph, you had to turn off the AC to summon enough power to make a perilous left turn against oncoming traffic. But for all its mechanical quirks and foibles, I grew hopelessly attached to that little mechanical marvel. Grandpa had driven it for years, leaving an imprint of his essence in every worn seat and faded patch of paint. The day my mom sold it, you'd have thought I'd lost a lifelong friend. And in some ways, I had.

The metamorphosis of automotive love—like going from dating a librarian to a supermodel—was quite a thing. There I was, behind the wheel of a cherry-red, five-speed manual 2001 Toyota Celica GT. My mother was convinced I was the second coming of Mario

Andretti. Naturally, I had no qualms about living up to the expectation. Driving was my jam, racing my bread and butter. My band of merry, torque-obsessed friends and I would venture to those unsanctioned, downright illicit midnight street races south of Tucson when the weekend came calling. Ah, but the cops, ever so predictable, would inevitably show up, sparking a frenzied exodus of rubber scattering into the desert night. Soon enough, eluding capture became less of a consequence and more of a sport in itself.

The more I babied that car, the more it seemed to find itself in automotive misadventures, which was quite an unfortunate paradox. Like the time I took it to a car wash, only for the attendant—clearly not a candidate for employee of the month—to leave the windows down, transforming my Celica into a swimming pool. Or that ill-fated tinting episode, where the so-called “expert” decided to add the moonroof to his career casualties. It was clear: if I wanted something done right, I had to do it myself, or suffer the string of vehicular Vaudevilles that seemed to be my lot. And so, I’ve generally adhered to this self-sufficient philosophy ever since, for better or for worse.

I had always been the steward of my own oil changes. But I had a coupon offering a reprieve from my self-imposed duty. “Free” has a certain *je ne sais quoi* that’s hard to resist. I scooped up my friend Mike, who seemed more than willing to escape the domestic doldrums, and we rolled into the oil change station like we were

entering Valhalla on four wheels. Mind you, when it came to oil, I was a connoisseur, a veritable sommelier of synthetic blends and viscosities. I hopped out of the car and, oil elitist that I was, confidently informed the attendant that today I would be providing my own sacred nectar.

I popped the hatchback and, lo and behold, we weren't alone. Hidden amidst my bottles of high-viscosity elixir was a young man, eyes wide, looking like he'd seen his own ghost. His arms appeared to be bound, his disposition somewhere between a cornered animal and an extra in a crime drama. A layer of dread filled the air, thick enough to slather on toast. For a moment, I was paralyzed—a carapace of disbelief encasing me.

The attendant, clearly not trained for this level of customer service, began stepping back. “Whoa, man, whoa. I don't want any part of this, man. This is a kidnapping!”

In the blink of an eye, the kid in my trunk went from petrified stowaway to Olympic sprinter. There he was, a blur of adrenaline and mystery, darting across the parking lot in his socks. His hands still bound with rope, he looked back in fear as he disappeared around the corner. I stood there, gaping like a largemouth bass, forming unspeakable syllables of utter bewilderment. What could I say? What could anyone say? The situation had catapulted itself into the realm of the absurd, bypassing any pedestrian explanation I might have mustered.

The employee was already dialing 911, his face flushed with the colors of impending legal doom, when Mike burst from the passenger seat in a fit of laughter so robust it bordered on maniacal. “That’s my friend! Oh man, the look on your face!”

Apparently, my trunk had served as the stage for this impromptu performance art. Mike’s friend discovered his muse in a stray piece of rope in my trunk. Had he not returned just in the nick of time to clarify this bewildering scene, my rendezvous with a free oil change could have transformed into an indelible blot on my record.

It was not by coincidence then, that my car started smoking shortly after we departed. It turns out the employees, still rattled, had forgotten to fully secure the oil drain plug. Yes, the very lifeblood of my car had drained away, mile by mile, until the engine coughed its last. And so, I found myself marooned on the roadside, contemplating the cruel irony of it all. What had begun as a quest for convenience had transformed into a mechanical elegy. It was a poignant reminder—if you want something done right, you really must do it yourself. And maybe, just maybe, check your trunk for hidden occupants before undertaking any sort of social interaction. Life’s lessons come in all shapes and sizes, don’t they?

The Friendly Follies

Aidan and I weren't just roommates during our freshman year at The University of Arizona; we were veterans of the same suburban battleground, survivors of childhood skirmishes now bunking together by choice. The occasional tyranny of childhood coexistence had given way to a chosen companionship, an odd couple bound by the kind of shared history that was polished to a shine through the abrasion of conflict. It seems the universe, in its infinite jest, decided the only way for us to pave a path to amity was to first navigate the rocky terrain of our discord.

I hit the roommate jackpot with him—responsible, level-headed, and we saw eye-to-eye on nearly everything. If you looked up “studious” in the dictionary, you’d probably find Aidan’s student ID photo there, complete with a smug little smirk that said, “Yeah, my GPA can beat up your GPA.”

Aidan was an academic ninja, a sage, practically a monk sworn to the Order of Bookworms. He was also a Renaissance man—so he was both Einstein and da Vinci. Handcrafted smoking pipes, silk worm farming—you name it, he was into it. And not just “into it”—he mastered every bizarre hobby he picked up. When he graduated top of his class in electrical engineering, every bigwig company lined up, checkbooks in hand. But Aidan, in true Aidan fashion, decided to swerve into the most unexpected lane. After all, he had already mastered that field.



Aidan always had a different way of looking at the world.

Many a night, our little band of misfits would roam the sprawling university campus on bikes, as if auditioning for a low-budget remake of “E.T.” Mike and Will, our comrades-in-arms, were video game aficionados. As the semester wore on, Mike’s love affair with gaming blossomed into a full-blown obsession. We’d hit the hay, and he’d still be there, glued to the screen, clicking away in a trance. By sunrise, he was as much a part of the furniture as the lumpy dorm couch. It was a habit that clung to him like a stubborn barnacle, but eventually, he managed to shake it off. Perhaps those marathon gaming sessions unlocked some hidden potential because Mike ended up in robotics at Johns Hopkins. Maybe those video games were less of a time-sink and more of a crystal ball, foretelling a future filled with robots instead of raid bosses.

Back in those days, being stuck on campus during the school year, I was more a creature of the cyber underworld than a regular college student. Classes? Oh, I was aware that they were happening, some at ungodly hours, like, say, 10 a.m. My circadian rhythm was less a rhythm and more a chaotic jazz solo, refusing to sync up with the world’s mundane schedule. Much like my high school escapades, I could waltz through exams with the grace of a dancer, but homework? That was a different beast altogether. To me, it was like being told to wait in line at the DMV. There was a whole universe of things to learn and explore, and spending hours on end with worksheets felt like trying to swim in a kiddie pool.

All things considered, our freshman year unfolded splendidly—save for the occasional urge on my part to stoke the embers of mischief. Aidan presented such a tempting canvas for a bit of tomfoolery.

That first semester I caught one half of a phone call home: something about the tuition deadline and when would the check clear. Aidan's mom was a delightful philharmonic of chaos. It was clear that Aidan was neck-deep in the quagmire of his mother's chronic last-minuteness.

Fueled by the mischievous gods of college life, I concocted the perfect storm: a counterfeit email from the Bursar's Office. Crafted under the cover of night, it was a doomsday prophecy in Arial font, declaring Aidan's imminent academic demise due to unpaid tuition, complete with a twenty-hour eviction notice from campus.

Perched atop my top bunk bed roost, I watched the tragicomedy play out the following morning. The ding of his inbox was the overture to his unraveling, giving way to tears, hyperventilating, disbelief, and a frantic phone call home.

The jest had stretched to its limits, perhaps a smidge beyond. Guilt, that sneaky aftertaste of practical jokes, crept up on me, and I unveiled the truth. The initial response was less than favorable, and for a second I thought Aidan might recreate the Piccadilly Cafeteria incident. But relief soon washed over him like a tidal wave over a sandcastle, grateful his academic life was not, in fact, crumbling.

Karma, that stealthy, omnipresent bookkeeper, decided my ledger needed balancing, and so, balance it did.

I had secured my bicycle inside our dorm for Christmas break, believing it to be safe from the outside world's harsh elements. Little did I know, in my absence, it would become the centerpiece of what I can only imagine was a Newtonian experiment gone wildly entertaining, presided over by Aidan and a tribunal of our peers. Upon my return, I was greeted not by my dependable Schwinn, but a twisted relic of its former glory—evidence of it having been ridden down, or hurled down, the stairs repeatedly.

It was about this time the Fates decided that a joint venture in karma rebalancing was in order—a two-for-one special, if you will.

Every morning, Aidan was as punctual as a Swiss watch, waking up at the same ungodly hour. His morning ritual was a mystery to me, as I was usually deep in the embrace of my pillow. Part of this ritual involved a shower down the hall, and instead of taking his key, he'd leave the door ever so slightly ajar. On this particular morning, my digestive system, enraged by the previous night's overindulgence—twenty tacos, to be exact—demanded immediate attention. I thought, *I'll go ahead and shower while I'm down there*. I leapt from my bed, towel-clad, and dashed for the bathroom, confident that Aidan would have his key. How wrong I was.

Emerging from his shower, Aidan found himself locked out, his only companion being the naïve belief that I had a key. He waited. I

joined him. And together we discovered our predicament. There we were, two college students in nothing but towels, marooned in the breezeway.

Our dorm, La Paz, was a shiny new beacon that had drawn us in, despite being the hub for jocks—a tribe we were decidedly not a part of. The night before had witnessed some grand sportsball event, leaving the building hungover and comatose, including the RA, our only hope for rescue. Trying to wake him was like trying to summon a spirit from the great beyond. Time stretched out, and the corridor transformed into a runway of awkward encounters and unsolicited fashion critiques.

Eventually, I drew the short straw and embarked on a towel-clad odyssey to the front office. Picture this: a six-foot-four, rail-thin ding-a-ling sauntering down main street barefoot, his dignity hanging by the thread of a bath towel. It was a spectacle that would have had passersby questioning their morning coffee.

This little escapade ended with our eventual re-entry into our room, but not without paying a hefty toll at the bridge of embarrassment. In the ledger of the Fates, our karma accounts were now overflowing, courtesy of a morning we'd never live down.

As the year rolled on, our friendship, stitched together with the thread of shared misadventures and laughter, grew stronger. It was a bond formed not despite our differences, but because of them. In this carnival of late-night study sessions, prank wars, and unexpected

lockouts, we found an unbreakable friendship—a reminder that the best parts of college aren't always found in textbooks. This bond, tested and strengthened in the fires of youthful folly, culminated in a testament to its strength: years later, Aidan stood beside me as the best man at my wedding, a role only fitting for someone who had been so much more than just a college roommate.

The Beano Betrayal

In the summer of 2002, when I was a college sophomore, Jennie arrived at my Dad's house, where I was stationed for the weekend, her hands wielding a bubble wand with the sort of zeal generally reserved for winning lottery tickets. The bubbles sashayed through the air like tipsy ballerinas, indifferent to their brief and soapy lives. That was, of course, until Jennie's enthusiasm was betrayed by the container's shoddy craftsmanship, which sprouted a crack.

Summoning the spirit of a chivalrous knight in somewhat less shining armor, I set upon a quest through the labyrinth of my father's household miscellanea to find a replacement bottle. It wasn't long before triumph struck in the form of a "Beano" bottle, its girth and height a match made in container heaven. I had never heard of Beano, but after briefly scanning the label, I learned it was a gallant defender against the gastrointestinal dragons of flatulence, which I

reckoned had no place in the upcoming romantic soiree. With a cavalier attitude that would later define much of my twenties, I downed the remaining pills, thus liberating the bottle for Jennie's bubbly concoction.

A tiny hole was drilled, epoxy was summoned for its adhesive prowess, and presto: the bubble wand was affixed to its new lid with the regality of a throne atop its kingdom. The bubbles could dance once more, and we were off, blissfully ignorant of the digestive disharmony I had just insured for myself—a detail that would only enrich the tapestry of the evening's follies.

In the driver's seat of my cherry-red Celica, I navigated to our dining destination for what I hoped would be a dinner unmarred by culinary or social disaster. We strutted in, only to be greeted by Jennie's ex-beau, moonlighting as our waiter. The evening's script took a turn for the cringe-worthy when, faced with culinary choices, Jennie announced her intention to partake in the grilled chicken breast. I, ever the aficionado of poultry pectorals and a stranger to my own mental filter, blurted out my shared enthusiasm with a poorly chosen, "Oh, I like breasts," I declared, as if at a confessional.

At this, Jennie's ex, pencil hovering above his notepad, shot me a look of stunned disbelief, one eyebrow arching high in silent judgment. Meanwhile, Jennie, confusion painting her features, glanced between us. The horror of my slip was immediate, and in the frantic scramble to right my ship, I tacked hard to the wind.

“Uhh, I don’t mean boobs, I mean chicken boobs, I mean breasts,” I sputtered, floundering in the shallows of my own embarrassment. My mind, in a panic, decided to toss in a paradoxical addendum, “I mean, I like all breasts, but chicken is what I’m mainly referring to here.” The probability of a third date dwindled before my eyes like the last bubbles from Jennie’s defective container.

Choosing then to adopt the wisdom of silence, I clamped my mouth shut, hoping to stem the tide of my verbal gaffes. Silence was my newfound, though short-lived, companion in the awkward waltz of that evening.

As we departed the restaurant, the date’s course seemed to steady itself, veering into the calm seas of pleasant story swapping. That was, of course, until the Beano, now a mutinous crew within my innards, began to stage a coup. Mere minutes into our homeward journey, a sinister cramp hoisted its Jolly Roger. I endeavored to sail on, a stoic captain, my discomfort concealed from Jennie like a pirate’s treasure. For what is young love if not a parade of dignified pretenses?

As we approached the sanctuary of my father’s abode, where Jennie’s vehicle was parked, the mutiny below decks escalated to a full-blown rebellion. I entertained the fond fantasy of a brisk goodbye, perhaps accompanied by a stoic grimace mistaken for mysterious allure. However, the moment the Celica’s door creaked open, my ability to stand crumbled like a meringue in a pressure

cooker. My body, defiant in its agony, refused to straighten, forcing me to adopt the posture of a man who had lost an ill-advised bet with gravity. I collapsed onto the curb, the pavement hot and unsympathetic beneath me, still warm from baking in the earlier summer sun.

Jennie, angelic in her concern, descended beside me. "Oh my gosh! Are you okay?" she inquired, her voice a melody of worry.

Through clenched teeth, I offered a groan that I hoped sounded gallant. "I'm okay," I lied. "Just a spot of stomach trouble." Desperate to spare her the impending ignominy of my Beano betrayal, I mustered what little dignity I had left. "Hey, why don't you head on home?" I suggested, with a feeble wave of my hand. "I'll just sit here for a few minutes."

She hesitated, her eyes a mirror of reluctance, but ultimately she departed, leaving me to commune with the hot, hard truth of the asphalt and the bubbling rebellion within.

Jennie's taillights faded into the night, and the reality of my predicament clawed its way to the forefront. Mother, you see, was expecting my arrival that night. A woman of unfaltering routines, she would certainly be draped in worry if her son didn't arrive as planned. So, I wrangled myself back into the cockpit of my manual transmission Celica.

The journey to my mother's house was less than twenty minutes under normal circumstances. A breeze, surely, or so my optimistic

self declared. "I can make it, right?" I whispered to the gearshift, my hand trembling. Alas, I had not accounted for the torso treachery that driving would incite, each gear shift demanding what felt like a herculean effort from my beleaguered abdomen. Within moments, the agony crescendoed, leaving me no alternative but to navigate the route solely in second gear, the whine of the engine mimicking my pleas to the universe.

There was but a solitary stop sign. In an act of automotive blasphemy, I eased through its warning without the customary halt, for the very thought of grappling with the clutch was tantamount to embracing the torture rack. Engine howling in protest, revving with the desperation of a creature in flight, my little car and I limped through the still suburban night in second gear. Mid-journey, I conceded some ground against the mounting insurgency. In a desperate bid for relief, I cast aside the constricting shackles of my belt and the oppressive button of my pants.

By some stroke of providence or sheer force of will, the beleaguered Celica and I limped into the safe harbor of my mother's garage. Sadly, this was not the end of my journey. The garage did not share a door with the comforting embrace of the house. Instead, I was to embark on an obstacle course that promised to be my undoing: a side door leading to a locked iron gate, and finally, the task of opening the front door. There was no turning back, for the promise of rest lay just beyond.

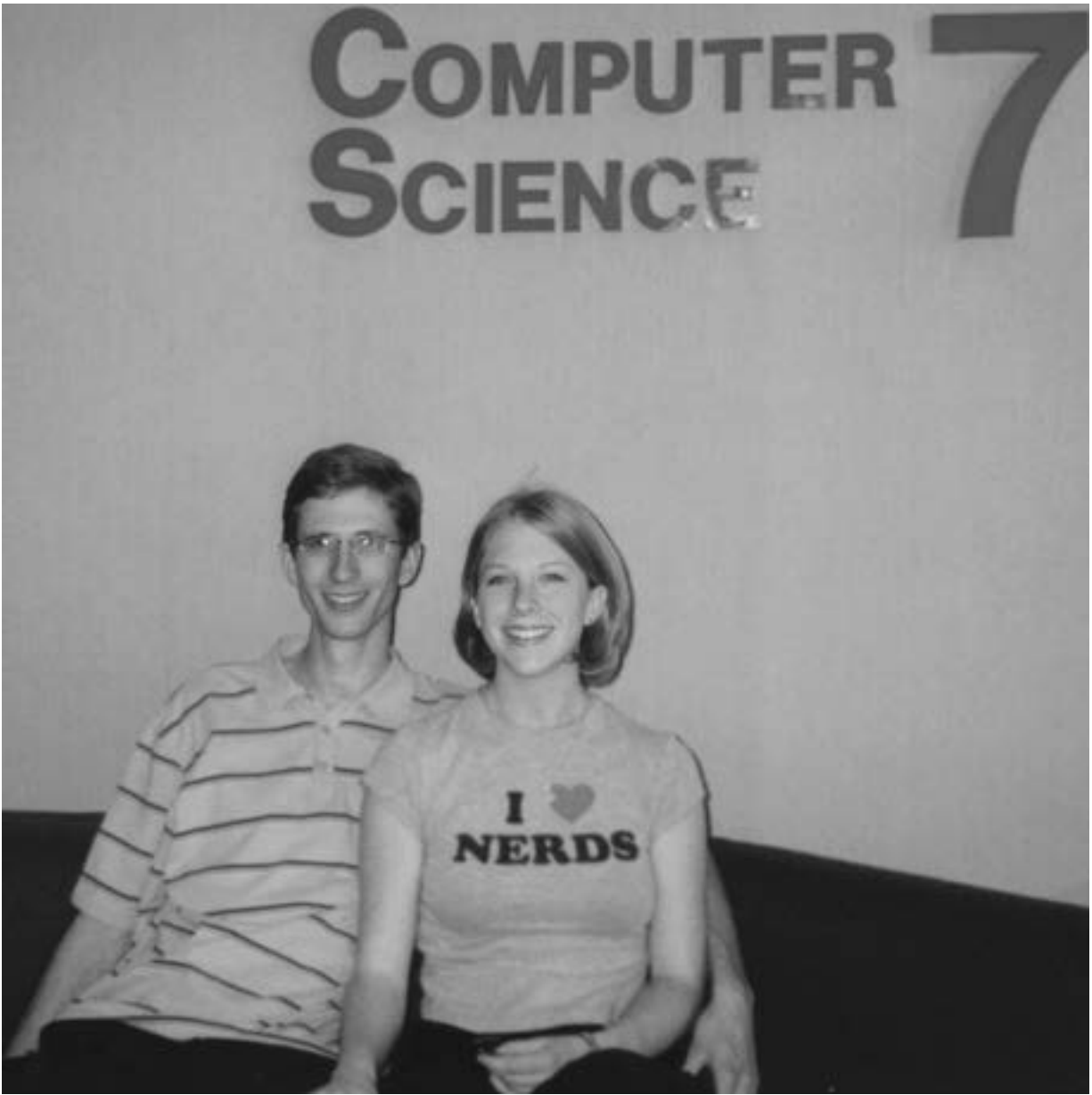
In a display reminiscent of a newborn fawn's first steps, I mustered what was left of my composure and coordination to traverse the final leg, clutching the waistband of my pants as I staggered to the front door. Alas, it was here, on the threshold of refuge, that my body declared defeat, and I succumbed to the darkness. Landing in a heap, I passed out just inside the door.

The next thing I knew, I awoke not to the sounds of celestial harps, but to the cries of my mother's panic and the sensation of being shaken like a rag doll. There I lay, sprawled unceremoniously, groaning like a bear nudged from hibernation, the door ajar, and my dropped trousers pooled around my ankles. In her eyes, I saw the reflection of a crime scene—her son, clutching his abdomen, mistaken for a casualty of some grisly altercation.

When the seismic convulsions of pain had receded, I was left to ponder the aftermath. I've since heard whispers and rumors, old wives' tales of Beano's alchemical powers—gas transformed into solid, a digestive philosopher's stone. Whether these accounts hold any scientific water, or are merely the musings of the masses, I cannot say. But I can attest, from personal and painful experience: the Beano overdose was nothing short of catastrophic alchemy.

Days later, as I nursed my battered ego and still-tender bowels, I was certain Jennie had filed me away under "Never Again" in her mental Rolodex of romantic mishaps. Yet, like a moth drawn to a particularly clumsy flame, she called. Perhaps she sensed a kindred

spirit in disaster, or maybe she just wanted to see what fresh hell our next encounter might unleash. Whatever her reasons, she asked for a third date. And so, armed with a newfound respect for digestive supplements and a self-imposed vow of silence regarding breasts of any species, I ventured forth once more.



As it turns out, my night of gastrointestinal theatrics and social ineptitude had somehow endeared me to her. In the catalog of her dating history, I was now the guy who quite literally fell for her—first off a curb, then through a front door. It became our story, retold as a cautionary tale about the dangers of mixing romance with over the counter medication. And isn't that the benchmark of true love? Finding someone who not only tolerates your most mortifying moments but embraces them as the cornerstone of your shared narrative. In the end, I may have lost my dignity, but I got the girl. And a lifetime supply of Beano, monitored with the vigilance of a prison warden.

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Trailside Troubles

By twenty, I'd made enough trips to consider myself an expert on truck stop bathroom quality between Tucson and Helena. This particular summer, I convinced Aidan and our mutual friend Michael to join me on the twenty-five-hour drive to Montana—mostly because misery loves company, and because somewhere around hour eighteen of previous solo trips, I'd developed an aversion to talking to myself.

In those days, I drove like I lived: either vibrating with enough caffeine to interfere with local radio signals, or so deeply unconscious that medieval physicians might have declared me dead. There was no in-between, which made me either the best or worst companion for a cross-country drive, depending entirely on which version showed up behind the wheel. Aidan and Michael took their chances, settling in as my captive audience through the endless

stretch between desert and mountains.

The summer unfolded exactly as summers do when you're young enough to believe in your own immortality—though I suppose I should mention our brief banishment from Dillon's sole supermarket, courtesy of an incident involving a frozen sausage and a broken fly rod. But that's hardly worth dwelling on, considering what came next.

News of a forest fire "somewhere in the area" had prompted my great-uncle Larry Fitzwater toward what I would later recognize as an admirably prophetic precaution: he'd transformed my grandfather's hunting cabin into what appeared to be the world's largest leftover dinner, wrapping the entire structure in industrial-grade tin foil. The cabin, which had stood in Comet Mountain's shadow since before I was born, now gleamed like a beacon of peculiar preparation—though at the time, I was too excited about finally sleeping inside it to properly appreciate Larry's aluminum artistry.

In all my previous Montana pilgrimages, I'd been relegated to tent status, wrestling with canvas and mosquitoes beneath mountain stars. But this year, my grandfather had deemed us worthy of cabin occupancy. "You'll stay here," he said, after performing minor surgery on Great Uncle Larry's masterpiece to create crude holes for windows and doors. Looking at our temporary home, I couldn't help but think that if aliens made first contact with Earth, they'd

bypass all major cities and head straight for this tin-foil beacon, assuming it must be some sort of interplanetary embassy.



Mike proudly displays his catch inside our humble foil-wrapped abode.

I spent my days introducing Aidan and Michael to what I considered a proper Montana experience. My specialty was golden trout—beautiful creatures that lived in Sawtooth Lake. Despite their notoriously bland taste, I never wasted a catch—there was something sacred in sharing that first flash of gold beneath the water.

Sawtooth wasn't just any mountain lake. In 1957, a converted Navy torpedo bomber, repurposed for spraying pesticides against pine beetles, had stalled and crashed into these waters, taking pilot and wife with it. The pesticides transformed the lake into a lifeless pool, but nature has a patience we humans can only marvel at. Decades passed, and gradually the waters purified themselves, returning to a crystalline clarity that seemed almost impossible given their toxic past. When the lake was ready, the Forest Service introduced golden trout, and the species flourished.

"We should hike in at night," I suggested, as if nocturnal mountain climbing was the state pastime. "That way we'll be there for sunrise." This missionary zeal led to what I now recognize as a spectacular lapse in judgment. Aidan and Michael agreed, still operating under the misguided assumption that all my ideas were rational.

Years of mountain hiking had taught me many valuable lessons, none of which apparently included "pack light when leading novices on a nighttime expedition." I approached equipping our adventure with the paranoid thoroughness of a mother sending her child to their first sleepaway camp. My grandfather's Jeep Wagoneer groaned in protest as I transformed my backpack into a mobile fishing outfitter's shop: neoprene waders, fins, multiple rods, and—the *pièce de résistance*—a fully inflatable float tube that made my pack look like I was smuggling a small weather balloon. In my

defense, I'd seen too many fishing trips ruined by forgotten equipment to risk leaving anything behind.

Soon after setting out on foot, I proposed that we take a ten-minute detour to a hidden lake. After expressing some city-boy paranoia about bears, they opted to wait for me on the trail. In all my years of hiking this route, I'd never seen so much as a grizzly's toenail clipping. The moon had turned the lake into something out of a Bob Ross painting, all peaceful reflection and happy little trees. I stood there congratulating myself on my woodland sophistication, master of all I surveyed.

There's a particular kind of silence in the mountains that tells you you're being watched, and not by something that wants to discuss literature. My flashlight beam revealed what appeared to be a family portrait from Hell: two grizzly cubs, looking as innocent as loaded weapons, and beyond them, their mother—whose eyes reflected my light with all the warmth of someone who's just found you eating the lunch they'd clearly labeled in the office fridge.

The debate between fight or flight is really only theoretical until you're faced with a thousand pounds of maternal instinct wrapped in muscle and claws. My body made an executive decision, bypassing all the usual committees and subcommittees of conscious thought. My legs, operating on an independent power supply, initiated what can only be described as an Olympic-qualifying sprint. I blew past my waiting friends, managing only to scream

“BEAAARGH!” which, because of my velocity, would have been warped by the Doppler effect.

Within moments, they ran past me, their sensible, gear-free bodies easily outpacing my REI-encumbered frame. I didn’t look back. Whether mama bear had chosen to pursue her flight-risk dinner or simply returned to her cubs remains one of life’s great mysteries, as I was too busy testing the land-speed capabilities of a human being carrying his body weight in fishing equipment.

Running, it turns out, has a finite supply, and I had reached the bottom of mine. What happened next exists in my memory as a series of disconnected images: dirt suddenly very close to my face, the weight of my ridiculous pack pinning me to the earth, and then...nothing. I came to what could have been minutes or hours later, face-down on the trail. My flashlight had disappeared. I called out to Aidan and Michael, but the night offered only the sort of silence that makes you wonder if the entire evening had been some sort of elaborate mountain fever dream.

After peeling myself off the trail, I shed my portable sporting goods store and began a blind man’s scavenger hunt. There, taunting me from the depths of a ravine, was my flashlight—its beam pointing cheerfully skyward.

The descent to retrieve it was forty-five minutes of fumbling, sliding, quietly cursing, and loudly cursing. I emerged victorious, though looking like I’d lost a fight with several bushes. Back at my

gear cache, I played amateur detective. The trail told a promising story: no bear prints (suggesting my ursine acquaintances had better things to do than chase idiots) and two sets of human footprints continuing upward (indicating my friends had survived their sprint into darkness).

Hoisting my pack back on—a process that involved more grunting than I care to admit—I followed their tracks like a heavily encumbered bloodhound. A mile later, I found them sprawled on the trail, looking like marathon dropouts. The prospect of continuing our midnight hike to the lake suddenly seemed about as appealing as nude ice fishing. Besides, after my unexpected brief dirt nap, my internal GPS had all the reliability of a chocolate sundial. We opted to make camp right there on the trail.

It was then that my friends' optimistic approach to wilderness preparation became apparent. Neither had packed a sleeping bag. My compulsive overpacking suddenly seemed less ridiculous. I produced three emergency sleeping arrangements: two "sleeping bags" and one "emergency blanket"—all made from the sort of metallic material that would make Uncle Larry's tinfoil-wrapped cabin look like reinforced steel by comparison. Still harboring some resentment about the frozen sausage incident and our subsequent banishment from Dillon's only supermarket, I made an executive decision about the distribution of comfort. Aidan and I claimed the sleeping bags, such as they were. Mike got the metallic sheet, which

prompted the night's most obvious revelation: "It's...it's...just a sheet!"

To which the universe replied: Sheet happens.

The temperature dropped until the air itself felt brittle enough to snap. Aidan, driven to the kind of creativity only hypothermia can inspire, decided to seal himself completely inside his bag—a strategy that worked perfectly until basic biology intervened. By morning, he had effectively created his own personal cold storage unit, his sleeping bag transformed into a soggy cocoon that had him shivering like a washing machine on spin cycle.

I woke at one point to what I genuinely thought was a massive predator looming over me, its shape thrashing against the moonlight. My heart attempted to exit my throat before I realized it was my own sleeping bag, now reduced to ribbons in the wind. The emergency blankets, it turned out, had all the durability of wet tissue paper and provided about as much warmth as a screen door on a submarine.

No one slept at all. When dawn arrived, I produced three cans of soup and a backpacking stove—another triumph of preparedness undermined by reality. After ten minutes of heating, the soup remained stubbornly solid, like a small, cylindrical glacier. Our only hope for sustenance now lay in our ability to catch fish, a prospect that seemed about as promising as our attempts at sleep had been.

Dawn revealed what might generously be called a planning

oversight: we had spent the night shivering approximately one hundred feet from our destination. I assembled my fishing gear with frozen fingers, with the dedication of someone who had just survived a night in what amounted to aluminum foil pajamas. As I launched my float tube onto Sawtooth Lake, the sun crested the Pioneers like nature's way of saying, "See? Wasn't all that suffering worth it?" And for once, nature wasn't being sarcastic.

That morning, the lake's surface erupted with feeding golden trout, as if the fish had been waiting all night to put on a show for three sleep-deprived fools. We were catching them so fast it felt like cheating.

Just as I was settling into a well-earned moment of triumph, the distinctive thump-thump-thump of helicopter blades shattered our solitude. Helicopters in these mountains were rare, but this one came equipped with a massive bucket swinging beneath it like a giant tea strainer dangling from the sky. The chopper hovered directly over the lake, its side door open wide, revealing someone gesturing with urgency. I waved back, pleased with myself for being so friendly.

It was then that my brain finally processed what my eyes had been trying to tell it: beyond the helicopter, smoke was cresting the ridge like a dark tide, and firefighters were sprinting down the mountain. I awkwardly paddled to shore, where firefighters converged on us. The foreman spoke. The helicopter, I learned, had been attempting to scoop water from the lake to fight the

approaching inferno, but couldn't safely do so because some idiot in a float tube was bobbing around in their dipping zone.



Still operating under the delusion that this was merely an inconvenient interruption to our fishing triumph, I began meticulously gutting my catch and organizing my gear. A firefighter, probably questioning how someone could simultaneously be smart enough to breathe yet dumb enough to clean fish in the path of a wildfire, finally broke through my haze of denial: “You need to run. NOW!”

There’s something about the word “NOW!” delivered by a professional firefighter that really gets the blood pumping. I began stuffing trout into every available pocket like a squirrel preparing for an apocalyptic winter, while Mike and Aidan, displaying considerably more survival instinct, abandoned their catch and turned tail. With my fishing pole in one hand, a trout in the other, and what felt like an entire sporting goods store still strapped to my back, I joined the evacuation parade down the mountain.

The trail told a sobering story: large sections were completely charred, still radiating heat from the fire’s recent passage. In a moment of delayed revelation, it occurred to me that while we’d been fleeing bears and freezing in our foil wrappings the previous night, we’d unknowingly been playing an extremely high-stakes game of leapfrog with a forest fire.

After six and a half miles of running down a mountain with trout-filled pockets, we stumbled into what appeared to be a

convention of every government vehicle ever manufactured, all accompanied by their respective uniformed owners. The reception committee's mood suggested we'd graduated from mere idiots to criminal masterminds, having apparently achieved the rare distinction of disrupting an entire wildfire operation. As various badges and patches took turns explaining exactly how many federal regulations we'd violated, Aidan experienced what we would later describe as divine intervention in the form of his former next-door neighbor from Tucson. There she stood, sporting the high-ranking insignia that makes other badges nervous.

Of all the trailheads in all the forests in all of Montana, she had to be at this one. It was the sort of coincidence that makes the lottery look reasonable. Without her intervention, I suspect we'd still be explaining ourselves to increasingly higher levels of government officials, eventually ending with a congressional hearing about the national security implications of float tube fishing.

The Stormy Stakeout

It was just after sunset in 2003 when Jennie's call disrupted what had been a perfectly ordinary evening. Her voice dropped to a whisper that spelled trouble—she needed me to come to the house where she was housesitting for her chemistry teacher. Something had gone wrong, though she was suspiciously light on details. I didn't wait for elaboration. Within minutes, I was speeding across town, leaving a half-eaten dinner.

Mother Nature chose that night to unleash an Arizona monsoon. Blue skies vanished, replaced by a wall of water that reduced my windshield wipers to useless plastic flags. Rain hammered the earth while gusts of wind battered my car, testing for weakness in the metal and glass. Lightning split the sky in brilliant forks, followed by thunder that shook the ground.

The moment my finger reached for the doorbell, the door burst

open. There was Jennie, crouched like a sprinter at the blocks. No pleasantries—just a finger pressed to lips and an urgent command to hit the floor. When mystery presents itself so directly, you adapt. I dropped, crawling behind her through the shadowed maze of her teacher’s home. Lights, apparently, would give us away to whatever threat lurked beyond. Like seasoned operatives, we slithered toward the house’s rear, where Jennie gestured toward the window. “Slowly,” she whispered.

And so, with bomb-squad delicacy, I lifted my gaze above the sill. The tempestuous desert night demanded patience from my eyes—like emerging from bright sun into a lightless room. When vision finally crystallized, it revealed...an education. There, perhaps twenty yards distant, a man stood beneath his porch eave, commandeering his private stage.

In deference to this book’s family audience, I’ll paint with careful strokes: our protagonist was engaged in a passionate solo performance—and “passionate” truly understates the vigor and artistry. I remained transfixed for what any straight man might deem an unseemly duration. But how could one look away? An exhibitionist is one thing—but one who takes his craft outdoors during nature’s own dramatic display? That’s not just audacity; it’s practically avant-garde!

My first impulse sparked vigilante dreams: storm into the deluge, righteousness in one hand and phone to police in the other. But

Jennie, ever diplomatic, proposed gentler tactics: alert her chemistry teacher, approaching the situation as one might handle fine china wrapped in newspaper.

She dialed, her voice dropping to unfamiliar depths as she translated the backyard theater into language that wouldn't send her teacher reaching for restorative tonics. After the third incredulous "You're joking, right?", he prescribed a "wait and see" approach—perhaps unable to reconcile his yard's new role as an adult entertainment venue.

Thus came Jennie's request for reinforcements, an impromptu night watch which I accepted. After all, what are boyfriends for, if not to keep company while a neighbor engages in X-rated outdoor activities during a monsoon?

Deep in those witching hours, Jennie's sleep was interrupted by the whisper of paw prints—at least she hoped they were canine—padding through the house. Yet she wondered how this was possible when her teacher's dogs lived outside. She quickly awakened her night watchman.

Our investigation revealed a scene worthy of pulp fiction: a window gaped open, its screen lying askew. Someone had slipped through storm and shadow, entering the house under the cover of darkness! And in doing so, the intruder allowed the curious canines to trespass as well. The plot, as they say, had not just thickened—it had congealed.

Morning light brought fresh urgency, and Jennie sought her teacher's counsel—only to find silence. Do we call the police? Ultimately we decided against it, because of uncertainty. So I channeled my inner Sherlock, combing the house for traces of our midnight visitor. The search yielded nothing but empty corners. My frustration simmered as puzzle pieces clicked into place. I reported to Jennie: Our exhibitionist neighbor opened the window to enter the house, possibly for some kind of twisted encore, until the dogs intervened. Canine interruptus.

For the rest of that day, the teacher's residence became a fortress of vigilance. We jumped at shadows and grew eyes in the backs of our heads. We were all but etching tally marks on the wall, marking time like prisoners of our own paranoia, committed to a defensive posture against the symphony of desert sounds that could mask the approach of Tucson's least clothed criminal.

As dusk fell, I decided it was high time I hit the emergency stop switch of this sordid carousel. I readied myself to capture our rogue's next exhibition on film—the kind of evidence that would have judge and jury wincing through his indiscretions as they rendered judgment.

In those days, I carried a disposable camera in my car like a boy scout's Swiss Army knife—ever prepared. Camera phones were still just whispered prophecies among tech enthusiasts, so we relied on these humble devices to capture fleeting moments. Tonight, this

simple memory-maker would document something of the unsavory variety.

As twilight surrendered to darkness, the heavens orchestrated another monsoon masterpiece. Wind howled its aria while rain performed its sideways ballet. Such meteorological drama would surely deter even the most dedicated exhibitionist from his evening pursuits. I melted into the cushions with false comfort. Then came that gasp—the kind that slices through storm-song and electrifies nerves. I spun to find Jennie’s face painted with unmistakable meaning: our private screening of *The Full Monty* had begun. No words needed; our recent vigilance had forged its own silent language. I launched into action.

Propelled by monsoon-fueled determination, I burst through the front door like a man on a mission from the gods of decency. Racing around the house’s edge, I transformed from upright citizen to ground-bound operative. With surprising foresight, I’d wrapped both my trusty disposable camera and equally dependable flip phone—cutting-edge technology for its time—in protective plastic.

The mud became my unwitting accomplice as I snaked across this backyard battlefield, creeping toward our neighborhood scandal’s ground zero. Stealth was hardly necessary; the mud did a splendid job of masking my advance, as I became a mobile mud sculpture.

At last, I reached my chosen vantage, estimating our brazen performer stood mere yards away. Seeking confirmation from

someone whose vision was not hindered by a barrage of mud splatter, I placed a call to headquarters. Wind and rain orchestrated chaos against my ear, yet through nature's fury came Jennie's voice, crystalline and spine-chilling: "He's still there!" Those words rang pure as monastery bells, and I knew—it was snapshot time.

I bolted upright, camera ready. But as my finger hovered over the shutter button, I found only emptiness—our subject had melted into the storm. I pirouetted in confusion, every nerve screaming questions: *Had he spotted me? Was he lurking nearby? Am I ready to mud wrestle a naked man?*

Heart drumming an SOS, I called Jennie again. "He's right in front of you!" Her words hit like arctic rain. My insides performed acrobatics. Panic took hold, and I retreated a good fifteen feet. I turned back. There he stood once again, shameless in his exhibition. *Gotcha!*

But as I charged forward, camera raised like the sword of justice, reality twisted. He evaporated, as if he was a figment of my overactive imagination. The downpour wasn't merely obscuring my sight—it was weaving illusions. I cleared my eyes, peering through sheets of water for another glimpse, but he was gone. One step back, and like some perverse game of pornographic peek-a-boo, he materialized anew. This was no exhibitionist magician; this was something altogether different.

After what seemed an endless tango of advance and retreat, the

bizarre truth dawned on me. Our menacing exhibitionist? Nothing more than a patio umbrella, its crank handle dancing in savage winds and porch light, transforming into a phantom of scandalous proportions. At precise distance and angle, it rivaled any Vegas performance. Not a pervert after all, just a monsoon mirage.



I trudged back to Jennie, mud-painted and waterlogged, my foolishness heavier than my rain-soaked clothes. Her phone nearly slipped from stunned fingers as I explained the tempest's sleight of hand, and the umbrella's masquerade.

The subsequent conversation with her chemistry teacher was one for the ages. As it turned out, his canine companion had a penchant for breaking and entering during inclement weather—a rather anticlimactic finale to our night of intrigue.

In the calm after our storm-chasing escapade, Uncle Steve—a man who understood the importance of commemorating such monumental embarrassments—sent a package. Inside lay the “Pink Panther Umbrella Award,” now a fixture on my desk, serving as a tribute to life’s uncertainties and the humble pie we all, at times, are forced to dine on. It’s a reminder that the thing we understand so clearly might just be a crank handle in the storm.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Rod Race

Summer—the divine stretch of months that allowed me to revel in the natural splendors of the Rockies, a veritable Eden if Eden had trout streams. I was a devotee in the cathedrals of Idaho, Montana, and Wyoming, praising the holy trinity of Hiking, Fishing, and Just Existing In Gorgeous Surroundings. On one particularly hot day, Grandpa Fitzwater proposed a jaunt to Clark Canyon Reservoir. Normally, the idea of reservoir fishing ranked somewhere between dental surgery and attending a four-hour mime show. But grandpa was the exception to every rule, so I leapt at the chance. Plus, this was Jennie's first time fishing and it would be a good warmup.

As we launched the boat on the south end of the reservoir, alongside the Red Rock River outlet, a fellow fisherman was just starting to pack up. I could tell he was frustrated, and the tone of his voice confirmed my suspicions. "You're wasting your time; there's

nothing biting today,” he mumbled. I gave him a nod—sort of an emotional tip of the hat—but we carried on.

Grandpa Fitzwater, who was eighty-four and still rowed like he was escaping Alcatraz, wouldn't let anyone else man the oars. Trying to reason with him about this was like trying to explain to a cat why it shouldn't knock things off a table. So we compromised, sort of; I convinced him to fish the river outlet near the boat ramp so he wouldn't have to row far.

On hot days such as this, I would typically take seriously the task of locating the thermocline. I would use an old thermometer attached to a long cord, carefully lowering it to find that critical layer where the water temperature changes abruptly. Above this layer, the water is generally warmer, enriched by wind and sunlight. Below it, the water is colder and less affected by what happens at the surface. This layer acts as a sort of barrier, limiting the movement of nutrients and oxygen between the two zones. For many fish species, the thermocline essentially becomes a floor they prefer not to cross, choosing instead to stay in the warmer, oxygen-rich waters above. It's vital information for any fisherman.

But here's the kicker: in the swelter of summer, especially in a deep reservoir, the thermocline can actually act more like a ceiling for some fish, notably rainbow trout. These fish are like the Goldilocks of the fish world; they thrive in water that's not too hot, not too cold, but just right—somewhere between 55 and 65°F. As the

sun beats down, warming the surface layer, the water above the thermocline can turn into a veritable hot tub, far too balmy for these cold-water aficionados. Below the thermocline, however, the temperature remains comfortably cool and often even offers a richer oxygen environment.

But this year was a moderate drought. Near the boat ramp, the water was so shallow the concept of a thermocline was almost laughable. A novice fisherman might head for deeper waters, assuming that's where the sanctuary of a thermocline might be found. Yet the intricacies of fish behavior aren't so easily distilled. You see, the Red Rock River feeds into the reservoir not far from where we were, offering another oasis for the trout. They tend to congregate near inlets like this, where fresh, cool, oxygen-rich water flows in, providing a much-needed respite from the summer heat. It's as if nature, in its unending complexity, offered multiple VIP lounges for our piscine friends.

In years punctuated by extreme droughts, the creek would often have to meander further to meet the reservoir, carving an extended riverbed along the way. In more water-blessed years, this added stretch of river would be submerged, concealed beneath the surface of the reservoir like a hidden passage in an old castle. The existence of this underwater stream bed isn't just geographical trivia; it plays a role in directing the flow of water as the river joins the reservoir.

While even the most advanced fish finder gadgets of the era

would scratch their electronic heads trying to detect this underwater feature, Grandpa Fitzwater was in his element. The former game warden knew the landscape of southwest Montana. To him, this invisible channel was as real as the lines on his weathered palms. With unerring accuracy, he rowed us to the exact spot above that submerged stream bed, anchoring us over a secret world that most would pass over, none the wiser.

I was practically buzzing with anticipation for this outing, not just because of the secret spot Grandpa had led us to, but because I had recently acquired two sparkling new fishing rods—one for me and one for Jennie. Fresh off the shelf, they still had that new-rod gleam. As we adjusted our lines to the right depth, Jennie put her rod down for a moment to roll up her pants leg. Perhaps the untested equipment made me overzealous, but I seized the chance to impart some hard-won fishing wisdom. “You might want to keep an eye on that rod,” I said. But before the final syllable had left my lips, her rod shot over the side of the boat like an Olympic diver going for gold, disappearing into the depths below.

Eyes locked onto the water’s surface, I spotted the runaway rod cutting through the depths like a torpedo. That fish had ambition! “Grandpa, follow that rod!”

The boat sprang into motion, with me serving as navigator, squinting to keep sight of the speeding rod’s underwater trajectory as it traveled in a northeasterly direction. Grandpa, stationed in the

heart of the boat, rowed with the fervor of a man half his age. Meanwhile, Jennie was on damage control, hastily reeling in the remaining lines to avoid any oar entanglements. We were a well-oiled machine, united in a singular, if somewhat peculiar, quest: the retrieval of a fishing rod with ambitions of its own.

Several hundred feet and countless rowing strokes later, the runaway rod ran out of steam. It came to rest in a shallow, weedy area, hovering about four feet below the surface. Either the fish had given up its dreams of freedom, or it had found solace among the flora. Carefully, I positioned my own rod above the water and began the delicate operation. Like a surgeon guiding a laparoscope, I gently nudged my rod underneath Jennie's and started lifting. Once it broke the water's surface, I handed it back to her, the prodigal rod returned.

"Well, reel it in!" I said, grinning from ear to ear. This was, after all, still a fishing trip, and we had a fish to catch. And wouldn't you know it: after a spirited tussle, Jennie reeled in a rainbow trout that was nothing short of majestic. At twenty-seven inches, it was the kind of catch that could be the crown jewel of an entire season.



As the adrenaline of our rod-chasing escapade ebbed away, we circled back to our initial haunt, pulling in several more respectable rainbow trout in no time. Before we knew it, we'd reached our catch limit. As we approached our pullout, I noticed the same naysaying fisherman from earlier, now munching on what seemed like a consolation snack. He had clearly been watching our lakefront drama unfold, and if looks could speak, his would've recited a novella of grudging admiration mixed with bitterness. His eyes met ours, and the look was a cocktail of disbelief, envy, and resignation. Ah well, some days the dragon wins—and that fine summer day, we were the dragon.

The Living Legend

When I told my grandfather I worked on Internet Explorer at Microsoft, his eyes lit up with pride. He'd served as a game warden in Montana for decades, mapping wilderness and blazing trails, and now here was his grandson, carrying on the family tradition of exploration—a kind of cartographic conquest, perhaps. I didn't have the heart to tell him my exploration involved sitting in an air-conditioned office, debugging code. That my frontier was made of pixels and protocols, not mountains and meadows.

In my grandfather's world, strength had weight and substance. It moved barns from one side of a property to another because they "needed to be somewhere else"—a concept my generation would have turned into a six-month planning committee. It cleared acres of brush and trees from my mother's Arizona property through sheer force of will. It woke up one morning in Tucson and decided to hike

the entire Rincon mountain range with nothing but a canteen and a pocketknife, returning two weeks later as if it had been a casual stroll—though he did admit the prickly pears had given him a bit of trouble.



As a boy, I once paraded around in his war medals, pinning them crookedly to my Superman t-shirt. They hung at odd angles, clinking together as I marched through the living room. I remember the weight of them against my chest, how important they felt, though I didn't understand their meaning. I wonder what Grandpa Wayne thought, watching me play at being him. I was pretending at wearing his strength, while having no idea what strength really meant.

The medals stayed a mystery for decades. Grandpa was too busy living his next chapter to dwell on his last one. He wore a small pin that read "I AM QUITE DEAF," which seemed like just another quirk, like his unfailing dedication to sending handwritten letters for every occasion, each one carefully embellished and filled with pages of thoughtful words. But there were stories behind that pin, stories I wouldn't hear until I asked him to write his memoir.

We were sitting in his trailer, which he had driven to Arizona to escape Montana's winter, when he finally shared them. His voice, always steady and clear, took on a different quality as he spoke of enlisting and joining the First Infantry Division—the Big Red One. "We had a reputation to uphold," he said. I heard something rare in his voice: pride.

The training stories came first—obstacle courses, ship-to-shore landings, the cramped quarters of the Queen Mary crossing the Atlantic. But it was Operation Torch invasion that changed

everything. I sat there, tea growing cold in my hands, as he described the Mediterranean waters, the weight of gear, the loss of life. His matter-of-fact tone made it all the more powerful: the bullets that struck his leg, then his chest, then his side. The dog tags that saved his life. The final shot that shattered his thigh, leaving bone exposed.

What struck me most was how he described playing dead as German soldiers approached—the smell of their boot polish, the sound of their rifles, the kick to his side that must have been excruciating. A French nurse who gave her own blood to save him. Major General Terry Allen presenting his Purple Heart. They were pieces of a puzzle I'd been trying to solve my whole life: how had this humble, extraordinary man come to be?

After our talk about the war, I noticed how his game warden stories took on new meaning. The way he'd freed himself from his own bear trap was the same determination that had kept him alive on that North African beach. His rescue of my mother and their dog during a blizzard, using an elk carcass for shelter, showed the same quick thinking that had served him in combat.

In 2006, at the age of eighty-three, my grandfather stood before Senator Conrad Burns and the Chairman of the Congressional Armed Services Committee in Helena, Montana. The ceremony took place outside, the light filtering through the trees. His uniform had long been lost to time, so he wore a secondhand shirt from the thrift

store. As they pinned each medal to his chest—the bronze star, the combat wounded purple heart, the combat infantry badge, and a constellation of other honors—his weathered hands remained steady at his sides. I thought back on the little boy that had played dress-up with his medals, and felt the weight of all the years between these two moments. My grandfather's face remained composed, but a slight tremor in his jaw could be seen, the kind that appears when a man who has spent a lifetime being strong finally allows himself to be recognized for it. The chairman read citations that turned battlefield chaos into orderly sentences, while my grandfather stood at perfect attention, as if the decades since his service had dissolved and he was once again that young soldier in Algeria. Recognition, even delayed by sixty years, carries its own kind of power—not in the metal and ribbon of the medals themselves, but in the public acknowledgement of a private strength that had shaped not just his life, but all of ours.



Sometimes I stand in front of my bathroom mirror, searching my face for traces of him. For evidence of the DNA that had survived gunfire and moved mountains. Most days I can't see it. But I can feel something else—a different kind of deafness creeping in.

His came honestly—artillery fire and survival carved into his

flesh until he needed that small pin: "I AM QUITE DEAF." Mine comes quietly, in the soft death of climate-controlled rooms and ergonomic chairs, in the gentle click of keyboards that never bite back. His generation's hearing loss was earned in the cacophony of combat. Ours is chosen in the numbing comfort of screens and safety.

But then I catch myself doing something impossibly hard just because it needs doing, and I realize: maybe the greatest achievement of our ancestors wasn't surviving their wars. Maybe it was making us believe we could survive our own. I'll never hike the Rincons with a canteen and a knife. But I carry the same relentless drive that made Grandpa think these things were not just possible, but necessary. The same stubborn refusal to accept that something can't be done.

MERRILL WAYNE
FITZWATER

1918



2018

WILDLIFE OFFICER OF THE
YEAR - 1970

M.L.E. ACADEMY GRADUATE

OTTO FOSSEN AWARD

1968 PISTOL CHAMPION

1 INFANTRY DIVISION
EUROPEAN THEATRE WW II
INFANTRY SQUAD SGT.

PURPLE HEART

BRONZE STAR

COMBAT INF. BADGE

MEMBER DILLON ELKS
LODGE - 1554

LIFE MEMBER - D.A.V. & N.R.A.

The Cable Conundrum

I went into a technical interview not knowing the first thing about how to interview for a job. There's a chance I didn't even know what "stage freight" was, although I was about to experience it. Early on during this sit-down, my first shot at the big leagues, I was asked for my date of birth, and I blanked.

"I'll have to get back to you on that," I heard myself say, as if my birth date was some obscure mathematical theorem I needed to verify back in the lab.

There's something uniquely humbling about forgetting your own date of birth as the people you want to impress stare at you. It's like being asked your name at a coffee shop and suddenly wondering if you've been "Steve" all along.

That interview kicked off what I lovingly call my "Tour de Fails"—a string of technical interviews where my tongue seemed

permanently tied into a sailor's knot. Each company became another stop on my grand comedy tour, though I was the only one laughing (and only later, much later). By the time I got to Google and Microsoft, I had reached that special zen state of not-giving-a-damn that only comes after thoroughly embarrassing yourself multiple times. And wouldn't you know it? Both companies offered me jobs. The universe, it seems, has a peculiar sense of humor.

By then, I'd been grinding away at a Tucson startup for five years, having started there during my junior year of college. The work was great, but Arizona summers are like living in a hair dryer set to "broil," and I was ready for bigger technical challenges that didn't involve spontaneous combustion. So when Microsoft's offer landed in my lap, it felt like winning a ticket to both career advancement and cooler weather. Washington state beckoned with its cloudy skies and tech-giant status.

The Microsoft campus in Puget Sound was a sprawling megavillage with more buildings than a small European duchy. Think of it as the Riviera for the introverted—only instead of beaches, you get clusters of software geeks sandwiched between Starbucks and cloud cover. There I was, a baby-faced software engineer hobnobbing with the high priests and priestesses in the hallowed Windows division. It was like being called up from the kids' table at Thanksgiving to sip actual wine, but the wine is made of ones and zeros and a dash of social anxiety.

One afternoon, in one of the many conference rooms, I awkwardly fidgeted while presenting a new technical design. The place had all the ambiance of an interrogation chamber in a Scandinavian crime drama. And speaking of crimes, I was committing the one I always do: fiddling with random objects when nervous. This time, it was a network cable.

We wrapped the meeting up and I headed back to my office. You know how you can feel the atmosphere change before a thunderstorm? The corridors were filled with actual chatter—like seeing Bigfoot, you document it because nobody would believe it otherwise. I soon found out the corporate network was down. When the network goes out at Microsoft, let's just say it's akin to a Chicago bar running out of alcohol on St. Patrick's Day.

Minutes stretched like taffy into hours. With no progress in sight, some of us were calculating, in real-time, how much money Microsoft was burning on our collective downtime. It was like watching a cash bonfire.

Then, as abruptly as it had disappeared, the network flickered back to life. A post-mortem email explained the drama: a sweaty network engineer had burst into a conference room like he was diffusing a bomb and unplugged a network cable. The resemblance between his actions and mine was too uncanny. I had picked up that very cable, and without thinking plugged it into a jack. Unknowingly, the other end was also plugged in, thus creating

what's known as a packet storm, a form of denial-of-service attack. I was the culprit, the Phantom of the Ethernet!

I was sweating like a turkey on Thanksgiving Eve, figuring my next gig would be as a stand-up comedian—with no audience because who'd want to come near me after this? I replied-all, apologizing for the inconvenience, fully expecting an e-lynching.

But here's the kicker: My inbox got flooded with mostly positive reactions, and they ranged from "Oh, you!" to "You just made my day!" Apparently, I'd offered the best comic relief since Clippy, the Microsoft Office Assistant. I wasn't fired, even though the next day my badge gave up on me temporarily, giving me a minor panic attack—yet another absurd twist in my Microsoft tragicomedy.

I kept my job, got a new badge, and earned the kind of workplace street cred you just can't buy. All it took was tanking the network of one of the world's most powerful tech companies.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Obsession's Oath

South Korea's financial system crashed on a Tuesday. The bug report arrived without drama—just another item in the queue at Microsoft's Building 50. Banks were down. Credit cards stopped processing. Millions of people stared at error messages instead of their bank accounts. A single flaw in ActiveX controls, a technology that let websites interact with users' computers through Internet Explorer, had brought a nation to its knees.

Ed Praitis took charge with his characteristic calm. I'd seen him approach impossible problems before, each one met with an optimistic steadiness that made you believe any system was salvageable, any crisis containable. Ed would die years later, bicycling down Union Hill Road toward this same building, this same pursuit of solutions. But that morning, he was there when we needed him most, leading us through the maze of code that

controlled a nation's economy. We wrote code that ran the world. Sometimes the world wrote back.

Time dissolves when you're deep enough in the code. I'd look up from my screen to realize days had passed, emerging blurry-eyed and slightly feral. No deadline loomed, no crisis demanded attention, no midnight deployment had gone wrong. Just problems that needed solving, systems that could work better than they did. For over a decade, time passed like this—a blur of fluorescent lights and humming servers, of solutions spawning new fascinating problems.

Deep problem-solving sends a vibration through your skull, a low hum that builds and builds until your brain feels wired directly to the power line. Your body becomes an inconvenient afterthought, a vessel for carrying caffeine to consciousness. What drove me to map every inch of my childhood backyard, certain that treasure lay around the next bush, now expressed itself in finding vulnerabilities others had missed, each discovery a new doorway. The world revealed itself in logic, but only if you knew its weaknesses. And I was built to find them.

My career shifted like tectonic plates beneath my keyboard. After Microsoft, I moved through worlds that couldn't have been more different. Disney's corporate polish felt worlds apart from the startup that rolled a booze cart through the office every Friday, or the one where the CEO awarded stock options to the winner of the

Christmas party limbo contest—a particularly cruel form of compensation that assumed both physical flexibility and the company's continued existence. Microsoft split the difference—professional but increasingly casual as the years wore on, our building a maze of identical corridors and conference rooms named after mountains we'd never climb. Throughout my tenure at various companies, we shaped digital empires from these fluorescent-lit rooms, our fingers on keyboards controlling systems that moved billions of dollars, connected millions of people, stored the world's knowledge.

The office kitchen's lights would hum at 3 a.m. as I scrounged through drawers for forgotten snacks, finding a packet of crackers that expired sometime during the Bush administration—though which Bush, I couldn't say. The cleaning crew would give me the same bemused looks they'd probably once given to the campus raccoons. We were all nocturnal creatures now, though they at least had the dignity of doing their job during designated quiet hours.

My escapes to the Rockies dwindled to memory. Vacation meant the occasional weekend in Vegas—quick, structured, urban. When friends mentioned hiking or fishing, I'd nod. The mountains that had once been sanctuary became theoretical places, reduced to conference room names. Nature existed in a parallel runtime environment, one that required too many context switches to access. I told myself I'd return when things settled down, knowing they

never would. The wild places that had shaped me waited patiently while I shaped digital landscapes instead.

The money came, yes—stock options, bonuses, startup acquisitions, and investments. In 2003, between projects, I recognized a pattern of a different kind. Netflix was still focused entirely on DVDs, those red envelopes showing up in millions of mailboxes. But their technical architecture—the way they handled inventory systems, the sophistication of their recommendation algorithms, the structure of their APIs—suggested a company building for something far beyond physical media. The same instinct that helped me spot edge cases in code showed me the edges of their ambition. I scraped together enough money to buy shares. Digital distribution wasn't a possibility yet—but its foundation was being laid in every technical decision they made. The investment multiplied, but I barely noticed. The ability to read systems, to see their future in their architecture, was intoxicating in a way money never could be. I was too deep in the next problem, the next challenge, the next impossible thing that needed solving.

We commanded digital armies from ergonomic chairs, our commits and deploys reshaping the landscape of human interaction. Sometimes the power was abstract—chat platforms expanding to serve millions of concurrent users, payment systems moving invisible money. Other times it was tangibly real—working with Disney's Imagineers, where software met storytelling, where lines of

code manifested as real magic for millions of guests. One day you're designing systems to handle ten million streaming subscribers in twenty-four hours, the next you're building APIs that will guide developers for decades. Each solution spawned ten more fascinating problems, a fractal of endless possibility. We were gods of our digital domains, yet somehow powerless before the basic demands of our bodies.

Ed used to say that every system fails where theory meets practice. He'd say it with that same calm smile, whether hunting down memory leaks or explaining why a particular architecture wouldn't scale. His calm, however, was like a foreign language to me.

People talk about burnout like it's a failure of balance, but they misunderstand the nature of true obsession. Balance was never the goal. There's no balance in a hundred-and-twenty-hour work-week, in the kind of focus that makes you forget to eat, in the sort of drive that turns months into a single continuous problem to be solved. You don't balance an obsession—you feed it, or it feeds on you.

It started with a whisper—a stiffness in the shoulders, a twinge in the lower back. Easy enough to ignore when you're building high-throughput, low-latency ingestion systems that process petabytes of data. The discomfort grew slowly. Hours dissolved into an elaborate dance: shifting positions, propping feet, transforming my ergonomic chair into a gymnasium of twisted limbs. The awards accumulated—

Engineering Excellence, Trustworthy Computing, patents with my name inscribed in careful legalese. I accepted them standing awkwardly, body rigid with pain I hadn't yet learned to name.

Then came the floor phase. One evening found me wedged between desk and wall, laptop propped on my chest, debugging code that controlled massive data flows across continents. Nights stretched into mornings as I chased down edge cases in content delivery systems, spine curved like a question mark. The position should have been uncomfortable, but discomfort had become just another background process, something to be managed and minimized.

I lived in that state of perpetual chase for over a decade. When I wasn't working, I was thinking about work. When I slept, I dreamed in algorithms. Each success just opened the door to more complex challenges, some visible to the world, others deliberately invisible. Every project was a new depth to explore. Time measured itself in commits and deployments, in system uptimes and response latencies. Ed's death barely registered as an interruption in the flow of code, yet it echoed through the corridors of Building 50.

When I read about Forrest's treasure, the article mentioned a bronze chest hidden somewhere in the Rockies. But what caught me wasn't the promise of gold. It was the recognition that the force driving me through endless nights of code could find its twin in sunbaked canyons. The mountain doesn't care about your

ergonomic chair. The wind won't debug your approach. Nature runs on its own immutable code.

At first, Fenn's treasure was just another puzzle—a system to be understood, a pattern to be decoded. The same obsessive focus that kept me tethered to screens now pulled me toward topographical maps and historical records. But something shifted when I first stood in those canyons, my boots crunching on ancient rock. I remembered the child who had mapped every inch of his backyard, who felt alive in both mind and body during the search. That kid knew something I'd forgotten in the fluorescent glow of endless debugging sessions—the profound satisfaction of a hunt that engages both intellect and instinct.

The treasure hunt offered a bridge between worlds. Here was a puzzle that demanded not just mental acuity but physical presence, a challenge that couldn't be solved through API calls or system architecture. In those sun-scorched valleys, I found what streams of commit messages and deployment logs couldn't provide—a reconnection to the tangible world beyond the screen. This realization led me to Tucker, a companion who wouldn't let me disappear into digital realms for days on end. The dog needed walks; nature demanded attention. In seeking Fenn's bronze chest, I stumbled upon a different kind of treasure—the reminder that some codes can only be deciphered by leaving the comfort of our carefully constructed systems.

We don't lose ourselves to our obsessions. We give ourselves to them, gladly, completely, relentlessly, regardless of the cost. Because nothing else feels like existing at the edge of your own dissolution—where a single line of code can crash an economy, where an afternoon bicycle ride can end a brilliant mind, where the boundaries between power and powerlessness blur and fade like time in the depths of an endless algorithm.

Grandma's Hands

The summer I went to Space Camp—not the one in Alabama, but the decidedly more modest affair in Alamogordo, New Mexico—Grandma Posey watched her first movie since *Singin' in the Rain*. In the darkness of that theater, while velociraptors hunted children through a gleaming kitchen, I watched her hands. They moved in her lap, weaving invisible threads, a gesture so foreign that for years afterward I questioned whether I had truly seen it. My grandmother's hands were always purposeful, whether kneading dough or pointing out constellations or, most often, shooing rabbits from her tomato plants with the kind of authority that made me wonder if she had some secret agreement with the local wildlife.

The drive home stretched out like a highway in a dream until Grandpa finally spoke: "I think I prefer them jackrabbits to those dinosaurs running around."

Grandma Posey clicked her tongue against her teeth—that familiar percussion of my childhood. “Well,” she said, adjusting her glasses with one finger, “I suppose that’s what comes of people poking around in the past.” She paused, and in the rearview mirror, I caught the familiar glint in her eye. “Though I have to say, if one of those creatures showed up at my garden gate, they’d learn what happens when you cross a Posey. And besides,” she added, patting Grandpa’s arm, “at least a velociraptor would eat the squash bugs.”

For years, that moment in the theater stood alone in my memory—singular, contained. Memory is a trickster that way. In trying to preserve her, I keep returning to this moment—the one time I saw her certainty waver, as if that temporary absence revealed more about her presence than all the years she stood unmoved. Strange how we search for truth in anomalies, how we define the rule by its exception, how we sometimes only recognize bedrock by the way it trembles.



Then came the trip to Tucson. She and Grandpa had driven down for what was meant to be a family reunion, but the circumstances were darker this time. My great aunt Rita Verne had passed, and we had gathered to say goodbye.

Alzheimer's had woven its way into Grandma's memories, blurring the lines between past and present. That afternoon was a flurry of times gone by, with Grandma narrating stories as if she were flipping through an old, dust-speckled photo album. She was eagerly anticipating a reunion with Rita Verne, undeterred by our gentle reminders that we were at Rita Verne's funeral. Every time, the news seemed to land on her anew, a soft surprise, unsettling yet tender. My fear for her mingled with a deep, aching love. Grandma Posey had always been my anchor, her stories a colorful backdrop to my childhood. Watching the threads fray was like watching the end of an era, each moment both precious and fragile.

The afternoon following the funeral in Patagonia, I stumbled upon her in my father's study, lost in thought. She noticed me peering in the doorway and beckoned me over with a flick of her wrist. I joined her, sinking into the study sofa.

Grandma Posey had a way of listening that made you feel like you were the only person in the world. Not like those conversations where you can tell the other person is just perched on the edge of their seat, waiting to leap into their own monologue. No, she harbored a genuine curiosity, a sincere thirst to understand whatever trifling or monumental thoughts you decided to share.

As our conversation continued and the shadows lengthened across the study's dense carpet, she confided in me with a vulnerability that seemed at odds with her usual vigor. "You know,

everyone keeps insisting that I have dementia, that my mind is slipping away. But I feel just as sharp as ever!”

Her voice, usually so sure, wavered a bit. Her hands reached for mine—those hands that had quilted blankets for new babies and wiped away my childhood tears. They felt paper-thin now, but still warm, still strong enough to grip with surprising firmness.

“Listen,” she continued, her eyes locking onto mine with an intensity that rooted me to the spot. The late afternoon sun caught the red in her hair, creating a halo effect that made her seem both fragile and fierce. “If you ever see me losing myself, promise me you’ll tell me. I’d rather take a walk out to the south forty and end it all than become a burden.”

The weight of her words pressed heavily against my chest. Tears burgeoned behind my eyes, and I mustered every bit of composure to keep them at bay, unwilling to fracture the stoic veneer I had crafted for her sake. Her fingers tightened around mine, her wedding ring pressing into my palm. The cruel irony was that Alzheimer’s had already taken hold, its presence clear to all but her. As I sat there, holding Grandma’s hands, I felt a whirlwind of emotions—grief for the aunt we’d lost, fear for the grandmother I was losing, and a desperate desire to freeze time, to keep her mind intact just a little longer. I couldn’t bring myself to shatter her illusion of clarity, so I simply squeezed her hands back, offering what comfort I could in that moment, while the dust motes danced

in the dying light around us.

For years, that moment haunted me—the impossible thing she asked. “Tell me if you see me losing myself,” she said, as if such a thing could be measured, as if there was some clear boundary between presence and absence. But who was she asking? A grandson? A witness? A mirror?

We think we’re islands of consciousness, captains of our own minds. But here was my grandmother, asking me to be her lighthouse keeper, to warn her of the rocks ahead—rocks she had already struck, though she hadn’t felt the impact. The same rocks that wait for all of us, hidden in the fog.

The truth is, we’re all just watching each other, searching for reflections of ourselves in other people’s eyes. I watch you watching me, you watch me watching you, and somewhere in that infinite gaze, we try to find something solid enough to call the self.

When I write these memories now, I think of Grandma Posey in that sun-filled study, her hands warm in mine, asking me to be the guardian of her consciousness. The cruel beauty of it all is that we can never truly be that for each other. We can only bear witness, hold hands in the fading light, and love each other through the uncertainty.

Sometimes, late at night, I catch myself wondering if I, too, will sit in a study someday, just as certain as Grandma Posey was, insisting my mind remains clear as crystal. And perhaps they’ll

squeeze my hands just as I squeezed hers, both of us locked in that timeless moment of watching and being watched, neither of us able to see ourselves clearly, but both of us trying to hold onto something true.

The Bronze Beast

I'd had dogs before. Labs that fancied themselves lapdogs, terriers with egos bigger than their bark, and poodles that silently critiqued my wardrobe choices. I thought I knew dogs. I was practically Dr. Dolittle—minus the ability to chat with animals and the problematic colonial undertones. But nothing—no gnawed shoes, no 3 a.m. emergency walks, not even the occasional “gift” left on the carpet—prepared me for the four-legged whirlwind that swept into my life like a furry tornado.

In November 2012 I cradled an eight-week-old puppy, nameless and brimming with untamed energy. I delayed naming him, waiting for a bolt of inspiration or perhaps divine intervention to deliver the perfect moniker. It seemed only fair to let his budding personality guide the choice.



The first week with this pint-sized cyclone made babysitting a toddler feel like a spa retreat. At least toddlers sleep. This creature? He seemed to have struck a deal with insomnia itself. My exhaustion reached levels typical of new parents or contestants on survival reality shows. By day seven, my brain functioned on par with an unambitious sea cucumber. In this foggy state, we finally christened the beast “Tucker.” Truth be told, I considered a name that rhymed with “Tucker” but was decidedly less appropriate for shouting across a crowded dog park. Imagining the horrified faces of

suburban parents shielding their children's ears, I settled on "Tucker"—a compromise between my fraying sanity and societal norms.

Tucker had two settings: "Tasmanian Devil on espresso" and "comatose." There was no middle ground, no peaceful interlude where he might, say, quietly contemplate the meaning of life or at least let me use the bathroom unaccompanied. For the first year, as his bones and joints developed—presumably into springs and high-tension coils—I had to get creative if I wanted any semblance of rest. I tried everything short of hiring a team of marathon runners to take shifts exercising him. I even fantasized about opening an amusement park called "Puppy Perpetual Motion Land," featuring a hamster wheel the size of the London Eye, complete with a sign that read, "You must be *this* hyper to ride."

It took me a while to realize the key wasn't just physical exhaustion, but mental stimulation—and very particular types of mental stimulation. Here I was, trying to tire out a dog who made the Road Runner look lethargic, when what I really needed to do was to engage his mind.

Tucker's favorite brain game, hands down, was hide-and-seek—but not your run-of-the-mill, hide-ball-behind-the-couch version. We elevated the game to the great outdoors, turning our local forest into a canine version of *National Treasure*. As we meandered down trails, I'd wait for Tucker to become engrossed in something utterly

fascinating—like a leaf or his own tail. Then, I'd stealthily hide freeze-dried liver bits under ferns or in the nooks and crannies at the base of trees. To Tucker, these liver morsels were the caviar of dog treats—the kind of delicacy that would make a Beverly Hills Pomeranian green with envy.

Once my covert operation was complete, I'd catch Tucker's attention. "Where is it?" I'd inquire. In the early days, watching him search was like observing a pinball bounce erratically in a machine. He'd dart from tree to bush to tree in a frenzied ballet of confusion. More often than not, he'd stumble upon his prize by sheer chance, looking as surprised as I did when I found forgotten money in an old coat pocket.

But over time, something clicked in that fuzzy head of his. It was as if he'd discovered his nose was a sophisticated GPS calibrated for liver-scented treasures. The frenetic whirlwind transformed into a focused sleuth. He'd lift his snout, take a few discerning sniffs, and make a beeline for the treat.

As it turned out, Tucker's knack for locating treats was surpassed only by his talent for finding me. Tucker decided that tracking me down was the ultimate game. Occasionally, when he was captivated by a particularly intriguing patch of brush or an especially aromatic piece of who-knows-what, I'd seize the opportunity. I'd slip into the ferns, feeling like a bargain-bin Houdini in hiking boots.

After a few moments—during which I held my breath so

intensely I risked self-induced asphyxiation—Tucker would notice my absence. You could almost see the thought bubble above his head: “Wait, where did my two-legged treat dispenser go?” Then, like a furry Sherlock Holmes, he’d set off on the case.

The game became so addictive that Tucker started giving me a head start. He’d sprint ahead, pausing to throw a glance over his shoulder that clearly said, “Make it challenging this time, human.” Then he’d double back, nose twitching, target acquired.

When he finally unearthed me from my leafy hideout, his excitement could’ve powered a small city. He’d launch himself at me with the force of a cruise missile, subjecting me to a face-washing so thorough I considered canceling my dermatologist appointment. Who needs exfoliation when you have a dog tongue that could strip wallpaper?



One evening, while I was swamped with work, Jennie volunteered to take Tucker on his daily walk. By this point, our six-mile evening treks had evolved into miniature Lewis and Clark expeditions. I wrapped up my work and hatched a plan. I figured they were about four miles in. I'd surprise them by hiding in the

woods along their route.

Crouched behind a tangle of ferns, I heard them approach. Tucker and Jennie rounded the bend. Suddenly, Tucker's nose shot up like an antenna picking up a signal. He froze, sniffing the air with an intensity that suggested he was trying to decode the secrets of the universe. Jennie, unaware of the impending chaos, urged him forward. But Tucker had other ideas. He bolted into the underbrush, dragging poor Jennie along like a tin can behind a newlywed couple's car.

To Jennie's astonishment—and my mix of pride and mild terror—Tucker discovered me in record time. There I was, crouched like a misguided survivalist, suddenly face-to-face with 55 pounds of ecstatic fur and one very bewildered spouse. As Tucker reveled in his victory, his face alight with the joy of a creature who'd just solved the world's greatest mystery, I locked eyes with Jennie. Her expression was a cocktail of confusion, exasperation, and the realization that perhaps she should have heeded the warnings when my father asked at our wedding, “Are you *sure* you want to join this family?”

As time marched on, Tucker and I settled into a routine. Every evening, as the world wound down, we'd embark on our six-mile odyssey through the woods surrounding Novelty Hill. I often wondered if Tucker had an internal pedometer. Six miles, non-negotiable. Any attempt to shorten the journey was met with a look

that contained disappointment and thinly veiled threat, implying I'd pay for this transgression later.

The woods of western Washington became our second home—a place where Tucker could live out his wolfish fantasies and I could ponder life's big questions. Earlier that year, I'd become engrossed in the Forrest Fenn treasure hunt, and our summer expedition had left me with more questions than answers. Now, as we trudged through muddy trails, I found myself dissecting Fenn's cryptic poem, line by enigmatic line.

Our nightly treks became a peculiar merging of dog walking and treasure-hunting symposiums, with Tucker as my silent, if somewhat distracted, confidant. We had our favorite spots: the towering cedar where an owl with a superiority complex resided, the pond where Tucker once spent twenty minutes trying to befriend his own reflection, and the clearing where I'd lost a battle with a vindictive blackberry bush.

Our walks were a constant in an ever-shifting world, and lately my thoughts went to matters more somber than the treasure hunt. My dad, still active and years away from his seventieth birthday, had been recently diagnosed with cancer. Seasons changed, fads came and went, but every evening, you could find Tucker and me—hiking through forestland like two explorers on an endless quest. One searching for the perfect stick, the other pondering the enigma of a poem, or perhaps the riddle of existence. I couldn't help but see

these walks as a metaphor for life—this relentless forward motion, covering the same ground yet discovering something new each time. Or maybe it was just a man slowly losing his grip, accompanied by a dog with the energy output of a small nuclear plant.

It's often during the most mundane moments that life throws you a curveball. One evening, having just crossed the road to re-enter the forest, I was mentally reciting Fenn's poem for the umpteenth time. "Begin it where warm waters halt," I mumbled, while Tucker investigated what I hoped was a harmless stick and not some dubious forest offering.

The sound of rapid footsteps shattered my reverie. Instinctively, I reached for Tucker's leash, preparing for a jogger to pass—a common courtesy to assure strangers that my dog was more interested in sniffing than snarling. Before I could secure him, a man burst around the corner, eyes wide with terror. He wasn't so much running as fleeing. Before I could process this, the reason for his panic emerged—a bear, thundering down the trail with the speed and determination of an express train.

In a heartbeat, Tucker decided to channel his inner hero. He lunged at this hostile creature that was easily four times his size. Time seemed to slow as the bear swiped a massive paw, sending Tucker tumbling into the underbrush. The sight stole the air from my lungs. "Tucker!" I screamed, my voice raw with desperation. The forest held its breath. Then, miraculously, Tucker stumbled back onto

the trail, shaken but moving. Relief washed over me, but there was no time to celebrate. The bear was still advancing. In that instant, Tucker and I shared a singular thought: run.

We bolted toward the road, hearts pounding in unison. Just as we burst onto the asphalt, an oncoming car screeched to a halt. The bear, perhaps dissuaded by the cacophony or the prospect of urban chaos, halted its pursuit and retreated into the woods. The driver stared at us, shocked and bewildered, before slowly driving away.

As his taillights disappeared, I noticed a figure across the road: the man who'd set this wild chain of events into motion. Approaching cautiously, he explained that he'd accidentally come between a mother bear and her cubs. Suddenly, the bear's aggression made all too much sense. We stood there, three strangers bound by a harrowing experience, each grappling with our own blend of fear and relief. Tucker leaned against my leg, tail wagging, both of us giving and receiving a little welcome comfort after the ordeal.

In the days that followed, Tucker seemed mostly unfazed—still bounding ahead with the enthusiasm of a happy kangaroo. But there was one notable exception: his newfound wariness of anything even remotely resembling a bear.

It started subtly. We'd be driving through town, windows down to let the breeze tousle our hair and fur, respectively, when Tucker would suddenly erupt into a frenzy, barking and pawing at the window as if orchestrating a one-dog reenactment of *Jaws*. At first, I

thought he'd developed a grudge against mailboxes or took issue with the local topiary. But then I saw it: the life-sized bronze bear statue that stood guard near the town center. Every time we passed it, Tucker would go bananas—barking, growling, scrambling from one side of the car to the other. Pedestrians would stare as my car lurched erratically, the result of 55 pounds of agitated canine reacting to a metal sculpture.

One day, curiosity got the better of me. "Enough is enough," I declared, pulling the car over. If Tucker was going to wage war against inanimate art, we might as well face the enemy head-on. Leashing him up, I approached the statue with Tucker in tow. He advanced cautiously, each step a hesitant shuffle as though the sidewalk were made of bubble wrap. "See? It's just a statue," I said, tapping the bronze leg of the bear to demonstrate its solidity.

Tucker eyed me skeptically, clearly unconvinced. He stretched his neck forward to sniff, maintaining a safe distance that would allow for a quick retreat should the sleeping bear awaken. A group of teenagers passed by, smirking at the sight of a grown man discussing a public art display with his dog.



Just then, a gust of wind rustled the leaves of a nearby tree. Tucker took this as a sign of imminent danger. With a yelp pitched two octaves higher than usual, he bolted behind me, using me as a human shield. The teenagers burst into laughter. Even the statue seemed to smirk. In the safety of the car, Tucker glanced back at the bronze bear, issuing a final bark that I interpreted as, “And stay out!”

No amount of coaxing or treats could convince him this metal creature posed no threat. I tried different routes, but Tucker had an

uncanny ability to detect the statue's presence from blocks away. It was as if the bear emitted a frequency only dogs attuned to post-traumatic bear stress could hear. It became a non-negotiable part of our lives—a constant reminder that some fears are as stubborn as a terrier with a bone.

I suppose we all have our bronze bears—those irrational anxieties that logic can't quell. Tucker never got used to that statue, and maybe that was okay. It kept things interesting, a quirk that made him uniquely him. So we adjusted. We avoided the town center, took the long way home, and let Tucker have his say whenever a bear-shaped cloud drifted by. Life continued, unpredictable and endearing, much like Tucker himself. And honestly, I wouldn't have it any other way.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Home Depot Hound

April of 2013: On a quest for yard tools, I ventured into The Home Depot, leaving my puppy in the car. I had parked in a far-flung sector of the lot, the asphalt equivalent of the Gobi Desert, to avoid door-swinging barbarians reenacting scenes from *Braveheart*. Tucker, locked in his mobile kennel, was dissecting his latest chew toy. Or so I thought. In reality, this canine magician had already initiated his great escape, his paw working the door handle with the dexterity of a safe cracker, his snout pushing against the door with the utmost determination.



I was deep in the throes of an existential crisis, debating between stainless steel and cast aluminum shovels, when I felt it: the slobbery baptismal sacrament that is Tucker's tongue. Somehow, my furry Odysseus had unlocked the car, opened the door, navigated not just one, but two parking lots and an ocean of SUVs, scoured aisles 2 through 13, only to find me in The Home Depot.

Here, my imagination took flight. I could just picture him waltzing past the greeter, probably a disillusioned retiree named Bob who'd seen it all but never a dog hell-bent on finding his human.

Tucker would have sauntered through the automatic doors, briefly cocking his head and perhaps even rolling his eyes at the faux Tuscan tiles (an aesthetic offense he'd not forgive easily), and then charged down the winding labyrinth of aisles. Finally, bursting through yet another set of doors, he'd find me amidst a jungle of potted plants and organic soil.

This moment of canine determination made me realize something: as far as society has come in terms of technology, politics, and even social dynamics, we still underestimate the very creatures we share our homes and lives with. Tucker's zeal for hide-and-seek made even the most zealous Jehovah's Witness seem uncommitted.

So the next time you're lamenting the complexity of your IKEA furniture instructions, just remember: there might be a Tucker in your life capable of extraordinary feats that would make your struggles seem as trivial as choosing between stainless steel and cast aluminum.

Yes, dogs are woefully underrated. And we—mired in our human complications—might just be a bit overrated. After all, it's not every day you witness a hound-nosed Houdini navigate the perils of modern retail just to slobber on your shoe.

The Curious Confluence

July 2013 found me in northern New Mexico, on a reconnaissance mission for Forrest Fenn's treasure. The hunt had been my hobby for a year now, a persistent itch that refused to be ignored. I pulled into Santa Fe in my rental SUV, a vehicle chosen more for its ability to handle rough terrain than for comfort. The back was stuffed with maps and gear, testament to my commitment to the search.

As any dedicated Fenn treasure hunter would do, I made my way to The Collected Works Bookstore. This establishment was known for stocking Fenn's memoir—a volume that had become a familiar friend over the past twelve months. Supporting the store felt like a nod to the community of searchers I'd become a part of.

I stepped into the bookstore, the cool air a welcome respite from the New Mexico summer. The scent of paper and ink filled the air as I made my way through the stacks, my eyes scanning the shelves

with purpose. It didn't take long to spot several copies of *The Thrill of the Chase*. I grabbed one, despite already owning a few. It never hurt to have a backup, I reasoned. As I flipped through the familiar pages, a voice caught my attention. It was a voice I recognized from interviews and videos.

I looked up, my heart rate quickening. There, just a short distance away, sat Forrest Fenn, casually chatting with another patron. He looked exactly as he did in the photos I'd seen—an older gentleman with an air of easy confidence about him.

My first instinct was to leave quietly. I didn't want to be an intrusion or come across as an overeager fan. I made my purchase and headed for the exit. But as I neared the door, I saw Forrest rising from his seat, clearly intending to leave as well. Our paths were about to cross in the narrow space near the entrance. A little voice in my head whispered, "It's now or never."

Taking a deep breath, I extended my hand. "Hello, Mr. Fenn," I said, proud that my voice remained steady. "My name is Justin, and I've been searching for your treasure. It's a pleasure to meet you!"

Forrest's face creased into a slight smile as he shook my hand. His grip was firm, the hand of a man who'd lived an active life. I rushed to fill the silence, words tumbling out in a cascade. "I don't want to intrude on your day, but I just wanted to introduce myself and thank you for the adventure you've created."



I expected a polite nod, maybe a quick word of encouragement before he continued on his way. What I didn't expect was his reply: "You look like someone who might be looking in all the right places. Why don't you sit down with me for a bit and tell me about it?"

I hesitated, taken aback by the offer. "I really don't want to invade your privacy like that, Mr. Fenn," I stammered, giving him an easy

out. "I'm sure you have more important things to do than listen to my amateur theories."

But Forrest seemed genuinely interested. "Where have you been looking for the treasure?" he asked, his eyes curious.

Realizing this was really happening, I took a deep breath and dove in. "So far, mostly up north," I replied, my words picking up speed as excitement overtook nervousness. "Boiling River, Gardiner, Devil's Slide, Hebgen Lake, and a handful of spots in Yellowstone National Park. I've come down this way to look over some potential areas that might fit the poem."



First tracks, according to tradition, on Yellowstone's opening morning.

As I spoke, I watched his face carefully, hoping for some flicker of recognition, some tiny tell that might indicate I was on the right track. But his expression remained neutral, betraying nothing. It was

what I'd expected—Forrest was known for keeping his cards close to his chest.

Our conversation continued as we walked out of the bookstore. The initial awkwardness melted away, replaced by the easy flow of two people discussing a shared interest.

"I really enjoyed reading your chapters on fly fishing," I said, moving the conversation beyond my treasure hunting exploits. "I have memories of fishing some of the same rivers and streams you describe."

At the mention of fishing, Fenn's eyes lit up. "It's beautiful country," he said, a note of fondness in his voice.

In that moment, we were just two anglers, sharing our appreciation for the rivers and the art of fishing. Emboldened, I continued, "Hopper season came a bit late last year, but it was worth the wait. Those big browns get pretty excited about a juicy grasshopper." I grinned, remembering a particularly good catch from the previous summer. To my delight, Forrest leaned in conspiratorially.

"Let me tell you a secret about tying hoppers," he said, his voice low as if imparting sacred knowledge. What followed was a masterclass in fly tying, a technique I've used religiously ever since.

Our conversation meandered, touching on everything from favorite fishing spots to the challenges of navigating Yellowstone's backcountry. With each exchange, my initial nervousness faded,

replaced by a growing appreciation for Forrest's knowledge and experiences.

As our chat drew to a close, I thanked Forrest for his time, silently praying I hadn't made a complete fool of myself. But as we shook hands to part ways, a question burned in my mind. "Forrest," I said, "I've got to ask. Do you really think someone can find your treasure?"

Fenn's eyes narrowed slightly, not in suspicion, but in the way of a wise sage about to impart a profound truth. "Someone is going to find that treasure," he said, his voice steady and sure, "and not by chance. You know the poem and you've read my book. You're just the kind of person that could find it."

Those words etched themselves into my memory, a mantra to carry me through the years of searching that followed. My dad always said, "You can judge a man by his eyes." As I walked away from that chance encounter, my doubts melted away like spring snow in Yellowstone. I saw in Forrest's eyes a glimmer of the same excitement, the same thrill of the chase that had drawn me into this grand adventure. The treasure was out there, waiting to be found. And in that moment, with the New Mexico sun warm on my face and Forrest's words ringing in my ears, I was more determined than ever to be the one to unearth it.

As I climbed back into my SUV, maps spilling across the passenger seat, I felt energized. This treasure hunt had become more

than just a hobby—it was a journey of discovery, encompassing not only the search for Fenn’s cache but also an exploration of the beautiful and varied landscape of the American West.

I turned the key in the ignition, the engine humming to life. The road stretched out before me, leading to countless possibilities. Where would I search next? The Gallatin River? The Grand Tetons? Or perhaps somewhere closer, near Taos Pueblo or Ojo Caliente?

As I pulled out of Santa Fe, my mind was already racing with new ideas, new interpretations of the poem that had guided my search for the past year. One thing was certain: my encounter with Forrest Fenn had only reinforced my passion for the chase.

The thrill, as they say, was just beginning.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Sleep Study

The doctor swiveled his probing gaze upon me, eyes glinting with the eagerness of a kid at a lemonade stand. “And how do you sleep?” he inquired.

I offered a nonchalant shrug. “Oh, I’m a champ when it comes to sleeping—eight hours a night. I could snooze standing up in a subway car if you asked nicely.”

But Jennie, with that marital semaphore—eyes widening, eyebrows dancing their telltale tango—betrayed me. Before I could protest, she had unfurled my most mortifying naptime tales to the good doctor, painting me as Rip Van Winkle incarnate.

As I sat there, ensnared in the web of an impending sleep study, my mind drifted back to adolescence. Back then, I’d reached an unflattering self-diagnosis: incurably indolent. This revelation came with its evidence. Take that Saturday when I caught a slight cough—

nothing terminal, mind you, just the universe's gentle nudge to slow down. I nestled into bed for what should have been a brief siesta. Imagine my bewilderment when I awoke, not to birds chirping their late-afternoon serenade, but to the hollow silence of a day that had slipped away without me. Twenty-six hours had vanished into the void of sleep, leaving nothing but drool on my pillow and a profound sense of betrayal. I mourn that lost Saturday still.

Then came that moonlit drive back from Jennie's during college, when our visit had stretched into the velvet hours of morning. As I approached a desolate traffic light on Tucson's outskirts, I remember one blink—just one—before consciousness fled. An hour later, I came to, still at that red light, my foot maintaining its loyal vigil on the brake like a steadfast sentry. How it managed such devotion while the rest of me melted into oblivion remains one of life's sweet mysteries.

School offered no refuge. My talent for impromptu slumber showed no favorites among subjects; calculus or creative writing, it made no difference. The gentle drone of a teacher's voice became my lullaby, a siren song beckoning me to the land of nod. It's a miracle I emerged with more than a diploma in advanced somnolence.

Jennie wrestled with her own nightly demons. Her snoring thundered with such force it could summon spirits from the afterlife—not that it ever pierced the impenetrable veil of my slumber. An earthquake couldn't have roused me. Still, it wreaked havoc on her

own peace, leading her to seek wisdom from a sleep specialist in June of 2014. By some fluke of fate, I accompanied her on verdict day, only to learn her tonsils were staging a hostile takeover of her throat.

Under the combined assault of Jennie and the snore-whisperer, I found myself conscripted into a sleep study. My protests proved as effective as a paper umbrella in a hurricane. The greatest indignity? This scientific intrusion would cleave my sacred weekend in two—an unforgivable sin in my book of leisure.

And so half my weekend vanished into the maw of medical curiosity. Jennie shepherded me to the sleep center like a lamb to the scientific slaughter. Once there, I was costumed in pajamas that whispered, “This will not be a dignified evening.” Technicians swarmed, affixing wires and gadgets to my person with a zeal that would make a Christmas tree blush. I was a human circuit board by the time they tucked me in.

And oh, the amenities! A one-way mirror (for the voyeuristic pleasure of some graduate student, I imagined) and an orchestra of machines that hummed and blinked like a lonely spacecraft’s control panel. Wrapped in this electronic embrace, I attempted sleep—ever the optimist, even while masquerading as a science experiment.

Emerging from my cocoon of wires at dawn, I discovered the inquisition wasn’t yet over. Enter the Multiple Sleep Latency Test, the MSLT. Its mission? To measure how swiftly I could surrender to

sleep in broad daylight—an art I’d unwittingly mastered in countless drowsy lectures.

The MSLT hunts two prey: sleep latency—the countdown from alertness to oblivion—and REM sleep, when your eyes perform their private ballet beneath closed curtains. The test unfolds as a parade of prescribed naps, a concept I’d normally embrace if it weren’t for science’s cold stare and the metronomic tick of observation.

I submitted to the ritual, sinking into sterile sheets. No sooner had my eyelids begun their familiar descent than the tech appeared, her voice cutting through my impending nap. “Rise and shine,” she’d chirp, each time more absurd than the last. Had enough time passed to even warrant the title of nap? It felt like being invited to a feast only to be told I could only smell the kitchen from the parking lot.

By the second act of this clinical comedy, worry had etched itself across the tech’s face. “Just how long has this been happening?”

“How long has *what* been happening?” I replied, innocence personified.

“You don’t even realize you’re falling asleep, do you?” My laughter snagged in my throat as she confessed, “I’m just the tech—I can’t officially diagnose.” But when I pressed, she couldn’t resist: “You’ve got narcolepsy!”

The words burst from her like confetti at a surprise party no one wanted to attend. Me, narcoleptic? I’d heard of it, naturally—wasn’t

there a narcoleptic date in that cinematic masterpiece, *Deuce Bigalow*? Yet here I sat, clinging to the hope that perhaps this tech was merely being dramatic.

A week after the sleep charade, Jennie and I trudged back to the oracle of slumber. I'd spent the interim in an ostrich-like state of denial regarding the tech's amateur prophecy, yearning for a verdict of simple laziness—a familiar cloak I'd worn with practiced shame for fifteen years. But reality had other plans. In the realm of sleep, where normal souls drift off in ten to twenty minutes, I managed two—flat. And each siesta arrived gift-wrapped in REM sleep, achieved faster than microwaving popcorn.

The doctor delivered his verdict with the solemnity of a judge at sentencing: textbook narcolepsy. As this new identity settled around my shoulders, my phone pierced the moment. My stepmother's voice trembled across the line, carrying storm clouds of grief into my already turbulent sky. My father, whose strength I'd always counted as constant as the North Star, had succumbed to his battle with brain cancer.

In that moment, my life seemed to unfurl before my eyes, each thread a vibrant reminder of time's relentless passage. The revelation of my condition, the echo of my father's laughter, the irretrievable Saturdays, and those stolen moments at red lights—all coalesced into a truth. Life, with its merciless tick and tock, waits for no one, not even those lost in the depths of an unbidden dream. Here I

stood, a man who could slip into sleep's embrace at any moment, now faced with the one slumber I desperately wished to wake from. Life, in its unyielding march, had finally given me a label, a condition, a framework for the peculiarities of my existence. Yet, in the same breath, it had snatched away a cornerstone of my world, leaving behind a void no sleep could fill.



The weeks that followed unspooled like a ribbon in slow motion. As grief and reflection intertwined, I realized my diagnosis was not the end of my story but a turning point. The regimen and treatment that emerged from the sleep study offered a path to a healthier

lifestyle, one where I could manage my condition instead of being ruled by it. The irony wasn't lost on me—that in learning to manage sleep, a thing so fundamental, I was waking up to life's possibilities in a way I hadn't before.

It was then I began to understand—life itself is collection of awakenings. Some jolt us awake with the gentleness of a dream's end, while others with the ferocity of nightmares. Each rousing, though, a gift wrapped in the fragile folds of time—pressing us to live, to feel, to embrace the now before it slips silently into the yesterdays.

My daily treatment became a ritual, a reminder that balance dwells even in chaos. I learned to view narcolepsy not as a sentence but as a challenge to be met with the same quiet valor my father had shown in his final battle.

In night's silken silence, after grief's sharp edges had softened, I pondered sleep's nature—that temporary death we court each night, and the mercy of each awakening. Those lost Saturdays, the red-light reveries, classroom surrenders to slumber—all were but dress rehearsals for the final curtain that had claimed my father. The silence following his departure echoed the many quiet intervals that had punctuated my own existence.

As twilight's embers fade to ash, I understand now that we are all wanderers between consciousness and dreams, swaying like dancers between worlds. Perhaps I had been too quick to mourn that

vanished Saturday, too generous in my self-prescribed indolence. For time, that most elusive dream of all, is what we chase while awake, squander while sleeping, and truly value only when it slips, like starlight through our fingers, into the infinite night.

The Derailed Duo

Tucker, my four-legged shadow—he was my constant in a world spinning ever more wildly off its axis. Together, we chased away the demons of sleep and sorrow, one exhilarating bike ride at a time. But even the strongest bonds face their trials, as we learned that fateful Thanksgiving Eve.

Every day after work, Tucker and I would vanish into the forest trails—always on foot at first, but lately my bicycle had become our chariot. The setup was pure mad scientist: a spring steel contraption married to my bike, a rope dancing between us to his adventure-ready harness. Once, just to see if we could set some sort of canine land-speed record, I clocked him at a gasping forty miles an hour. No joke. The dog was a jet with fur.

Before our daily feats of speed, Tucker would strain against his lead like he was channeling ancient sled dogs, his rare, jubilant barks

splitting the air. A whispered “Go!” was all it took—my steadfast companion transformed into pure motion unleashed, and I was just the fortunate passenger. Pedaling? Totally optional. Tucker had evolved from pet to propulsion, turning our daily excursions into something mythical.

Tucker and I developed a bond that verged on telepathy, or at the very least, highly observant codependency. We were connected by an invisible thread that hummed with energy as he followed my lead, while he carved through air and earth, nose raised to the rushing wind.

Sometimes, before I’d even lean into a turn at a trail crossing, Tucker would shift his weight like a dancer anticipating his partner’s next move, reading the morse code of my muscles. A gentle sway to the right, and he’d glide into the curve as if he’d already mapped the geography of my thoughts and found them aligned with his own.

“Oh, we’re going that way? Fantastic, that’s what I had in mind, too,” he seemed to say, his tail wagging like a metronome set to allegro.



If my life had a narrator then, surely it would be Sir David Attenborough: “And here we see the Posey and his domesticated canine in their natural habitat, so attuned to each other’s movements that they seem to operate as a singular entity. Fascinating.”

Was Tucker reading my mind, or was I reading his? The line

blurred until it didn't matter. All that was left was the trail ahead and the unspoken agreement that whatever came next, we'd face it in synchronized stride.

The seasons turned, and our world turned with them. After fleeing what could only be called the Dante's Inferno of apartment living, Jennie and I landed in Bellevue, where even the squirrels wore Patagonia vests. This was Seattle's prim cousin, the one who'd never let its recycling bins sully the pristine curb. Here, among the artisanal coffee shops—their beans personally blessed by Tibetan monks—and luxury pet spas offering canine aromatherapy, we mapped our new domain. The trails were different, as if nature had graduated from Swiss finishing school, but they still beckoned to a dog and his human just the same.

November deepened, and the air grew crisp with winter's promise and upcoming family gatherings. Lu Ann, my stepmother, sent daily texts about turkey, while Brandon and his wife made their way north from California. Yet even as holiday preparations loomed, Tucker and I held to our sacred routine.

Thanksgiving Eve found us on the trails while others wrestled frozen turkeys and cursed at pie crusts. The late sun filtered through bare branches, stretching shadows across our path. Tucker seemed to glow that day, as if he'd caught the festive spirit that hung in the air like woodsmoke from nearby chimneys. On the homestretch, gliding down a tree-lined boulevard, my thoughts drifted to pumpkin pie

waiting at home. The last clear memory: Tucker's steady rhythm beside me, his breath making ghosts in the November air.

Then everything went black.

The impact came without warning—a sudden, violent break in our perfect sync. In that split second before consciousness fled, I caught the crunch of metal, the sensation of flight, and one desperate thought of Tucker that followed me into darkness.

Waking up was like rising from a murky pond, my senses returning in waves. First came touch—rough asphalt against my cheek, cold seeping through my clothes. Then sound—the distant hum of suburban life rolling on without us. Finally, sight, though my vision swam like I was looking through running water.

And there was Tucker, his wet nose pressed to my face, administering his signature face-licking therapy with paramedic precision. My guardian had somehow freed himself from our tangled gear and found his way to me. The bike lay scattered yards away, its frame twisted into modern art, testament to the force that had struck us from behind.

When I lifted my hand to check on my trusty sidekick, it became clear something was seriously wrong in the wrist-and-arm department. The evidence pointed to vehicular foul play. Hit and run—the coward's handshake. Tucker was miraculously unscathed, but my extremities? Let's just say they'd seen better days, but nothing a hospital visit couldn't fix.

There in the quiet of that evening, amid the wreckage and murmurs of suburban life pausing to notice, I felt the full weight of our bond. Tucker's steady presence as I surfaced back to consciousness spoke to something deeper than leashes and trails. We were more than man and dog; we were guardians of each other's souls, bound not by spring steel but by an unspoken promise that whatever came our way—hell, high water, or hit-and-runs—we'd face it together.

The Snout Scout

In 2012, while the rest of the world was fretting over Mayan calendars and apocalyptic predictions, I grew increasingly preoccupied with Forrest Fenn's treasure hunt. For the next three years, Tucker and I hopscotched across the Rockies, chasing a dream of a bronze chest. By 2015, as we stood in the upper Rio Grande of Colorado, our adventures had evolved from casual bike rides to full-blown treasure expeditions.

There's something about the phrase "upper Rio Grande" that makes you expect to stumble upon a hidden treasure. Instead, I found myself alongside a small footbridge, staring up at a silly rock. This wasn't your garden-variety boulder. No, this was a rock with delusions of grandeur, shaped like an arrow and pointing emphatically at...well, that was the million-dollar question, wasn't it?

There I was, rummaging in the bushes like a man possessed, all because a rock told me to. Meanwhile, Tucker, my loyal vizsla, had transformed into a canine philosopher. His normal routine involved thorough investigations of every scent, sound, and potential playmate within a mile radius. But in this moment, he sat still, watching me with an expression of pure, uncomplicated concern. Our eyes met, and I swear I could read the thoughts behind those soulful brown orbs. “Oh, human, what peculiar quest have we embarked upon now?”

I beckoned him over, inviting him to join my pointless excavation. But how does one explain to a dog the irresistible allure of a directionally emphatic boulder? It’s not as if I could appeal to his sense of geological curiosity.

As the sun began to set, painting the Colorado sky in hues of orange and purple, I reluctantly admitted defeat. My adventure had yielded nothing but sore muscles and a renewed appreciation for Tucker’s patience. With a sigh, I packed up our gear, and we began the long journey back to Texas.

The hours stretched on, and I shifted in my seat, trying to find a comfortable position. A dull ache had taken up residence in my left hip lately, but I brushed it off as just another sign of getting older. As mile markers flew by and states blurred together, my brain gnawed on this conundrum: how does one explain the finer points of treasure hunting to a being whose idea of “priceless” is a slightly

stale ham sandwich?

It was during one of those long evenings back home when I stumbled upon something that made me sit up straighter than a choir boy who's just been caught sneaking communion wine: prospecting dogs.

I had some basic knowledge about the canine nose: humans have six million olfactory receptors; dogs have 300 million. The part of a dog's brain devoted to smell is forty times greater than ours. Some estimates say their sense of smell is 10,000 times ours. Other estimates say it's ten times that! We have not invented technology that comes anywhere close to what your pup can do with a single whiff. But this was different. Apparently, while Tucker and I had been play-acting as the world's most incompetent treasure hunters, there were actual canines out there living their best Yukon Gold Rush lives. These four-legged fortune-finders could sniff out precious metals with the same enthusiasm Tucker applied to detecting the opening of a cheese wrapper from three rooms away.

The pioneer was Lari, a German Shepherd trained by Pentti Mattsson in the early 60s. Lari could sniff out sulfide boulders hidden under peat. From 1964 to 1994, a veritable Justice League of mineral-sniffing mutts emerged. At its peak in the 1980s, eight dogs were on the payroll. Fast forward to 2012: Swedish geologist Peter Bergman trained his canine crew to sniff out specific ores up to forty feet underground—that's about six and a half Shaquille O'Neals, for

those who measure depth in basketball players.

So there I was, awestricken by the revelation that dogs could smell metal underground. I knew dogs had been trained to smell the strangest things: drugs, bombs, diseases like malaria and cancer. The only question was, could I turn Tucker into a bronze-detecting maestro, or would this be another entry in the long list of “good ideas at the time?”

Before our metal-detecting adventure, Tucker wasn’t exactly a rookie in the sniff-and-find Olympics. Back in Washington state, I’d unknowingly laid the groundwork for our future treasure-hunting career because we both needed to survive his high-strung puppyhood. It was less “training regimen” and more “please, for the love of all that is holy, tire yourself out.” With my cue, he’d track down and unearth treats, tail wagging with the fervor of a heavy metal drummer.



“Where is it?!”

The next step was to transition Tucker from poultry by-product to bronze. I ordered an assortment of bronze rods, each with a slightly different composition. I chopped these into bite-sized pieces, as if preparing metallic amuse-bouche. At first, I paired these inedible nuggets with liver treats, creating the world’s least appetizing charcuterie board.

I went full CSI: Canine Scene Investigation. I had to make sure Tucker wasn’t following my scent, so I always wore gloves. And I

conducted research on bronze aging, oxidation, and corrosion. I left some bronze bits outside to weather for a year, turning my backyard into a metallurgical aging facility.

A grown man, tiptoeing around his yard in rubber gloves, hiding metal for his dog. *This is it. This is what my life has become.*

At the pinnacle of my descent into madness, I decided to take our little experiment to the next level. Alone in the Rockies I buried twelve metallic morsels in different locations at various depths. One year later, on the morning of our grand experiment, I parked the car and fumbled with my GPS. The device blinked to life, revealing a map that looked like a drunken spider had tap-danced across it, each little blip representing our buried metallic treasures.

Tucker bounded out of the car, unaware of his impending assignment. I walked in a straight line, like a man on an invisible tightrope, while Tucker gallivanted around me in joyful loops. After a few minutes of this woodland promenade, I decided it was time. I called out his name.

Like a soldier snapping to attention, he froze mid-sniff and locked eyes with me. The intensity of his gaze made me wonder if he thought I was about to reveal the secrets of the universe, or at least the location of an unlimited supply of bacon. "Where is it?" I asked. And just like that, the switch flipped. Tucker's ears perked up, and he began his olfactory investigation of the area.

As I continued my straight-line march, Tucker zigzagged around

me in wide arcs. It wasn't long before he suddenly sat down and fixed me with a stare so intense it could have melted steel. Or bronze, as it were. Lo and behold, he was directly on top of our first buried treasure.

After each successful find, Tucker was rewarded with a treat, turning our archaeological expedition into a sort of Easter egg hunt. As we progressed through the forest, Tucker hit pay dirt time and time again, each success marked by that same sit-and-stare routine.



I checked the GPS. There was just one more bronze bit with Tucker's name on it, this one buried deeper than the rest. Could he pull it off? This was his showstopper, the big finale. Would he nail the landing? Tucker circled the area, occasionally darting to one side, lingering, then continuing his sweep. For a heart-stopping moment, I thought he'd given up. But then, with a decisive plop, he sat down and locked eyes with me. "Excavate here, human. And I'll take two treats this time."

As Tucker and I made our way back to the car, the forest alive with the rustle of countless unseen creatures, I pondered the strange series of events that had led us here. What had started as a whimsical idea born from a chance discovery about Finnish ore-sniffing dogs had somehow morphed into this—a man and his canine companion, hunting for buried bronze *together* in the Rocky Mountains.

We stopped to listen and take it all in. Suddenly, every chirp, buzz, and rustle in the underbrush took on new meaning to me. The ant laboriously dragging a leaf across our path, the hawk circling overhead, even the invisible microbes teeming in the soil beneath our feet—they are all communicating, perhaps in ways we've only begun to understand.

As we drove home, the landscape blurring past our windows, I couldn't shake the feeling that we'd stumbled upon the edge of

something vast. It wasn't about the bronze, or even the feat of canine olfactory prowess. It was about communication, trust, and the peculiar alchemy that occurs when two species come together in pursuit of a shared goal.

Tucker dozed in the backseat, no doubt dreaming of his next great bronze adventure. And I realized perhaps this is what it means to truly know someone, be they human or otherwise—to uncover their hidden talents, to push the boundaries of what you thought possible together. If a dog could learn to sniff out bronze, what other cross-species feats of understanding might be possible?

While dedicated researchers have made strides in decoding animal communication—from the complex dances of bees to the subtle electrical signals of trees—we've yet to give this field the full attention it deserves. We've been so preoccupied searching the stars for intelligent life that we've underestimated the depth and complexity of the communication happening right under our noses—or paws, as the case may be.

After all, in a world that often takes itself too seriously, there's something to be said for a man, a dog, and their shared passion for sniffing out the extraordinary in the ordinary. Or in this case, bronze in the bush.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Jinxed Joint

The summit of Piegan Pass loomed ahead in Glacier National Park, a sight that should have filled me with its usual thrill. Instead, I was locked in negotiation with my left hip, which had chosen this precise moment for its final mutiny. What had started years ago as a whispered complaint now screamed through every nerve, each step a fresh betrayal. I adjusted my hiking poles—my newfound crutches disguised as outdoor gear—and forced myself forward.



The look of a man grimacing as he crests Piegan Pass.

Back home, I was reduced to hobbling around like a Victorian gentleman, clutching a cane for dear life. Even the simplest task, like wheeling the trash out, turned into an epic quest. Sleep? A distant dream, and that's saying something for a guy with narcolepsy. One

night, after a strategic, almost architectural arrangement of pillows, I thought I'd finally outsmarted my hip. But just as I was about to drift off, it shifted, unleashing a pain so fierce it rivaled the agony of kidney stones—and those little devils had previously topped my chart of personal agonies.

Like any self-respecting man, I treated doctors as if they were telemarketers. But there I was, eagerly ticking off days like a kid before Christmas, but instead of toys, I was yearning for a doctor's appointment.

The first doctor's x-ray reading proclaimed perfect health. The second doctor discovered a cartilage tear. The third—Dr. McDonald—dismissed both findings entirely. Three different doctors reading the same x-ray like tea leaves, each finding a different future in its shadows. But in Dr. McDonald's frank admission—"I'm confident I can fix your symptoms, but I have no idea what the root cause is"—I found unexpected comfort. His honesty was like a crack in the medical profession's veneer of certainty, and through that crack, trust slipped in. It's a rare breed, a doctor who doesn't masquerade in a cloak of false certainty.

After a seemingly endless parade of scans and tests, Dr. McDonald ordered what felt like a blood-letting ritual from the Dark Ages. Twenty-seven vials, lined up like soldiers on the lab tech's tray. I watched each one fill—my life force encoded in crimson, ready to be decoded by machines that cost more than my house. By

the final draw, I felt light-headed enough to name each vial, wondering which one might hold the answer.

Dr. McDonald finally set the stage for the grand revelation. The MRI revealed my hip had turned into a sort of unwanted swimming pool, accumulating an absurd amount of fluid. So, step one: drain the pool, or in medical terms, “aspirate the joint.” Simple, right? Well, when that needle jabbed into my hip, I nearly launched into orbit from the pain. Cue Plan B: an x-ray-guided needle adventure. Thankfully, the drugs they gave me wiped my memory of that adventure cleaner than a chalkboard on the first day of school. But the aftermath? My hip joint was as dry as a bone—no fluid to be found.

With all other avenues explored, it was time to play the surgery card. In January of 2018, I surrendered myself to the operating table. The incision into my synovial membrane was like “cutting into a piñata,” as Dr. McDonald later described it. Suddenly, it was a cartilage fiesta, with bits blowing out of my hip joint like confetti. The culprit? A hoard of benign tumors, synovial chondromatosis, squatting in my hip joint for who knows how long. Not a single one of these uninvited guests had the courtesy to show up on any scan. For hours, the surgical team played a game of hide-and-seek, extracting a veritable treasure trove of cartilage pieces and rebuilding my hip. Dr. McDonald later reminisced about the ordeal as if it were a therapeutic retreat, calling it a “cathartic experience”

for the surgical team. Who knew hip surgery could double as therapy?

Post-surgery, the sensation was nothing short of miraculous. The hip pain, which had been my constant companion, had packed its bags and left, leaving behind an almost mythical sense of relief. This sudden absence of agony ushered in a tidal wave of hope. Presurgery, I had almost accepted a future chained to a wheelchair, but suddenly, walking seemed back on the menu.

“Push against my hand,” Jacob instructed during our first physical therapy session, his voice carrying none of the sterile clinical tone I’d grown accustomed to. When I grimaced, frustration bleeding through my attempted poker face, he didn’t offer the usual therapeutic platitudes. Instead, he dropped into a chair, crossed his arms, and said, “Tell me about those trails you’re missing.”

Stumbling upon a brother-from-another-mother type of friend is like finding a needle in a haystack. This breed of friendship goes beyond the casual coffee buddy or the hey-let’s-catch-a-game pal. It’s rooted in a deep, almost telepathic understanding and respect, a kind of soul-sync that’s as rare as a solar eclipse. The true test of this bond? It’s not just there for the high fives and champagne toasts, but it really shows its mettle when the chips are down. As Jacob helped me navigate the trials of physical therapy, a brotherhood was forged, one that endures to this day.

Six months later, I stood again at Piegan Pass. The familiar ache in

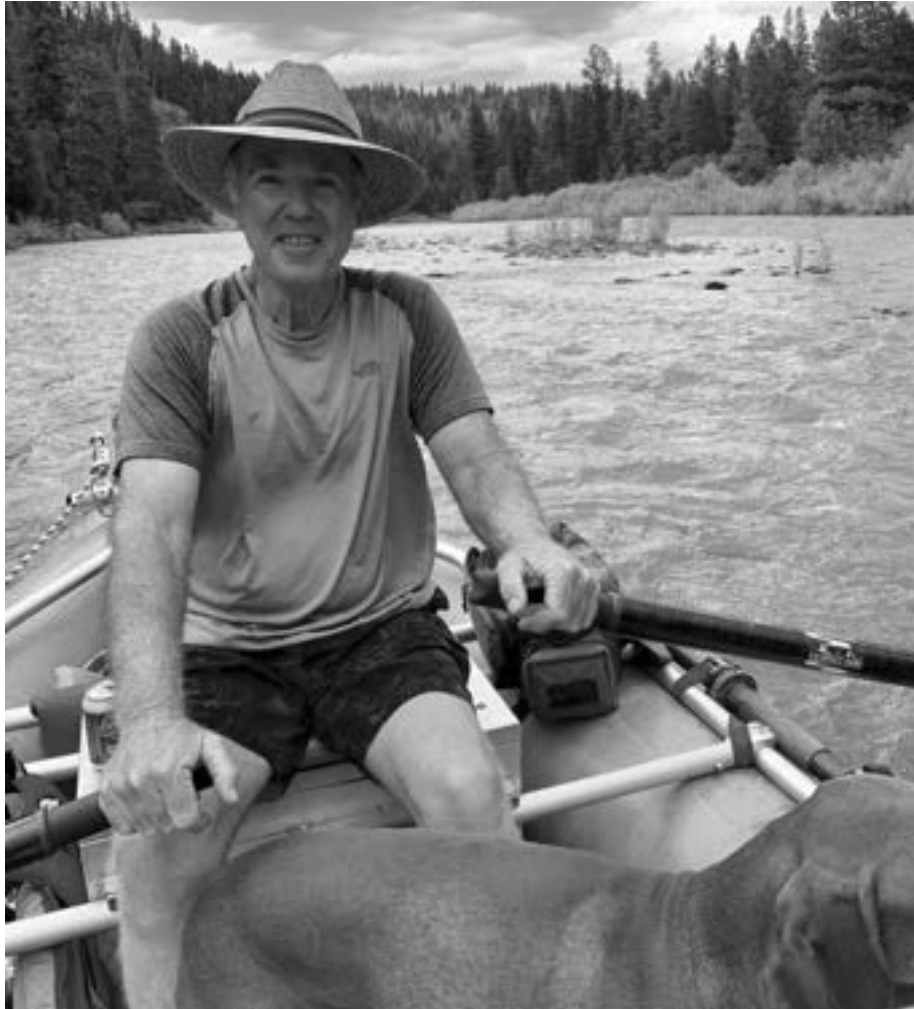
my muscles felt like a homecoming, but something else had changed. The hip pain was gone, yet I couldn't shake this new awareness of my body—not as an ally, but as a countdown clock I couldn't quite read.

I watched a young couple bound past me on the trail, their bodies moving with unconscious grace. They didn't know yet. None of us do, until it happens—that first betrayal that reveals the lie we all live: that healing means returning to what we were before. But our bodies keep score in ways we can't see. Every victory is temporary. Every recovery is just an intermission.

The medical world likes to frame these stories as battles won or lost. But what they don't tell you is that sometimes your body is just warming up, testing defenses, probing for weak spots. That first hip pain? A scout sent ahead of the main invasion force.

The Grizzly Gathering

Tucker and I briefly shelved our treasure-hunting ambitions and waded into the murky waters of the Blackfoot River with my stepfather Gary. A recent storm had thrown nature's equivalent of a toddler's tantrum, leaving the water coffee-colored. Even the most desperate fish—the kind that would normally mistake a dangling shoelace for a five-star meal—had developed discerning palates overnight and vanished into the depths.



Gary and Tucker floating the Blackfoot River.

Faced with the certainty that we were more likely to catch pneumonia than trout, we pivoted to Plan B. In our family, Plan B was less an alternate strategy and more a ceremonial refusal to admit defeat. It meant transplanting our misguided optimism to different waters—in this case, the North Fork near Ovando. There, the river cleaves the wilderness between the Bob Marshall and the Blackfoot Valley, threading through a landscape where grizzlies still command

their ancestral domain. This tributary flows slower than its southern cousin, carving deep pools beneath cut banks—perfect sanctuary for both trout and the apex predators that stalk them.

En route to our new fishing spot, rumors of “elevated grizzly activity” reached our ears. To most souls, this would signal a swift retreat and perhaps a pivot to less mauling-prone pursuits. But not us. No, we simply armed ourselves with bear spray, the hiker’s equivalent of bringing a slingshot to a tank battle.

We left the truck near the bridge and meandered down to the riverbank. There we stood, wading downstream in the kind of silence that only wilderness provides. The weather painted a scene worthy of Van Gogh, if Van Gogh had ever captured Montana’s wild heart. Before long, Tucker and I had drifted a quarter-mile downstream from Gary.

That’s when I saw it—a log jam of mythic proportions, part wooden fortress, part piscine sanctuary. Braving the chest-deep current, I ventured closer, working my elk hair caddis through the seams of flowing water. The fly—tied with hair from a shed I’d discovered on spring trails—danced perfectly across the surface. In my mind’s eye, I imagined a brown trout so massive it deserved its own postal code. This, I decided, was where fishing legends took root.

Tucker, witnessing my aquatic crusade, chose the path of wisdom. He claimed a sun-drenched patch of opposite bank that looked

divinely crafted for canine repose.

Gary eventually waded down to our position. Tucker offered his customary greeting, while Gary squinted through the glare to spot me, tucked behind the logs, my rod tip barely visible. Then his voice—the same steady baritone that had guided me through my first elk hunt and countless river crossings—sliced through the pastoral quiet with an edge I'd never heard: "Hey! There's a grizzly behind you!"

Certain he was indulging in stepfatherly mischief (he had, after all, once convinced me bull trout could bark), I laughed. But when his hand shot toward the bear spray, I remembered my cardinal rule: "Trust but verify." And there he stood, muscle and mass, sniffing the air.

As we backed away, the grizzly paced along the bank, moving with the measured grace of a wildlife officer checking permits. Rounding a bend, we spotted another group of anglers across the water, blissfully unaware of their impending luck. Our shouts sent them scrambling at the sight of our formidable escort, and just as we began our breathless debrief, a second grizzly materialized upstream.

Having survived two bear encounters, we should have recognized the folly of testing probability's patience. But Montana's backcountry plays by its own mathematical rules, where lightning—or in this case, grizzlies—shows particular fondness for statistical improbability.



Maybe Gary was startled by a nearby bear.

Back at the truck, we found a cluster of anglers frantically hunting for a lost phone. Tucker's sudden bark shattered our nervous banter. His hackles rose as his gaze locked beyond the fishermen. While one continued his frantic search, oblivious, Tucker's instincts spoke volumes. His deep growl had me scanning the treeline before the man's face even drained of color.

Not twenty feet away loomed our largest grizzly yet, with our bear spray sitting uselessly in the truck. We retreated behind a flimsy gate—the sort meant to deter garden gnomes, not thousand-pound

predators. The bear, perhaps unimpressed by our improvised fortification, moved off toward the river. But our relief was short-lived as we spotted another pair of fishermen walking blindly along the riverbank path toward the bridge, directly in the bear's new trajectory. Our shouts finally penetrated their consciousness when the bear, now ninety yards from them, suddenly charged—a freight train of fur and fury. Mercifully, it reconsidered, settling instead beneath the shrubs' shelter.



A beautiful scene only in retrospect—unsuspecting fisherman are just off camera. The grizzly charged just after this photo was taken.

And there it was, our fishing expedition transformed into wildlife theater, proving once again that the great outdoors remains the ultimate unscripted stage—bears and all.

The Treasure Trail

West Yellowstone—August 2018

I slipped out before dawn and secured Brandon a prime spot at Baker's Hole Campground. By the time my morning tea had whispered its last confession, Brandon appeared, claiming his temporary kingdom with all the flair of a conquistador in polyester shorts.

Brandon's van defied expectation. Where you'd expect chaos from weeks of road life, there was instead a shrine to order, everything arranged with monastic precision, as if the very act of organizing was a form of prayer. The van's shelves told stories of a thousand journeys—artifacts from the world's corners nestled against each other, each secured against the jostle of nomadic life. It was a mobile reliquary, each trinket a touchstone to some distant

memory, offering the comfort of home wherever the road led.

My setup: an Airstream that caught the summer light like a massive foil-wrapped spud, shimmering among the pines. This rolling command center let me play responsible adult by day while chasing treasure by night and weekend. Like my colleagues, I worked from home. It's just that my home kept moving. One week I'd be nestled among the aspen near Silver Gate; the next you'd find me creekside, ensconced in the shadow of Sawtooth Mountain. Each spot had its charms—and its challenges, including access to WiFi. More than once, I climbed an Engelmann spruce to affix relays to extend signal.

Then there was Tucker. The truck was his mobile throne room, complete with a custom-built platform spanning the backseat, his bed perched atop it like a royal dais. He reveled in those road trips, shuffling contentedly between his regal perch and the co-pilot seat. For all their boundless enthusiasm for the outdoors, dogs face a peculiar exile in national parks—banned from any adventure that strays from pavement.

The forecast promised furnace-level heat, making our decision simple: Tucker would skip this expedition. His alternate kingdom awaited in my twenty-seven-foot Airstream, a climate-controlled sanctuary of polished aluminum. Dual air conditioners hummed their lullaby, backed by shore power, a vigilant generator, and a remote monitoring system that would sound the alarm if his royal

chambers grew too warm.

Pre-dawn found us sharing breakfast, then stretching our legs through the familiar woods edging West Yellowstone. Tucker had always possessed a sixth sense about these days, reading the script before it unfolded. His drooping eyes and tail on our return told me he'd already read today's ending. Neither of us were morning creatures—these dawn patrols felt like heresy against our nocturnal nature. But routine would soon have him snoring in his aluminum castle. Part of me always lingered behind, curled invisible beside him in the quiet of the trailer.

Brandon and I cracked the dawn to outpace the burgeoning caravan inching toward Yellowstone's west entrance. That's the sly dance of the west side—you either rise with the bleary-eyed roosters or dawdle through breakfast, waiting for the vehicular flood to ebb. My personal rule? Only summon the will to greet the sun if the day promises something spectacular, something worth the sacrifice of warm sheets.

Solo hunts close to the west entrance inspired a different strategy altogether. My secret weapon: an UBCO 2x2 e-bike, seventy-five miles of freedom on a single charge. There's an electric thrill in gliding past the frozen procession of cars, their occupants pressed against windows like children at a candy store, all because some nonchalant buffalo decided the road was its personal catwalk.

That morning, my truck carried us into a landscape Brandon

hadn't touched in years. From the shotgun seat, he drank in the scenery like a man savoring his first bourbon after a decade of drought. It was one of those crisp, banner mornings where the sun doesn't just rise, it performs, casting golden spotlights across Yellowstone.



Tucker and Brandon both called shotgun!

We slipped through what we'd come to know as the hallowed hours along the Madison, Gibbon, and Firehole rivers. Dawn here has a way of making the world feel newly forged—steam spiraling from the water like ancient spirits stretching awake, rivers dancing their morning ritual as trout rise with lazy grace to pluck breakfast from the surface. These waters and paths had become more familiar to me than my own reflection, each bend and eddy holding stories of searches past. My tales spilled out as we drove, leaving a trail of memory-breadcrumbs deeper into the park's secrets.

Our quest drew us beyond the Firehole to Iron Springs, tucked against the Gibbon River like a secret note pressed between pages. We claimed the picnic area as basecamp. Reaching our true destination required a calculated backtrack to where the Gibbon offered passage, a careful upstream traverse beneath the bridge, then a slip sideways into Iron Springs' domain where silence held court. There, at the threshold of Secret Valley, guardian of its namesake creek, we faced the riddle that had drawn us here, a line from Forrest Fenn's poem: "I can keep my secret where." Secret Valley? The question hung in the morning air, unanswered.

As we combed the landscape, I unspooled the poem's riddles aloud. Yet before boots hit dirt, before GPS marks first coordinates, there's always this: a kitchen table, midnight oil burning, maps spread like battle plans, and Forrest's poem staring back at you. Through bleary eyes and too many cups of coffee, patterns emerge.

A method forms from madness:

“where warm waters halt” → where the Firehole and Gibbon Rivers merge their heated breath to birth the Madison.

“canyon down” → beckoning us through this natural corridor.

“not far but too far to walk” → the poet’s wink: drive.

“put in below the home of Brown” → ford the river below Iron Springs, where “iron” whispers “brown” in nature’s tongue. Forrest himself gave us this cipher, his childhood trousers stained rust-brown by his school’s iron fire escape.

“no place for the meek” → abandon the well-worn path.

“no paddle up your creek” → Secret Valley Creek

But the poem also mentioned a blaze. Ah, the blaze. This was the game’s heart, a mystery folded within mystery, hidden in plain sight. What I’d pieced together suggested something subtle, something that required eyes trained by years of searching to recognize. Not a shout, but a whisper. Not a sign, but a suggestion. The kind of marker that would mean nothing to most, but everything to the right observer.

“Sooo...” Brandon’s voice carried that familiar edge. “This is where it’s hidden, huh?” His eyebrow arched, mouth caught between smirk and question mark.

My brother wielded sarcasm like a master fencer—subtle, precise, deadly. Most people couldn’t read him, couldn’t tell if he was

mocking or merely doubting. The meaning lived in the spaces between the words, in the slight shifts of tone that I'd learned to decode over decades. This particular delivery carried just enough acid to betray his skepticism.

"It's a possibility," I said. "What do you think?"

He answered with a shrug and kept scanning the ground.

The real test of any spot comes when boots hit the ground. Could an eighty-year-old Forrest have navigated this terrain? Do those poetic clues still sing when you're standing in their shadows? Being there changes everything. The air, the light, distances on maps—they all conspire to reshape your theories. You check for deal-breakers: private property lines lurking like tripwires, terrain that would make a mountain goat nervous, spots that feel wrong for a legendary treasure cache.

Then come the practical questions: What gear? How long to search properly? How many hours before you can cross this spot off your list with confidence? These aren't just details—they're the difference between searching and finding. One might mark each segment of forest digitally, and comb the grid with mechanical precision. But grid searching—that's admission of defeat, the last resort of the desperate treasure hunter. You don't start there. Nobody starts there.

Each clue carried weight, each hint had value. This wasn't mysticism—it was math. Every reconnaissance let me assign hard

numbers to gut feelings, transforming hunches into data points. Call it treasure hunter's calculus: differential equations of possibility. The numbers told stories. High-scoring spots rose like cream through my list, earning the right to deeper scrutiny. The formula didn't find treasure, but it separated fool's gold from real possibilities.

Iron Springs and I had history—multiple chapters of it. The solution seemed clean on paper, logical even. But the blaze? That damned blaze. The kind of marker you might pass a hundred times without seeing, like a familiar face in a crowd that only registers after they're gone. If Tucker could roam Yellowstone's backcountry with me, I'd bet my last GPS battery that Iron Springs wasn't our spot. Fresh eyes, though—that's different magic. Maybe Brandon would see what years of looking had trained me to overlook.

Midday found us methodically combing the woods. Search a spot long enough and you begin to recognize not just the standout landmarks but individual saplings, lichen on a boulder, a pine cone half buried. Something about Brandon's focus reminded me of our childhood searches for lost fishing lures, that same stubborn patience.

We let the afternoon stretch. We knew better than to join the sluggish exodus. Wait for stars. When darkness camouflages the wildlife, the roads clear like magic. The drive back wrapped us in quiet reflection until Brandon's voice cut through. "What's the plan for tomorrow?" He was done with Iron Springs. Ready to move on.

“Let’s grab a bite to eat and we’ll mull it over,” I suggested, knowing well that food and fatigue could make strategists of us all.



\$100 to the first person who can tell me where this was taken.

As evening draped its cool mantle over West Yellowstone, Tucker settled into the familiar quarters of the truck, his contented sighs filling the space. Brandon and I sauntered into Madison Crossing, my preferred haunt for evening strategizing. It remained the quaint gem it had always been, before its expansion—small, intimate, the ideal spot for deep thought or deeper conversation. I made sure to park the truck right outside the restaurant window, keeping a watchful eye on Tucker. In this cozy corner of the world, we would pore over maps and possibilities, the familiar walls bearing silent

witness to countless adventurous schemes.

Tut, the bartender, stood sentinel behind the bar, as immovable and essential as the stools that lined it. By night, he crafted cocktails with practiced precision; by day, he shared his wisdom as a naturalist at The Grizzly and Wolf Discovery Center.

My order flowed from memory like a familiar prayer: bourbon smash paired with a medium-rare flatiron steak, sided by au gratin potatoes and crisp green beans. Brandon, though, had long since forsworn hard liquor—a decision born from his Coast Guard days, a tale that lived in fragments and whispered hints of a wilder past. Beer would do just fine. While we waited on our drinks, I opened my laptop and called up the list of search locations:

1. ~~Firehole Canyon~~
2. ~~Nine Mile Hole~~
3. ~~Harlequin Lake~~
4. ~~Highway Hole~~
5. ~~Iron Pipe~~
6. ~~Barns Hole~~
7. ~~Nez Perce Creek~~
8. ~~Sentinel Creek~~
9. ~~Iron Springs~~
10. ~~Sinks Canyon~~
11. ~~Stevenson Island~~

Everything in me said Wyoming. My conviction wasn't built on hunches—I'd spent months running voice and facial analysis through machine learning algorithms, letting computers confirm what instinct suggested. The results spoke clearly: nine of my top ten locations clustered in Yellowstone's western reaches, and half of them huddled along the Madison River.

Each location insinuated its own story. Barns Hole offered gentle mercy—accessible terrain, sparse forest, a search spot that didn't demand blood sacrifice.

Sinks Canyon welcomed Tucker's company, lying beyond national park borders where dogs could still roam free, his nose adding another layer to our search.

But Harlequin Lake—there nature built her fortress. Dense forest pressed in from all sides, and mosquitoes swarmed with such ferocity they might have carried off small children.

"Iron Pipe"—or the "Water Hole" in Forrest's parlance—holds a sacred corner in my memory. The name echoes from Pat Barnes, the old fishing maestro, and stuck like river mud to waders. Names have their own gravity this way. Call a place "Sparkling Rainbow Unicorn Falls" all you want, but if the locals christen it "Smelly Bog of Despair," that's what the maps will eventually surrender to.

The pipe itself stands unremarkable—metal conduit emptying its waters roadside. But watch those waters reach the other side, where they join the Madison's endless flow, and witness the ordinary

transform into something magnificent.

In our younger days, this served as a trout cleaning station. The mountain rose guardian on one side, the road marked boundary on the other—perfect parameters for a child’s imagination to roam within. But that road noise—the constant intrusion of engines and horns—it struck a wrong note. I couldn’t picture Forrest choosing this cacophony for his eternal rest. Though memory, that clever artist, has a way of softening even the harshest sounds into something almost musical.

I drew a decisive line through number nine and slid the laptop across the table to Brandon. “I feel like I’m missing something here. What do you think?” The weariness of another empty search colored my words.

Brandon leaned forward, eyes narrowing at the list. He was no stranger to this treasure hunt—he’d walked more than a few of these high-ranking spots with me before.

“Nine Mile Hole,” he murmured, finger suspended above the name like a divining rod. His tone carried something deeper than mere suggestion—a quiet certainty that five years of searching hadn’t managed to erode.

Summer of 2013 rose in my memory—how could five years have slipped past so quickly? This wasn’t just another pin on a map; this was sacred ground for us both. We’d spent days there that summer, ostensibly searching for treasure but really wading through the deep

pools of memory: two boys with fishing rods, learning the water's secrets. Even after Brandon left, I stayed on two more weeks, grid-searching with methodical desperation, as if our shared history might have left some secret marker only I could find.

Objectivity dissolved when it came to Nine Mile Hole. Brandon's voice carried echoes of those earlier days, and my heart answered in kind.

Every fisherman carries a mental map marked with sacred waters—places where the mundane world dissolves at the riverbank, leaving only the eternal triangle of river, fish, and friendship. These spots become temples, their locations passed between trusted souls in whispers, if shared at all. To speak them aloud feels like breaking a spell, risking the dissipation of their particular magic. The connection runs soul-deep, binding not just friend to friend but human heart to wild places. Nine Mile Hole held this power over us, this marriage of water and memory where two boys became brothers, where we learned the language of current and call of river.

Yet Nine Mile Hole could never remain a secret. Something about that deep, sheltered pocket of water draws fly fishermen like pilgrims, and the Madison gives up her browns with generous grace. Here I learned to euro nymph, that meditation of patience and precision that coaxes big fish from deep water. The hole itself enforces intimacy—room enough for just one angler, maybe two.

I rolled Brandon's words in my mind like river stones, wondering

whether he spoke of fishing memories or treasure hunting dreams. But the distinction blurred. Nine Mile Hole transcended such categories—it was memory and possibility, past and future, a place where brotherly bonds had been forged in river water and where ancient secrets might still whisper from beneath the current's endless song.

Brandon slid the laptop back, turning to his beer with the quiet satisfaction of someone who'd planted a seed and could now wait for it to grow.

The list on my screen read like a travel diary of disappointment. Firehole Canyon had surrendered every secret except the one I sought. Harlequin Lake waited behind its wall of dense trees, a challenge I couldn't tackle in its entirety until Brandon returned to his life beyond Yellowstone. The names marched down the screen, each a memory of experience: Barns Hole, Nez Perce Creek, Iron Springs. Tucker and I had combed Sinks Canyon so thoroughly we started to receive mail there.

But Nine Mile Hole....

My hand rose in surrender to inevitability. "You know what? Let's do it." The words carried both defeat and defiance.

Brandon's eyebrow arched, his smirk a familiar ghost. "You sure about that? I seem to recall a bit of complaining the last time we were there."

"That was the old me. The new me is ready to tackle it head-on,

mosquitoes and all. Besides, what else are we going to do? Sit around and wait for the treasure to find us?"

"Nine Mile Hole," Brandon echoed, the name expanding between us like river mist, heavy with unspoken histories.

Beyond the window, tourist traffic crept past Madison Crossing, another summer evening's exodus, cameras full of geysers and bears. And here I sat, plotting tomorrow's search of ground I could walk blindfolded. As if time might have rearranged the trees. As if the coordinates might have shifted. As if six years of obsession might finally yield something besides more obsession.

I dropped cash on the table and rose. Sometimes there's no point fighting what owns you.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Probability Paradox

What they don't tell you about obsession is how it starts with a smile. Eight years ago, when I first printed the poem from Forrest Fenn's book, Brandon grinned and said, "Well, this'll be a fun weekend project." Now I watched my laptop's battery fade into darkness, its artificial glow surrendering to raw autumn light, surrounded by probability matrices that had devoured nearly a decade of my life.

"Your algorithm say anything about bringing a spare battery?" Brandon asked from his perch on a fallen pine, the same brotherly teasing in his voice that had been there since that first weekend. He'd watched my evolution from weekend warrior to whatever I'd become—a man who spent months coding facial recognition software to analyze an octogenarian's micro-expressions in videos.

The Madison churned beyond the wall of pines that had grown

up around us, its constant flow a metronome marking the years of our quest. Like that river, my obsession had carved its own channels through time. What began as a trickle of curiosity had swollen into a torrent of data, each theory and calculation eroding the bedrock of my certainty. That river kept its steady rhythm, indifferent to our searching.

I shut the laptop, its screen having shown me the same futile heat maps and statistical clusters I'd been drowning in for months. Red zones and blue zones painted across topographical data like tributary streams, each dataset feeding into a larger river of theories. What had started with a poem and a map had morphed into an obsession measured in terabytes.

"Remember that kid we saw yesterday?" Brandon asked. "The one just learning to fish?"

I did. A boy, maybe seven, standing with his father at the river's edge, pure joy radiating as he cast his line into the water—the same unfiltered excitement we'd had when we were first brought here as kids. Brandon had watched them for a long time that final day, perfectly still on his fallen pine, as if memorizing every detail.

"I bet he doesn't have statistical analysis to back up his casting technique," Brandon said. He'd been like that all day—present in a way I was too consumed to notice, watching everything with quiet intention.

A pine branch caught me across the face as I stood—a perfect

whip-snap of spite that left my cheek burning and filled my nose with sharp resin. Nature's reminder that while I'd been lost in my digital realm of probabilities and patterns, the real wilderness had grown wild and resistant around us. This wasn't the Nine Mile Hole I remembered, but I'd evolved, too. My backpack was heavier now, laden with technology, and like these towering pines, I'd grown in ways that made the old paths harder to recognize.

"You okay up there?" Brandon asked, and for a moment his voice held something I couldn't name—something that would haunt my dreams months later.



“You okay up there?” Brandon asked, and for a moment his voice held something I couldn’t name...

“Fantastic,” I said, spitting out pine needles. “Just getting reacquainted with the local flora.”

And that was us—just another search on just another day, Brandon making his familiar jokes, me lost in my endless patterns. His smile, however, when it came, had none of that first weekend’s easy confidence. We were going through the motions of our eight-year routine, but something had shifted beneath the familiar rhythms. Like a river changing course beneath a seemingly calm

surface, everything was normal in a way that felt like the silence before a storm.

The Redington Requiem

The Sonoran Desert stretched before me, vast and indifferent, its canvas of ochre and umber blind to the ache that had become my constant companion. Each step kicked up dust that clung to my tear-stained cheeks—echoes of the dirt we'd tracked inside after our adventures, you always grinning as I frantically cleaned before Mom could see. The Redington Mountains loomed, their weathered faces silent teachers of endurance, that lesson Dad had tried so desperately to instill.

Here, beneath a merciless sun that mocked our fractured family, I found you. Or rather, I found where your journey ended, my brother.

The earth had claimed you, as it had Dad, as it claims us all. A hawk's cry split the silence, and I remembered how you'd spot them first on our hikes, your eyes keener than mine despite my supposed

sharp sight. My fingers found the cold metal of your pistol, and I fought the urge to scream into the universe's void. How many times had I missed your pain, wrapped too tightly in my role as eldest?

Your absence carved through me deeper than any wind-sculpted canyon. Yet memory endures, doesn't it? The echo of your laughter, the ghost of your hugs, the way you'd look up to me even as you grew tall—it all pulses through my veins, painting every breath.

And so, I labored. With hands raw and bleeding, I pushed a monument of granite across this unforgiving land. Each inch gained was a whispered apology for times I wasn't there, each bead of sweat a tear for the future we'd never share.

The boulder crept forward, aching slow. My muscles screamed, but the pain was a blessing, a shield against the hollow in my chest. Each burning fiber, every salt-stained drop, proved I was still here, still fighting, still loving you even when you couldn't fight anymore. I pictured you watching, that crooked smile playing on your lips, shaking your head at my stubborn heart.

"Always trying to carry the world on your shoulders," you'd say.

But you'd understand, wouldn't you? This impossible task is my anchor to you, my tribute to a bond I was too blind to see fraying. You'd be proud, though, wouldn't you? Please, tell me you'd be proud.

The Treasure

Hiding treasure is significantly more complicated with a broken tibia. No one mentions this in the pirate manuals or adventure novels. In the haphazard shuffle of life's deck, it's the insignificant cards you barely glance at that end up dictating your next move. Jennie, with a flick of her wrist and a knowing look, slid a Newsweek article across the table to me. "Seems like this was written with you in mind."

The article delved into the world of Forrest Fenn, a man whose biography read like a love letter to the art of accumulation. Starting with a simple arrowhead in his youth, Forrest's obsession had taken him around the globe, sifting through the remnants of civilizations with the glee of a child left unsupervised in a candy store. Surrounded by fellow treasure seekers, he delved into the annals of archaeology, amassing a collection pirates would envy.

Reading about Forrest, I saw bits of myself mirrored back. There was a kindred spirit in our mutual adoration for the untamed, a shared history of youthful misadventures, and a common tendency to collect bits of the world like squirrels preparing for a never-ending winter. We both had a penchant for exploring the world's secret pockets and an almost mystical bond with the craft of fly fishing.

Yet, what truly made Forrest stand out was his elaborate way of thumbing his nose at the drudgery of everyday life. He expressed this rebellion by concocting a treasure hunt, a brain-teaser intricately interwoven with the essence of the American West. Forrest's audacious move was less about the physical treasure and more an invitation to live in technicolor, a beacon for anyone who's ever felt that itch to peel away the surface layer of life to glimpse the wild, pulsing heart beneath.

Little did I know then that I'd end up owning a piece of Forrest's legacy myself. When his treasure was finally discovered, I did something that would have seemed absurd to me while reading that Newsweek article—negotiating with the finder, Jack Stuef, to buy the entire treasure. The deal was sealed through my LLC, though I never planned to keep it all for myself. It felt right to ensure that the thousands of searchers who'd poured their hearts into the hunt should have a chance to own a piece of the adventure they'd lived. So, most of it went to auction. I kept a few choice pieces, including the bronze chest itself.

My captivation with Forrest's saga was bolstered by the challenge he threw down like a gauntlet before the world. As someone who appreciates a good puzzle and the allure of a mystery, it was a match made in heaven. It was a call to an adventure that promised to engage the mind and spirit in equal measure.

The saga that began with a simple gesture across a table evolved into a personal odyssey. It became a quest not for gold but for understanding, a dive into the depths of curiosity, and a celebration of the path less trodden. The ultimate puzzle, I discovered, wasn't one to be solved with a map or a decoder ring, but with an open heart and a willingness to venture into the unknown, embracing the journey for its own sake, with all its twists, turns, and inevitable dead ends.

Owning pieces of Forrest's treasure changed something in me. Perhaps it was holding those artifacts, feeling their weight and history, or maybe it was simply knowing that I'd become part of a story larger than myself. Whatever the reason, by the time 2023 unfolded, I found myself embroiled in the kind of scheme that, on paper, might seem to herald a mid-life crisis. Not for me the red convertible or the ill-advised tattoo; no, my rebellion took a decidedly more eccentric turn. I decided to flip the script. Instead of scavenging for treasure, I would hide one. Because, why not? Life's short, and then you're compost.

Embarking on this venture involved two exceedingly long trips,

each stretching well over 4,500 miles. These excursions into the American West were conducted with the kind of secrecy usually reserved for state secrets. I went completely off-grid, leaving behind no digital breadcrumbs for Google, the NSA, or my increasingly perplexed family to follow. It's much harder than it sounds.

The first trip was essentially a dry run, a rehearsal for madness. It was an opportunity to ask myself, "Is this as insane as it feels?"

Spoiler: it was. And yet, that journey only served to whet my appetite for the absurd. So, with a sense of purpose that bordered on lunacy, I set out once more to hide my treasure somewhere along my journey. I traveled further than necessary, just to throw off any scent of the trail.

Before you start thinking I've gone off the deep end into the realm of allegory or that I'm speaking in riddles, let me set the record straight. This treasure of mine is real. It's a bona fide, grab-your-walking-stick-and-start-searching kind of treasure.

Now, you might think planning and executing such an elaborate scheme would be the most challenging part of this adventure. But life, in its infinite wisdom, changed its grip and threw me a curveball. Picture this: It's May, and a large moving truck, clearly underestimating the steepness of my neighbor's driveway, ends up thoroughly wedged at the base, its back end sunk into the asphalt like a stubborn mule refusing to budge.

Being the neighborly sort (or perhaps just a glutton for

punishment), I decided to lend a hand. Armed with a large floor jack and an overinflated sense of my own capabilities, I set out to free this mechanical behemoth from its predicament. What happened next could only be described as a slapstick comedy gone horribly wrong. The jack, clearly punching above its weight class, gave out with a spectacular lack of warning. It shot out from under the truck like a greased pig at the county fair, making a beeline straight for my unsuspecting knee.

The result? A broken tibia, because apparently, I hadn't made things complicated enough for myself already. So there I was, nursing a broken leg while simultaneously trying to hide a treasure. It was a testament to either my determination or my complete lack of common sense—probably both.

As I limped my way through the final stages of my grand plan, I couldn't help but chuckle at the absurdity of it all. Gallivanting across the country, secreting away a treasure like some modern-day, slightly gimpy Long John Silver. If nothing else, it certainly added an extra layer of challenge to the whole endeavor. After all, what's an adventure without a few unexpected twists?



Photo by Dave Clawson

Anyway, back to the treasure. It should come as no surprise that my treasure is overflowing with history's most dazzling commodity: gold. Inside you'll find Gold Britannias, Austrian gold ducats, Canadian Gold Maple Leafs, and American Gold Eagles fashioned right here at home. Some were minted recently; some have been circulating for generations. Some coins are graded and slabbed. Rounding out the gold collection are PAMP Suisse kilogram bars that'll make you wish you had brought a lifting belt on your treasure hunting expedition. I could never decide which was more impressive: their heft, or their gleam.



Nestled beside the heaps of gold, catching the light like frozen stars, lie loose emeralds, rubies, and deep purple amethysts.

I wanted the treasure to contain stories from ancient history, and the vessel is brimming with artifacts that have seen more history than my entire lineage combined. Let's start at the beginning—I mean the very beginning—with what some consider the birthplace

of currency itself: a silver half-stater from ancient Lydia, struck around 561 BC during the reign of King Croesus, whose name became synonymous with unimaginable wealth. When I hold this coin, I'm touching one of humanity's earliest experiments with money, a piece of silver that changed the course of civilization. The surface still bears the distinctive punch marks of those first mint masters, who were literally inventing coinage as they worked.



From the third-century Kushan Dynasty comes a rare gold stater coin bearing King Kanishka's profile, its edge worn smooth from a millennium of trade along the Silk Road.

The Buyid Dynasty's artistry lives on in an exquisite dinar, its elaborate Kufic script praising Allah in flowing golden calligraphy.

From the Crusader era, a hyperpyron of Byzantine Emperor

Andronicus II gleams softly, its concave golden surface displaying Christ enthroned on one side and the emperor's solemn portrait on the other.



From the Ford collection, the highest rated “ANDO” edition Oak Tree shilling in existence.

Then there's my pride and joy—a 1652 Oak Tree Shilling from colonial Massachusetts. This isn't just any Oak Tree Shilling—this is what numismatists call the “ANDO” variety, where “Anno Domini” was boldly abbreviated to “ANDO.” In those four simple letters lies a quiet act of defiance, a whispered declaration of independence decades before the Revolution. It tells the story of colonial craftsmen who, with careful strokes of their dies, were already dreaming of a new world separate from the Crown. This exact coin, graded MS-64 by NGC, was previously part of the infamous Ford numismatic collection. It is the finest known specimen of its type in existence. Think about that: the highest-graded colonial American coin of its

variety anywhere in the world, its silver surface still gleaming with details struck nearly four centuries ago, including that bold engraver's move that makes it so special. Somehow it survived wars, fires, and the birth of a nation in better condition than any of its peers.

To round things out, I added a large meteorite that's traveled further than all of us ever will—because nothing says “treasure” quite like a rock from space.

In the grand tradition of hidden treasures, it needed more than just a personal touch—it needed a direct link to the man who inspired this whole harebrained adventure. Remember that dragon bracelet? It's a stunning piece of craftsmanship—gold fashioned into an intricate dragon coat, its surface studded with emeralds, diamonds, and rubies that make it look like something straight out of a royal treasury. More than its material worth though, it's the history that makes it special. From the hands of Eric Sloane—artist, author, and one of Forrest's dearest friends—to Forrest's bronze chest, to the Rocky Mountains where it lay hidden for a decade, and finally to my collection. It seemed only fitting that it should find its way into another treasure hunt. Along with a few other choice items from Forrest's original cache, it now rests among my hidden collection, creating a sort of torch-passing moment that I'm pretty sure would make the old collector himself crack a smile. The bronze chest, though—that one stays with me. Call it a souvenir of the

journey that led me here, or perhaps just my own collector's heart refusing to let go of everything.

And those are just the pieces I'm willing to talk about. There are other items in the treasure—things that perhaps shouldn't be mentioned until they're found.

So, yes, it's all there, hidden away for some intrepid soul to discover. It's my nod to the adventurous, a salute to the seekers and dreamers who look at a map and see not boundaries, but invitations. Whether this makes me a modern-day Magellan or just another fool with a flair for the dramatic remains to be seen. After all, history's not just something you read about—it's something you can hold in your hand, provided you're willing to search for it.

This trove, weighing in at about sixty pounds in total, is out there right now, lying in wait. I've secreted it away in a spot that's dear to my heart, a location that whispers of personal lore and secrets. And fear not—retrieving it won't require you to reenact any dangerous scenes from Indiana Jones. No, the path to discovery is surrounded in significance, not in peril.



Beyond the Map's Edge

**Can you find what lives in time,
Flowing through each measured rhyme?
Wisdom waits in shadowed sight—
For those who read these words just right.**

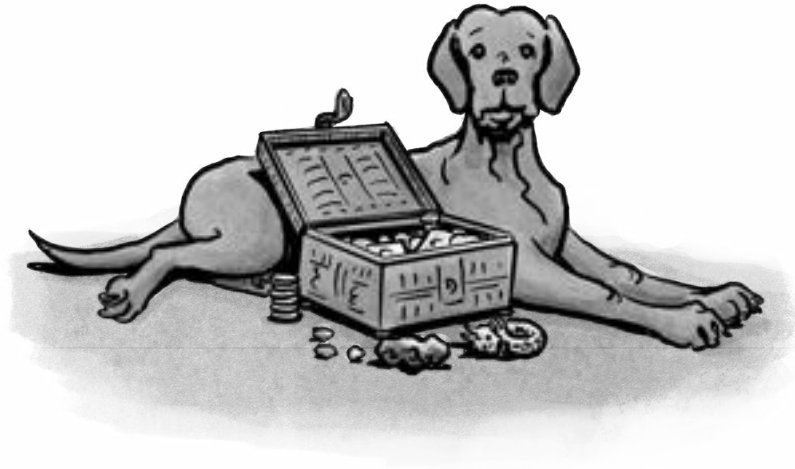
**As hope surges, clear and bright,
Walk near waters' silent flight.
Round the bend, past the Hole,
I wait for you to cast your pole.**

**In ursa east his realm awaits;
His bride stands guard at ancient gates.
Her foot of three at twenty degree,
Return her face to find the place.**

**Double arcs on granite bold,
Where secrets of the past still hold.
Beyond the reach of time's swift race,
Wonder guards this sacred space.**

**Truth rests not in clever minds,
Not in tangled, twisted finds.**

**Like a river's steady flow—
What you seek, you already know.**



Like four points of a compass, I've dedicated this treasure to four departed souls who've shaped my journey in ways immeasurable:

First, in memory of my late brother, Brandon, whose absence has left a void no amount of treasure can fill, but whose spirit of adventure and unquenchable curiosity I carry with me in this quest.



Next, a tribute to another guiding star in my constellation, my Dad and all my family that have come before me. In their memory, this treasure hunt gains an extra layer, a sort of spiritual varnish that deepens its hue. My father, with his toolbox of wisdom and a knack for finding humor in the least likely places, taught me to look beneath the surface, to see the adventure in the everyday. He was a man who could navigate the complexities of life with the ease of a seasoned sailor, all the while whistling a tune that made you think, “Well, if he’s not worried, why should I be?”

To Grandpa Fitzwater—you carved your name on the London Bridge and your legacy in my heart. This treasure hunt is my attempt to share a piece of your indomitable spirit with the world.



And last, but certainly not least, to Tucker, my loyal companion, whose enthusiasm for life could make even the most mundane of walks feel like an expedition into the unknown. Tucker, with his unerring instinct for joy and a tail that wagged like a metronome set to “celebrate.”



I offer this endeavor as an invitation—to adventure, to exploration, and perhaps to forging connections that resonate deeper than you may imagine. While I can't promise you'll find enlightenment at the end of this rainbow (or even a rainbow, for that matter), I do hope you'll discover something equally valuable. Maybe it's the thrill of the hunt, the beauty of a path less traveled, or simply a moment of connection with the world around you. Whatever it is, embark on this journey with the spirit of Tucker wagging his tail at the sheer possibility of it all, my father's wisdom as a guiding light, my grandfather's resilience, and with my

brother's sense of wonder as your compass.

San Juan Islands



The treasure is hidden somewhere here.

Book made for tannerjurek@gmail.com

The Dubious Decision

The half-naked man stumbled out of the Canadian wilderness like a modern-day Tarzan on a budget vacation. Scratched, shivering, and wearing nothing but underwear and flip-flops, he blinked at the search and rescue team emerging from the helicopter.

“Sir, are you Taylor Long?” the lead rescuer shouted over the whirring blades.

The man nodded, then grinned as if this was all part of some grand plan. “Just enjoying some camping,” he quipped, his teeth chattering. “Is there a problem?”

The rescue team exchanged bewildered glances. This was going to be one hell of a story. It had all started a week earlier with a phone call that would send me on a wild Canadian border goose chase.

“I’ve got it!” Taylor’s voice crackled through the phone, bursting with the excitement of a lottery winner.

I should have known then that trouble was brewing. Taylor had the kind of persistence that made a Jack Russell Terrier look positively lethargic. Once he got an idea lodged in that skull of his, it stayed there, come hell or high snowdrifts. "Got what, Taylor?" I asked, already dreading the answer.

"The solution to Fenn's poem! It's not just a riddle, man. It's a whole border-crossing extravaganza!"

I groaned inwardly. Forrest Fenn's treasure hunt had already led countless adventurers on preposterous chases across the Rocky Mountains. But leave it to Taylor to take it international.

As Taylor rattled off his plan, my protests fell on deaf ears. His destination? Cameron Lake, a glacially fed body of water straddling the borders of Alberta, British Columbia, and Montana. One leg of the journey even required boating, a detail that seemed to delight Taylor to no end.

"I'm heading out now," he declared. "You in?"

I wasn't. Coming off a season of overexertion and facing impending family commitments, I knew better than to dive headfirst into another of Taylor's schemes. But I also knew Taylor well enough to realize that my refusal wouldn't stop him.

"Just...check in with me in a day, okay?" I pleaded, already feeling the tendrils of worry creeping in.

"Dude, that won't work. I'll probably be out of cell reception. Give me at least four days."

That was well beyond my comfort zone, but Taylor wouldn't entertain anything shorter. As he hung up, I couldn't shake the feeling that this adventure might be different from the rest.

Taylor had identified a series of Canadian forest roads that would take him within a few miles of the border. From there, he planned to hike the remaining distance. One might ask why he didn't simply drive up Akamina Parkway to the visitor's center. Well, the center's fate was tragically comic: shortly after its completion, a fire surged through the vicinity. In a turn of cosmic irony, the fire didn't so much as singe the visitor center, but the entire Cameron Lake area, including the access road, remained closed.

I spent those initial days oscillating between hope and concern, imagining Taylor wrestling with Canadian dirt roads in a Sunseeker RV towing a Miata that had no business being there. I expected a call signaling his retreat but then remembered, this is Taylor, the human bulldozer. He'd stick it out, armed with meal replacement drinks and sheer determination.

As the deadline neared, my meteorologist friend Rick, whose weather predictions held the gravitas of a Supreme Court ruling, delivered a chilling forecast. It was about to get freezing cold. The time had come for official intervention.

What followed was a bureaucratic maze that would make Kafka proud. My first call was to the Pincher Creek detachment of the Alberta Royal Canadian Mounted Police, but jurisdiction quickly

became a topic of heated debate. The U.S. Border Patrol, Canadian Border Patrol, National Park Service, and Canadian Parks Service all got roped in. I lost count of how many agencies were involved, but I do recall staying up all night, coordinating between departments and updating Taylor's increasingly worried family.

The police were skeptical. "It's rough territory back there," one officer said, recounting his own failed attempt to navigate the area on a dirt bike.

You don't know Taylor.

After fruitless searches of nearby campgrounds, I finally convinced them to check a specific location on the map. Lo and behold, a few days before, a Natural Resource Officer had stumbled upon an RV towing a Miata, about 120 kilometers down a forest service road. Barking dogs could be heard inside. Bingo.

With Taylor's vehicles located, Search and Rescue formulated a plan. At first light, a helicopter was deployed. The wait was excruciating, my living room carpet bearing the brunt of my anxious pacing. When the phone finally rang, the news was mixed.

"We've spotted the RV and Miata," the coordinator reported, "but we've got a problem. There's nowhere to land."

My heart sank as I listened to the helicopter circling. Then, incredibly, they found one: the remains of a burned-out bridge. The very obstacle that had likely forced Taylor to abandon his RV was now key to his rescue.

“We’re setting down now,” the coordinator narrated, tension evident in his voice. “The bridge is creaking, but it’s holding.” I held my breath, every muscle tense, as I imagined the delicate landing. Finally, blessed words: “We’re down.”

But Taylor wasn’t in the RV. Only his dogs greeted the rescue team from the RV window. Where was he?

“Wait,” the coordinator’s voice crackled. “We’ve got movement in the treeline.” And that’s when they saw him—a half-naked man stumbling out of the wilderness, smiling back at them.



As it turned out, Taylor's adventure had unfolded in true Taylor fashion. Undeterred by the burned bridge, he'd set out on foot with a survival kit consisting of a smartphone, a battery pack, and a Walmart inflatable mattress. Skirting along See Creek, he'd crossed from British Columbia into Alberta. He'd approached the abandoned visitor's center, a commanding sign on display: "CAUTION: elevated grizzly activity. Do not enter!" Merely a suggestion in his mind, he had continued silently on to the lake, trying to pass by the bear guardians undetected. The lake had come into focus, stretching to the south about two and a half kilometers, straddling the U.S.—Canadian border.

With the audacity that only Taylor could muster, he'd inflated his mattress and paddled for hours across the frigid lake, using his hands as oars. He'd reached Montana, only to find his supposed treasure location underwater. Dejected but undaunted, he'd spent a sleepless night on the freezing Montana shore, surrounded by the sounds of foraging grizzlies.

At dawn, he'd made the perilous journey back across the lake on his now-punctured mattress, stopping periodically to re-inflate it. Back on Canadian soil, he'd hiked eight miles through rough, trailless backcountry in his underwear and flip-flops, his wet clothes abandoned. When the rescue team finally helped Taylor get his RV turned around, he insisted on staying put. For someone needing rescue, he sure didn't want to leave.

In the end, Taylor was more than a plot point in this implausible narrative—he was the whole, unbelievable story. A tale of determination, recklessness, and the kind of adventure that makes you question the fine line between bravery and folly. It's a story that deserves to be sealed in a time capsule and opened a hundred years from now, just to perplex and astonish a new generation of would-be adventurers.

As we wrap up Taylor's wild ride, let's distill some wisdom for aspiring adventurers:

- **Be Prepared:** Pack the ten essentials like your life depends on it (because it might):
 - Navigation tools (for when “wandering aimlessly” isn't on the itinerary)
 - Sun protection (unless you're aiming for that “boiled lobster” look)
 - Insulation (layer up like an onion, minus the tears)
 - Illumination (because stumbling in the dark is only fun at college parties)
 - First-aid supplies (for when you discover that yes, gravity is still working)
 - Fire starters (rubbing sticks together is so 10,000 BC)

- Repair kit (MacGyver's mullet is optional)
- Food (optimism isn't calorie-dense)
- Water (because hallucinating an oasis isn't hydrating)
- Emergency shelter (your backup plan when Mother Nature crashes your camping party)
- **Weather Wisdom:** Know the forecast like it's your favorite song's lyrics. It sets the tempo of your adventure.
- **Communication is Key:** Your phone isn't just for selfies; it's your lifeline. Always let someone know your plans—think of them as your adventure's co-pilot (minus the backseat driving).
- **Experience Matters:** Venturing into the backcountry without know-how is like entering a cooking contest with microwave skills. Team up with a pro; their experience is your cheat code.
- **Heed the Warnings:** Those cautionary signs aren't there for decoration. When the universe flashes a "Stop" sign, it's not playing hard to get.
- **Respect Mother Nature:** She's not just a pretty face; she's a force to be reckoned with. Learn her moods before you try to dance with her.
- **Know When to Fold 'Em:** Adventures are investments, but they're not one-way streets. It's okay to make a U-turn

when your quest starts looking like a fool's errand.



Remember, every adventure is a story waiting to be written, and you're the author. Equip yourself with gear, knowledge, and a healthy dose of caution. May your journeys be wild, your spirits high, and your adventures safe. Here's to navigating the great

unknown with wisdom as your compass and a good story as your destination.

The Mountain Memory

In the heart's deepest chambers lie memories so potent, so visceral, they transcend mere words, etching themselves upon the soul. Such is my journey with Tucker, whose spirit soared as boundless as the wilderness he so fervently explored.

He departed this earth, leaving in his wake a void as vast as the skies he loved to race beneath. Yet our shared tales, woven with golden threads of adventure and sealed by an unspoken bond of loyalty, echo eternally within me.

In the mountain's hushed solitude, where the air is crisp and the trees stand in silent reverence, I cast my line into a babbling brook. There, I sometimes hear the gentle patter of paws upon the stream's bank. I turn, yearning for a glimpse, but my mortal eyes fail me. The world falls silent, and time, with its relentless march, pauses to honor the memory of my companion.

Here, where earth and memory converge, Tucker lives on. His spirit gallops along familiar trails, as free and untamed as the day he first entered my life.

In the shroud of night, a tale to tell-- Of a dog and man, in
sorrow dwell.

He, a canine, faithful through each phase, I, a human, lost in
life's dark maze.

He was a dog, this creature true, His spirit kin to skies so blue.
I was the man, his earthly tie,
Yet in our gaze, we touched the sky.

A communion of souls so rare, A pact of silence filled the air.
In eyes that met, a world was found, A quiet love, profound,
unbound.

To him, my essence was his sphere, His wagging tail, my worldly
cheer.

But Fate, that mistress cold and sly, Deemed it time for him to
die.

The hearth now cold, the house so bare, A ghostly howl hangs in the
air.

My hands reach out to vacant space, Longing for his soft embrace.

"Loss teaches love," the sages say, Yet we knew love in full array.
Tucker, once my earthly friend,

Took half my soul around the bend.

The trails we walked, now vacant, dim, Yet still I hear our parting
hymn.

And as I tread this mortal coil, I wish release from sorrow's toil.

May when the Reaper comes to call, Beyond the vale, I'll hear a
paw.

With wagging tail and eyes so kind, In death, our severed souls
shall bind.

He was my dog, my earthly sky, My woeful, never-ending cry.
In life and death, our fates entwined-- Two lonely souls, forever
twined.



The Legal Lowdown

The essence of this endeavor, this leaving behind of a treasure, is to invite. To weave a narrative thread that binds my story to whoever dares to follow the breadcrumbs. In a world where we're often told to look but not touch, I offer something tangible, a real-life adventure that demands nothing more than the courage to seek and the joy of the find.

In an effort to avoid any future bickering, I've gone ahead and dumped all the necessary legal details—along with a few unexpected treasures—into the hands of a designated steward. To add a layer of authenticity to the whole affair, every document was signed, notarized, and verified. A digital fingerprint was posted to X on November 17th, 2023. Here's where you'd find it, assuming you've not already succumbed to the allure of cat videos elsewhere:



Digital fingerprint of all signed and notarized legal documents. When the treasure is found, this fingerprint can be compared with the documents' fingerprint to ensure the documents have not been altered. The legal documents contain a cryptographic hash to the treasure's location, so the treasure's location is set in stone. If the treasure were to be moved, the location would change which, in turn, would change the hash you see here.

The steward has a set of instructions so clear and simple, even my Aunt Verna could follow them—and she once got lost in a walk-in closet. These instructions are for validating the lucky duck who finds my treasure. The grand finale of this game involves matching a digital fingerprint of the hiding spot to one tucked away in the legal documents. **The steward has no knowledge of the treasure's location. No one knows where the treasure is but me.**

And because no treasure in the 21st century would be complete without a nod to the digital age, I slipped in half of a key to a cryptocurrency wallet. It's a nod to transparency—the balance and entire transaction history of the wallet are on display for all to see, accessible through its public address:

The other half of the Bitcoin wallet's private key is safeguarded by the steward. Each half is completely worthless on its own. You'll see the balance grow as book sales increase.

When some intrepid soul finds my treasure, they've got a thirty-day countdown to contact the steward. Miss that window and they'll lose out on the Bitcoin, the legal rights to the treasure, and probably a decent night's sleep fretting about it. So don't delay, dear finder!



The public address of the Bitcoin wallet. You'll see the balance grow as book sales increase. The lucky finder gets the balance.

When this treasure is found, the steward will issue a public statement. If you are the bashful type, fear not—the option for anonymity is available.

And lastly, we arrive at a juncture in our tale that's as inevitable as death, taxes, and the disappearance of socks in the laundry: the obligatory legal statement. Yes, the world demands we wrap our dreams in bubble wrap and caution tape.

During 2023, I intentionally abandoned certain property at an

undisclosed location in the western United States (the “Location”). If you decide to search for the abandoned property, you do so at your own risk. Please use caution and discretion and obey all local laws at all times. While the Location could be legally accessed at the time of abandonment, participants are solely responsible for determining current access rights and obtaining any required permits or permissions. Land status and access rights may change over time.

ELIGIBILITY AND PARTICIPATION

Participants must be 18 years or older to participate. Any participation by persons under 18 is strictly prohibited. By choosing to participate in this search, you agree to indemnify and hold me harmless from any and all claims, injuries, damages, losses, or suits, including attorney fees, arising out of or in connection with the treasure hunt.

RISKS AND LIABILITY

I am not responsible for any personal injury, loss, or damage of property that may occur during the treasure hunt. I am not liable for any accidents, injuries, or losses that occur during the course of this activity. The western U.S., including rugged mountains, deserts, and wildlife, may involve hazardous conditions (e.g., steep cliffs, extreme weather, wildlife encounters). Participants assume all risks and are

responsible for their safety and preparation.

PROHIBITED ACTIVITIES

The following activities are strictly prohibited:

- Use of heavy equipment
- Use of metal detectors where prohibited by law or regulation
- Operation of drones in restricted airspace or protected areas
- Commercial searching operations or services, including but not limited to guided tours, paid searching services, tour groups, organized expeditions, or any searching activity conducted for commercial gain
- Searching while under the influence of alcohol, drugs, or any substances that could impair judgment or reaction time
- Any reckless, illegal, or dangerous searching behavior, including but not limited to: searching at night, searching without appropriate safety equipment, searching in dangerous weather conditions, or searching without proper preparation for the environment
- Commercial exploitation of the search, including but not

limited to: selling maps, hints, or search-related materials; organizing paid guided searches; creating commercial products or services related to the treasure hunt without express written permission; or creating any form of media content for commercial purposes including social media monetization, documentaries, books, or other commercial media about the search

SEARCH CONDUCT AND ENVIRONMENTAL PROTECTION

Participants must respect the environment and not litter or disturb wildlife while searching. It's important to leave the Location in the same or better condition than you found it. Participants must comply with all applicable laws and regulations, not just local ones. It's crucial to respect the rights of others and avoid trespassing on private property or violating any other laws during your search.

EMERGENCY SERVICES AND COSTS

Participants are solely responsible for any costs associated with emergency response, rescue services, medical treatment, evacuation, or other emergency services that may be required as a result of their participation in the search. This includes, but is not limited to, helicopter rescue, ambulance transport, search and rescue

operations, and medical treatment costs.

MULTIPLE SEARCHERS

Each participant acknowledges that multiple parties may independently search for the abandoned property. The first person to legally obtain physical possession of the abandoned property will be considered the finder. Any disputes between searching parties are solely between those parties; I expressly disclaim any liability for inter-party conflicts, disputes, or injuries.

JURISDICTION AND LEGAL COMPLIANCE

This treasure hunt and all related disputes are governed by the laws of the State of Wyoming, without regard to its conflict of laws principles. You irrevocably agree that any legal action or proceeding arising out of or relating to this treasure hunt must be brought exclusively in the federal or state courts located in Wyoming, and you waive any objection to the jurisdiction or venue of such courts, including any claim based on inconvenience or forum non conveniens. This treasure hunt is void where prohibited by law.

INTERNATIONAL PARTICIPANTS

This treasure hunt originates in the United States. International

participants acknowledge that their participation may be subject to additional laws and regulations in their home countries. Participants are solely responsible for compliance with all applicable laws, including but not limited to customs, import/export, currency transfer, and tax regulations in any relevant jurisdiction.

Good luck. ✂

For current safety guidelines and the latest information about the treasure hunt, please visit <https://treasure.quest>. You can also share your thoughts about this book on Amazon, Goodreads, or your preferred reading platform.